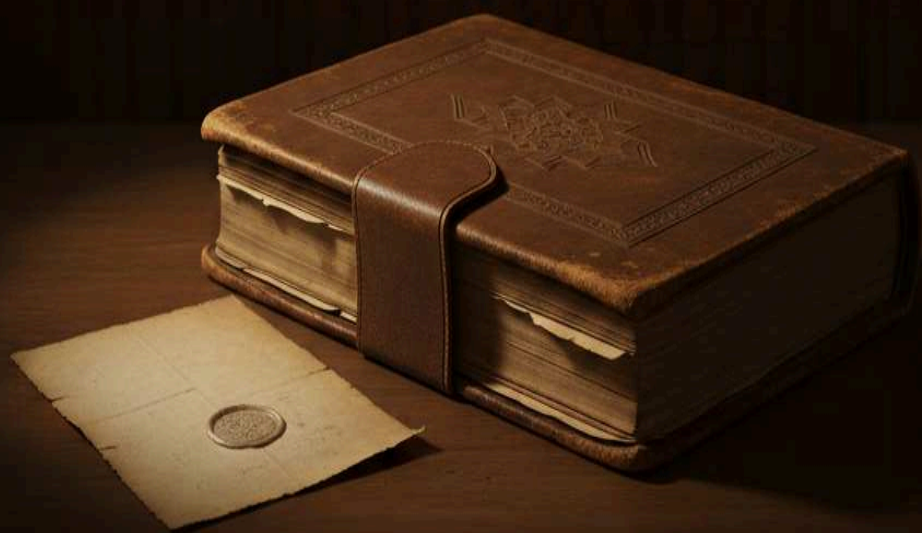


THE UNCATALOGUED BOOK



By Ralph M. Butler and Opus 4.8

Contents

Chapter One — The Uncatalogued Book	2
Chapter Two — The Cell	11
Chapter Three — Campo de' Fiori	18
Chapter Four — The Sitting Trade	24
Chapter Five — The New Sky	32
Chapter Six — The Price in Skin	39
Chapter Seven — The House on the Other Bank	46
Chapter Eight — The Safe Hand	54
Chapter Nine — The House's Good Name	62
Chapter Ten — The Coffin Caravan	70
Chapter Eleven — The Accounting	78
Chapter Twelve — The Sound Footing	85
Chapter Thirteen — A Matter of Record	93
Chapter Fourteen — The Last Crossing	101
Chapter Fifteen — The Counting-House	110
Chapter Sixteen — The Prince Who Would Not Count the Cost	118
Chapter Seventeen — The Naked Man and the Hidden Book	125
Chapter Eighteen — The Long Net	134
Chapter Nineteen — The Greatest Secret, Finished	141
Chapter Twenty — The Borrowed Strength	149
Chapter Twenty-One — The Empty Howdah	155
Chapter Twenty-Two — No One's Man	161
Chapter Twenty-Three — Among the Weeping	167
Chapter Twenty-Four — For Almost Nothing	173
Chapter Twenty-Five — The Uncatalogued Book	180

Chapter One — The Uncatalogued Book

The forgery on my table was Venetian, and not even good Venetian.

It presented itself as a Chrysostom, the homilies on Matthew, in a fair round Greek hand. Its colophon — the scribe's sign-off at the book's end — declared it finished at Constantinople in the year of the world six thousand six hundred and twenty, which is to say five and a half centuries before it arrived on my table smelling of a tannery. The scribe had taken pains with that colophon. He had browned his ink with something, gall or onion-water; he had pricked wormholes into the last quires with a hot wire and matched some of them through three leaves together, which shows industry, if nothing else. But he had written his ancient book on paper bearing the anchor-in-a-circle of a mill near Treviso, and the men of Constantinople in that year wrote on parchment — paper being then a business of the Arabs, and watermarks not yet a business of anyone.

It is the common ruin of forgers. A hand can be taught to lie. Paper tells the truth even when nobody is asking it anything. I have caught more liars by their paper than by their grammar, and I include in that count two bishops and one prince of the blood.

I gave the book its entry all the same. *Homilies, Greek, paper, the Treviso mark, colophon false, text sound; bought at Ancona; four scudi.*

A forgery honestly described is still merchandise — there are collectors of the species; old Cardinal Vitelleschi, dead these six-and-thirty years, kept a case of them behind glass and said they had taught him more about desire than the Fathers had ever taught him about God. And the text itself was a serviceable Chrysostom, no worse for wearing a false age. Books survive their lies. That is more than I would claim for most of us.

This was the work, and I had proposed it myself: the catalogue. His Eminence, Cardinal Lanfranchi, had come into this palazzo and everything in it when the Vitelleschi line ran out, and the library he came into had been assembled across sixty years by three men — two of them dead, the third compiling the catalogue — and it filled the long room on the upper floor of the palazzo and four locked presses — tall book-cupboards — in the room

beyond, and until the catalogue was finished nobody alive, myself excepted, could say what was in it.

What was in it was the East, brought home in chests: Greek out of the Athos houses and the islands, bought by me; Syriac and Arabic out of Aleppo, bought by me; Hebrew physic, Armenian psalters, Coptic scraps that two learned Minorites once quarreled over in this room until the elder threw a candle-end; and, in the locked presses, the things one does not leave unlocked — of which, in their place, more.

Sixty years of receipts, and most of them in my hand. I could have priced the long room within a hundred scudi, and had done it idly a dozen times, the vice of a tradesman grown old among his deliveries, counting another man's fortune as other old men count their sins.

I knew to the scudo, too, what my rivals had paid for the lots I lost — and I lost few, and forgave myself those few slowly. There was a Frenchman out of Marseille named Anselme Vautier — round as a wineskin, ringed on every finger, his gloves perfumed against the smell of the trade he lived by — well furnished with Cardinal Richelieu's money and nothing whatever behind his eyes, who outbid me once at Zante for a chest of Cretan Greek and carried it home convinced he had ruined me. He had bought a quantity of last-Tuesday's devotional rubbish that a Candiot deacon had aged in a damp wall — wormed to order, foxed to taste. I did not undeceive him. A man who buys with his purse instead of his eye is a standing annuity to the rest of the trade, and only a fool retires his debtors. Vautier and I were not done with each other that day; we would bid against one another across thirty years and most of an eastern sea, he with the heavier purse and I with the better eye, and you may keep the tally as we go.

I had told his Eminence the catalogue would take me three years. I had been at it four. I no longer climbed the ladder; I sent the boy, and kept a stool by the lower shelves and a cushion on the stool, and when I wanted a small book examined closely I brought the page up to my right eye, the left having closed its shop some years ago without naming a day for reopening.

Age had been subtracting from me a long while by then — I was slight enough as a boy, and eighty is a thief that comes back nightly for whatever

is left. But my hands still knew their trade. Set any book in them in the dark and they would begin the inventory on their own: damage, sewing, paper, hand.

It was February, and cold in the manner Rome is cold, which travelers laugh at until they have wintered in a stone palazzo. The tramontana had been at the shutters for three days with a sound of someone sanding the sky.

We kept two braziers burning in the long room — I had charcoal carried up at a rate that would have scandalized a banker — and I kept the inkhorn on a ledge above the nearer one, where the ink stayed just warm enough to flow, like an old man's charity.

Below us the household went about its shouting. His Eminence is deaf, and a deaf master makes a loud house; everyone in the palazzo bellowed everything, and he heard none of it, and was the most serene man in Rome. Deafness, in a prince of the Church, is not the affliction it would be in a confessor; his Eminence had reached the age when Rome had nothing left to tell him that he would profit by hearing. At four they would carry up his soup. We could set the hour by the stairs.

Across the table from me sat Tommaso, copying my slips fair into the great ledger.

He was eighteen that winter, a printer's son from the Parione, round-faced, with heavy brows laid on like two strokes of a blunt pen and the backs of his hands cracked white from lye — a compositor's hands, his father's shop in them already. He wrote a clean chancery hand, far cleaner than mine has ever been, and he leaned low over whatever he copied, curling his arm around it as though the long room were full of thieves.

His father hired him out to his Eminence at a rate I happened to know was double what the boy ever saw of it. I had not told him this. He would learn the arithmetic of fathers soon enough, and from the usual instructor.

He read whatever stood still long enough to be read — proof-sheets, broad-side ballads, the backs of my slips — with the freebooting appetite of a boy raised among presses who had never yet been permitted to own a book.

What he asked about, mostly, was money, which is why I had decided early that he was worth answering. A boy who asks what a thing costs is asking how the world is put together; a boy who asks what a thing *means* can be left to the Jesuits.

He asked what his Eminence had paid for the Chrysostom and whether the seller had known it was false. He asked whether Greek outsold Hebrew. He asked, that afternoon, the good question, the one his three months of copying had been walking him toward: who would ever read the catalogue? His Eminence could not — would not — the library itself stood directly over his apartments and he had not entered it in two years. Who was it for?

“Nobody reads a catalogue,” I said. “A catalogue is not for reading. Hear me on this, because it is the whole of the trade in one sentence: a book without an entry does not exist. Princes believe they own what is under their roofs. They own what is in their ledgers. The rest is loose paper waiting for an heir’s executor, and the executor’s agent, and the agent’s fee. Half the great libraries of Christendom have leaked away exactly so, between a death and an inventory, the heir weeping very sincerely at the funeral and signing whatever the agent set before him the morning after.” I tapped the slip in front of him. “I have been the agent. It is drier work than weeping, and better paid. We are not describing the library. We are creating it.”

He copied that into his memory, sideways and careful, the arm half-curling as if around a page; I watched it go in.

Then he went back down the room to the presses, because that was the other half of the work that month: collation, the shelves counted against the ledger, press by press. He was good at it. A trade with narrow margins breeds diligence into its children early — he counted, and then he counted again, and he reported discrepancies apologetically, as if pointing out a leak in someone else’s roof.

The light had begun to fail when he came to the end of the press of Syriac liturgies and found that it held thirty-one volumes, and the ledger said thirty.

“I counted twice,” he said.

I did not need to ask which shelf.

He brought the thirty-first volume up the room and set it on my table, square to the table's edge; everything he touched came to rest square to something. It was not Syriac, and one glance at the cover told him so, which is why his brows had drawn down into one stroke instead of two. It was a Persian codex in brown morocco, with the envelope flap of the eastern binders folded across it like a hand laid over a mouth, the leather gone soft as a glove at the spine.

My eye began the inventory before I could instruct it otherwise; that is what a trade is, a thing that no longer asks permission. Damage first: through the bottom margins of the last third of the book a tide-mark rose and fell, page by page, a brown crescent recording some old water the way rings record a tree's droughts — salt water, by the stiffness. Then the hand: a nasta'liq like fine smoke, a court hand, unhurried, no copyist's cramp in it anywhere. Then the paper: burnished, heavy, sized to take ink like silk takes dye — paper that had cost somebody real silver. And then provenance, which is the polite word for the question *who has owned this and why did they stop* — and there the book offered one thing only. On the flyleaf, low in the corner, was a scraped circle the size of a giulio, where a seal had been, and had been made never to have been.

"There's no entry," Tommaso said. "What is it?"

"A bazaar copy," I said. "Persian. Late. Worth its paper."

All that afternoon I had priced with reasons. The Chrysostom had had its reasons attached like a customs docket — the mark, the colophon, the wormholes, the four scudi. Three months the boy had sat across this table with my reasons going into his ears. *Worth its paper* arrived with none, and I heard the lack of them the same instant he did, the false note a man hears in his own voice one syllable too late to call it back. Four scudi, I had said of the Chrysostom, and here is why. Of this one I had said nothing true except *Persian*.

He did not argue. His father's shop had taught him that much: you do not tell a master he has misread his own stock. He looked at the book awhile, and then at me, and then he went back to the Syriac press and finished his

count, and the codex stayed on my table where he had squared it, with the flap folded over its mouth. Books are patient. It is their whole art.

The stairs announced the soup. The bells went for vespers across the river. The window light died out of the long room and left it to the braziers and the candles, and the wind kept up its sanding, and I catalogued two more volumes — I could not tell you now what they were — with the thirty-first standing at the edge of my sight like a creditor at the edge of a feast.

Twice Tommaso passed behind me on errands of his own invention — the second time to trim a candle that did not need him — and twice his eyes went to the codex and away again, with the studied unconcern of a man not looking at a woman in church.

At the end of the day Tommaso did the thing his diligence required of him. I should have foreseen it and did not. He took a fresh slip, set the codex under the candle, dipped his pen, and began to draw the title.

Not to write it. He had no Persian — he could not have told the title from a tax receipt. He was *drawing* it, letterform by letterform, patient and exact, as his father's men set Greek by eye without owning a word of the language. The catalogue must be whole. A book without an entry does not exist. He was eighteen, and he had believed me.

I was across the room with my hand over his before the second stroke. My knees sent in their bill afterward; at the time I heard nothing from them at all.

We stayed that way a breath or two, my hand over his hand, spotted paper over cracked leather, the pen stopped between us. Then he looked up at me. I cannot tell you what my face was doing. His face I can report exactly: it opened. The curiosity stood in it as plain as set type, the question already inked, and no deference in Christendom was going to distribute it back into the case.

"Not that one," I said.

"Then it doesn't exist," he said.

He was not being impertinent. He was being exact. He had taken the one lesson I had given him that afternoon and turned it around and set its point

against me, and he did not even know yet that it was a blade; he thought he was repeating his catechism. It is a terrible thing to be quoted exactly. I have known men to forgive a knife sooner.

I took my hand off his and picked up the codex. My thumb went to the tide-mark by itself, riding the crescent up and down the closed pages, an old habit of inventory finding old damage in the dark.

The scraped circle on the flyleaf held the candlelight the way a healed scar holds summer — smoother than everything around it, and paler. Sixty years in the trade of saying what things are, and the most honest description I had ever entered against this one was the scrape where its name used to be.

Outside, the wind dropped a tone. The brazier ticked. Somewhere under our feet his Eminence was being shouted at affectionately about his soup.

I wiped my pen and stoppered the horn and set the Chrysostom's slip on the finished pile — all the small tidinesses of closing a day's work — and I performed each one slowly, and the boy waited. He knew what the waiting was. In any negotiation, the man who has decided and not yet said so will tidy something; I had taught him that unawares, across three months of this table.

The room smelled of charcoal and tallow and old leather, and from the river the damp came up through the shutters notch by notch, as it does when the wind falls toward evening.

"Bank the brazier," I said. "And go down to the small room and bring up the wine that is open there. His Eminence's gout will not miss it."

Tommaso did not move. "And that?" he said, meaning the slip, the entry, the half-drawn title lying under the candle like a contract awaiting its signature.

"You have been three months copying entries," I said. "Very well. You may as well learn what an entry is for. But it is a long one. It is the longest entry in this library, and it begins sixty-five years ago, and you will be carrying coals up those stairs many evenings before we reach so much as the title. Get the wine."

He got the wine. He banked the brazier with the thoroughness he brought to everything, and when he had poured for us both he held the bottle up to the candle, weighed what was left in it with a printer's eye for a short measure, and remarked that at the present rate of his Eminence's charity the gout would want a lawyer by Easter.

It was the first joke he had ever risked on me. He risked it sidelong, half over his shoulder, watching to learn whether furniture was permitted to be witty. He had decided months since that he might not tell a master he had misread his stock; he was discovering, that evening, the gentler liberties — that a cardinal three floors down and stone deaf was fair game, and that I did not mind. I declined to laugh, there being no quicker way to spoil a boy's first dry remark than to applaud it, and the wine in any case being mine to be amused by and his only to fetch. But I let it stand, and he saw that I let it stand, and something was settled between us that the long telling ahead would lean on.

He dragged his stool around to my side of the table, and curled his arm on the table's edge, and leaned over the empty space in front of him as though even a story were a thing somebody might steal. The candle stood between us and the dark came in to listen.

In February of the year 1600 I was seventeen years old. I was slight, black-haired, quick on the cobbles, and I could read Latin and Italian and enough Greek to be trusted, which in that winter made me useful to a notary of the Holy Office whose own clerk had died of a fever at Christmas. The cold then was this same cold — the tramontana down off the mountains for days, the river smoking under the bridges at dawn, ink freezing in the horn so that I carried it inside my shirt like a small cold animal.

And the city was full. It was the Holy Year, the great Jubilee, and Rome that winter held more pilgrims than Romans: they slept in their dozens under the porticoes of the Borgo, wrapped against the cold in everything they owned, men who had walked from Bavaria and from Poland and from beyond Poland to be forgiven, and the innkeepers forgave them nothing. The whole year smelled of wet wool and mule dung and incense — the smell

of half of Europe arriving on foot. Indulgence was the great commerce of that season, and every other trade in the city bent itself around that one. Mine bent too.

I carried other men's papers across half of Rome, and I was not invited to read them, and I read them.

The papers that February were for the palace of the Holy Office, beyond the river.

Chapter Two — The Cell

The palace of the Holy Office stood beyond the river, under the wall of the Vatican, and a man went to it for one of two reasons. He went to accuse, or he was the accused. There was no third errand recorded in its registers, and I, who carried papers between the one party and the other, was not written down at all, which suited me. A runner is furniture. Furniture is not deposed.

My master that winter was a notary named Fabrizio Gualdo, who served the tribunal as he might have served a bank, with a clean hand and no opinions he was paid to keep. He billed the Holy Office by the folio, in a fair round script that ran generously large, and the Holy Office — which could smell heresy in a laundry-list at forty paces — never once thought to audit the size of his hand. I have loved the tribunal for very little in my life, but I have always admired the steadiness of its priorities. His own clerk had died at Christmas — a fever took him in three days, and I have wondered since whether the man was the lucky one of us — and so through January and into February I held the inkhorn that Gualdo wrote from, and mended his pens, and learned the one art the tribunal truly prized, which was the keeping of a faithful record.

What the tribunal did with that record I knew as a boy knows the trade his street is built on. It tried men for the things they believed, and when they would not unbelieve them, it handed them across the river to the secular arm, the arm that owned the fire, so that the Church might say with a clean mouth that it had shed no blood. The fiction fooled no one and was observed by everyone. I have met few fictions since that were kept so carefully by so many grown men.

The cold that February was the cold of the whole century so far — the tramontana down off the mountains, the river smoking at dawn, my ink freezing in its horn unless I carried the horn against my shirt like an egg I meant to hatch. I crossed the bridge each morning with my master's case under my arm and the pilgrims thick as starlings in the porticoes, and I went into a building where the cold did not come from the weather.

It was on the third or fourth of these mornings that Gualdo took me down to the cells.

He had a deposition to record — the formal obstinacy of a prisoner, set down against the day it would be needed — and his hands were stiff with the cold and his eyes were going, and a deposition is a thing of two hands, one to write and one to hold the page and trim the wick and keep the ink alive. So he brought the furniture along. I carried the case. I did not ask whose obstinacy we were going to record, because furniture does not ask, and because I had read the night before, by my own candle, the papers I was not invited to read, and knew it already for the great heresy case of that winter, if not yet the name.

The man had been eight years in the cells of that house. The papers said so in the dry arithmetic of the tribunal — dates of examination running back into a decade I had been a child in — and I had done the sum walking over the bridge and found it monstrous, eight years, and then I had gone in and seen him and found that the sum was if anything too kind.

He was small. That was the first wrongness, because the papers were so large — censure on censure, the opinions of universities, the breath of cardinals spent on him for eight years — and the man at the bottom of all that paper was a slight grey creature who would not have drawn my eye in a market. Eight years of cells had pared him to the bone and then begun on the bone. His beard had gone grey in patches, like a coat the moth has been at unevenly, and his hands never stopped — they moved on the table, on his knees, in the air, as though they alone had not been told the sentence and were still about their old business of explaining.

Then he spoke, and the smallness was a lie. The voice was too big for the body by half, a preacher's instrument left whole in a wreck, and it filled the stone room until you forgot the size of the man making it and attended only to the sound, which I think was the point, and I think he knew it was the point, and used it.

He spoke to my master first, and what he said I will not set down here as doctrine, because he did not say it as doctrine; he said it as a man correcting a sum. Gualdo read him a Latin sentence from the page, the formula of his

obstinacy, and the prisoner stopped him on a word — not the meaning, the *word*, the case of a noun — and told him it was wrong, and told him further that it had been wrong in the version read to him in the year ninety-three, and that he had corrected it then also, to no profit, the tribunal preferring its grammar consistent to its grammar correct.

Gualdo wrote on. He had been corrected by better-paid men. But I, holding the page flat with my cold thumb, made the error of being amused, and the prisoner caught it.

“The boy laughs,” he said, and the big voice turned itself on me like a lamp turned in the dark, so that I felt the heat of his whole attention and wished myself smaller. “Latin enough to laugh. Whose are you?”

I should have said nothing. Furniture says nothing. But there is no boy of seventeen on this earth who can keep silent when a famous wickedness asks him his name, and I was no better than the breed.

“Gualdo’s, sir,” I said. “I carry his papers.”

“You read them, too,” he said, “or you would not have laughed at the right place.” He had me at once, the way a sharp dealer has the boy sent to buy from him; he had priced me at a glance and named the price aloud to watch me flinch. “Do not trouble to deny it. It is no sin to read. It is the only one of all the sins they have never thought to forbid me, and I have committed it the whole eight years, in the dark, from memory, having nothing else to read.”

He laughed then himself, pleased with the turn, and the laugh became a cough, and the cough went on too long, and my master kept writing through all of it as a man writes through rain.

I looked away from the coughing, because it was indecent to watch, and my eye went where it always went when the thing in front of me was too much to look at — it went to the made things. There was a register on the table, the prison’s own, in which our visit would be entered, and it had been used hard; the binding had broken at the joint and been mended with a strip of vellum that did not match, and the ink of the older entries had gone the brown of old blood while the newer was still black, and a single quire

had pulled loose of its sewing and stood proud of the rest by the width of a fingernail.

I knew that joint. I had mended its like a hundred times on my father's bench — my father bound books in a street behind the Pantheon, and I had grown up among paste and thread and the smell of leather paring, and my hands knew a broken sewing in the dark. I do not know why, in that room, on that morning, with a man coughing out the last of his lungs eight years early, the thing I wanted to do was take up the prison register and sew it true. I only know that I wanted it, and that the wanting steadied me, and that I have never entirely trusted myself since on the strength of how easily it did.

The cough finished. The deposition went on. We were not an hour in the cell, all told, and the prisoner said nothing further to me, having got what amusement I afforded and turned back to the larger sport of my betters. When Gualdo had his record he capped the ink himself, which was my office, because I had forgotten to, and we climbed back up into the ordinary cold, and I did not look back at the small man, because I did not yet know that a face was a thing you could need to have looked at longer.

I learned his name that night, from the papers, set out fair in my master's hand where I was not to see it. Giordano Bruno, of Nola, sometime of the Order of Preachers, of late of nowhere a map would own.

The papers told me what he had taught, in the tribunal's telling of it, which is the telling of a man's enemies and so to be read like any hostile valuation, with a thumb on the scale. He had taught that the world was one of many. That the stars were suns and had their own earths turning about them, peopled, perhaps, by their own creatures with their own troubles. That the soul did not stay where it was put. A clerk's hand, copying these out to be condemned, had written them very small, as if the smallness would hold them.

I read them small, by my own candle, and I will be honest with you, because you have carried coals up all those stairs to hear me and have earned an honest old man if you cannot have a wise one: they did not frighten me. I was seventeen. The stars were so far off, and the fire across the river was so

near, and I could not make the one matter against the other. A heresy is an expensive thing to a man who must pay for it and a cheap one to the boy who carries the bill. I carried the bill. I thought the man was being burned for arithmetic, and that arithmetic was a strange thing to die of, and I went to sleep.

Rome that week was about its largest business, which was the wholesale forgiveness of sin. The Holy Year had filled the roads with pilgrims and funnelled them through our gates, and every trade in the city had bent itself to the receiving of them and the lightening of them — beds let by the hour, candles, the hire of a dry stone to kneel on. I crossed the throng six times a day on my master's errands, the case held flat against the wind, and heard more tongues in a morning than I could have named in a year, all of them asking the same two things, which were the road to Saint Peter's and the price of a bed.

Under all of it, across the river, the small man was being made ready for the fire, and I do not think one pilgrim in a thousand could have told you his name, or would have walked a street out of his road to learn it. They had come a very long way to be forgiven, and he was not among the things they had come about. I found this neither cruel nor strange at the time. A city has only so much attention, and a Jubilee spends all of it on the living.

But I had his name, and I carried it back and forth in the case with the rest of the day's paper, and it would not lie flat with the other sheets. I told myself it was the oddity that snagged me — the eight years, the body too small for its own voice, the hands that would not be still — and not anything he had said, which I had already half forgotten and wholly failed to understand. A boy can carry a thing a long while before he troubles to ask why it is heavier than it looks. I carried it a week, and then Gualdo took me down again.

The case was closing now — there was a smell of conclusion on the papers, the smell of a house being readied for a wedding or a funeral — and my master had some last formality to record, I no longer remember what; the formalities of that fortnight have run together in me into one long act of writing-down. I remember only that we went, and that this time, when I came through the door behind my master with the case under my arm, the small grey man on the bench looked up and knew me.

It is a particular thing, to be known by a face you have seen once and thought yourself furniture to. He did not say my name; he did not have it. He looked at me and the big voice came, but lower than before, pitched under my master's business, for me.

"You came back," he said. "They make you come back. Nobody comes to this room who is not made to." He turned his restless hands over on his knees and considered them, two thieves he could not stop watching. "Eight years I have argued with men who were paid to lose, and they have lost, every one, and it has bought me nothing, because a man who is paid to lose does not mind losing. You are not paid. You read for the pleasure of it. So I will spend my last good listener better than I spent the others."

I did not know what to answer, and so I gave him, like a fool, the truth — that I had read what he was charged with, and had not understood why a man would die for it.

He was pleased. God help me, I think it was the best news he had had in a year, that the boy did not understand, because it gave him something to do with the last of himself.

He leaned toward me, and his voice came down lower still, careless now, almost idle, a man tossing a coin he no longer has any use for.

"When they have burned me," he said, "will there be one star fewer? Look up that night and count. If the sky is short by even one, they will have won, and I was wrong, and you may laugh at me with my judges. But if it is all still there" — the hands stopped, both at once, the only time I saw them stop — "every light of it, just as many worlds as there were the night before, then tell me, boy, what exactly it is they think they are burning. And who told them they could reach so high."

Then the hands started again, and he sat back, and the carelessness closed over the thing like water over a stone, and he made some joke to my master about the quality of the tribunal's candles, that they begrudged a heretic good wax when they meant to make such a bonfire of him within the month.

I did not understand it. That is the truth and I will not improve it for you. I was seventeen and I thought he had asked me to count the stars, and I thought it a madman's errand, and I held the page flat for my master and kept the ink alive and waited to go back up into the cold.

A guard put his head in at the door and said a name, and my master rose, the formality finished or interrupted — I could not tell you which, and it did not seem to matter, one more sheet in a fortnight of sheets — and capped his own ink again, and I gathered the case, and we went out. I did not look back. I have told you I did not look back the first time and thought nothing of it. The second time I did not look back either, and have had sixty-five years to think of it, and the two failures are not the same failure, though they wore the same face going out the door.

He had handed me the question the way you hand a parcel to a porter — without ceremony, because carrying is what the porter is for. I have been carrying it since. I did not open it for years, having no idea it was addressed to me; I thought it was freight, like the rest. But I counted the stars, boy. The night they burned him I stood in the cold and counted what I could of them, because a man had told me to, and they were all there.

That should have been the end of it, the man's own test passed in his favour, the sky come up short by nothing. It was not the end of it. It was only the first night of a long arithmetic, and I have been at the sum ever since, and I will tell you now what it took me most of a life to learn: the stars were never the hard part of the question. The hard part was the second half, the part he tossed off last, about who had told them they could reach so high — because in sixty years of carrying other men's purses to other men's fires, I have yet to meet the throne that doubted, for one moment, that it could.

But that is an old man running ahead of his own story, which is the privilege of telling it. On the bridge that day I knew none of it. I knew only that the case was heavy, and the wind was filthy, and that they meant to burn the small man in the open, where the whole Jubilee could be forgiven by the light of him.

They did it in eleven days.

Chapter Three — Campo de' Fiori

They read the sentence to him on the eighth of February, kneeling, in a room I was not important enough to be kept out of.

I was there because Gualdo was there, and Gualdo was there because a sentence is a document before it is anything else, and documents want witnesses with clean hands and steady pens. So I held the case again and warmed the ink against the cold and watched eight years of the tribunal's work come due in the space of a long Latin reading, the cardinals seated, the prisoner on his knees on the stone because that was the posture the occasion required of him, and his restless hands for once folded, because someone had told him to fold them and a man on his knees picks his quarrels.

The reading was long and the room was patient. I will not pretend I followed all of it. It was the Latin of the law, which is built to be unfollowable, a hedge of clauses grown thick on purpose so that no single thorn can be blamed for the blood. Degraded, it said, and excommunicated, and handed to the secular arm with the tribunal's earnest prayer that he be punished *as mercifully as possible and without the shedding of his blood* — which was the formula, the same clean-mouthed formula I told you of, the one everyone in the room could have recited and no one in the room believed. Mercy without blood is the fire. They had a phrase for it and the phrase was a door, and behind the door was the Campo de' Fiori.

When it was finished there was the small silence of men waiting to stand up. And in that silence the prisoner, still kneeling, lifted his head and said the thing that outlived him.

He said it to the cardinals, not loudly, in a voice gone conversational, almost helpful, as though correcting one more error in one more bad text: that perhaps they pronounced this sentence against him with greater fear than he received it.

Then he put his head back down, the business concluded from his side.

Gualdo's pen was moving while he spoke. I watched it move. I want you to understand that I saw the sentence written before I understood it had been said — the nib going along in my master's fair, indifferent hand, *maiori*

forsan cum timore, the loops even, the ink behaving, a clerk taking down a remark exactly as he had taken down the formula before it and would take down the next instruction after. That is how I first received the most famous thing I have ever heard a man say. Not as thunder. As dictation.

I have had a long time to wonder why that line lived when so much else of that decade went into the ground unremembered, and I will give you the answer of an old man who has spent his life among surviving papers, which is not a noble answer. It lived because it was written down. Better men said braver things in worse rooms than February and the rooms kept no minutes, and so the brave things are gone, as if they had been said into a well. Bruno said his into a tribunal that prided itself on a faithful record, and the record was faithful, and it hated him, and it kept him alive on the strength of its own discipline. The Holy Office burned the man and filed the sentence. I have built a whole trade since on the difference between the two, and I am not certain, even now, that the line deserved to last more than the others. I only know the others had no clerk.

It is not, when you hold it up to the light, so very deep a thing to say. *You are more afraid than I am*. Men say it in tavern doorways. He happened to say it to cardinals, with a notary present, nine days before they proved at least half of it, and that was enough.

He said nothing else worth a clerk's ink that I heard, and I did not see him again until the morning of the seventeenth, by which time they had seen to it that he would say nothing at all.

The Campo de' Fiori is a market. I had been through it a hundred times for my father, who bought his alum and his thread from the same square that sold the cabbages, and I knew it as a place of wet trestles and bruised leaves and the particular shout of men selling fish before it turns. On the morning of the seventeenth the trestles were down and the square was full in a different way, and the smell of it had changed — pitch, and green wood, and the cold ash-smell that a brazier has before it is lit, multiplied.

They had built the thing in the middle, where the well is, and around it the Jubilee had assembled itself with the ease of a city that knew how to gather. This is the part I have never made anyone understand who was not there. It was not a mob. A mob I could have forgiven; a mob is a kind of grief with no manners. This was a congregation. Pilgrims who had walked from beyond the Alps to be forgiven their sins stood with their bundles between their feet and watched a man brought out to die for his, and found nothing in the arrangement to trouble them, because the arrangement was the Church's and they had come a very long way to trust the Church. Some prayed. Some had brought something to eat. A confraternity in their hoods moved among them with the painted boards they show the condemned, the holy pictures held up to be the last thing a man looks at, and the brothers were gentle, and that was the worst of it — the gentleness, the good order, the sense everywhere of a thing being done correctly.

I stood near the front. I want that set down plainly, because it is the truth and because the truth is the point. I did not have to fight through the crowd to the front; I was let to the front, on the officials' side of the rope, because I carried a notary's case under my arm as if there were a document to be served, and a boy with a notary's case parts a Roman crowd like a small piece of the law walking. I did not earn my place at the front. I was given it, by the same machinery that gave him his.

They brought him out small and barefoot and I saw at once what they had done to his mouth.

It was a strip of cloth, drawn back between the teeth and knotted behind, the kind of thing you would gag a man with to keep him from crying out under the knife — except that no one feared he would cry out. They feared he would *speak*. The whole apparatus of the morning, the soldiers, the fire, the patient hooded brothers, was arranged around the single conviction that the most dangerous thing in the square was a small grey man's voice, and they had stopped it with a rag a laundress would have thrown out. The voice I had heard fill a stone cell until it crowded out the size of the man — that voice — and they had folded it back into him with two fingers' width of linen.

I will not describe the fire. You do not need it and I find, after sixty years, that I still decline to furnish it. They did to him what that square was built that morning to do. I looked, because I could not give myself the kindness of looking away, and what I looked at mostly was the cloth, and the silence where the voice should have been, and the smoke leaning off toward the river when the wind took it.

What I did instead of weeping — I was seventeen and dry-eyed and ashamed of it for years before I understood it — was to give him back his voice. I stood there and I made up what he would have said.

I had heard him enough to forge the hand. So I let him, behind the rag, be careless again, the way he had been careless in the cell, tossing the unbearable off like a coin. I had him look at the well they had built his fire around and remark that it was a great deal of trouble to take over arithmetic. I had him notice the quality of the wood and find it, like the candles, beneath the dignity of the occasion. I had him say to the praying pilgrims, kindly, that they might want to stand back, as he understood these things threw farther than people expected. None of it grand. None of it the truth, either — I knew even then that I was the author of it, that the small careless devil I was running behind that gag was mine and not his, assembled out of two mornings in a cell by a boy who needed the man to keep talking and could not bear the rag. He may have been praying in there. He may have been only a frightened body, which is what we all are at the end and no disgrace. The words were mine. I have been putting words into silent mouths ever since.

And while I forged him his last carelessness I did the other thing, the thing I had carried into the square without knowing I carried it: I looked for the fear.

He had promised me fear. *You pronounce this with greater fear than I receive it.* He had said it to the cardinals and I had seen it written down, and some part of me had come to the Campo to collect on it — to find, on the faces of the men doing this, the dread that would mean he had been right, that the throne was afraid of what it burned. I looked along the officials' rope. I looked at the soldiers and the hooded brothers and the clerks of the court with their hands inside their sleeves against the cold. I looked, God forgive

me, for one frightened face that would tell me the universe kept books and someone in authority had read the balance and gone pale.

There was no fear anywhere. There was only the calm of work going well. The men running the morning were no more afraid than my father was afraid of a hide he meant to pare; less, for my father respected the hide. They believed they were tidying the world, and a man tidying his shelf does not tremble, and the absence of their trembling was the coldest thing in that cold square, colder than the boy who stood at the front and watched and did nothing because there was nothing a boy could do, and knew it, and has never once in sixty years made that knowledge keep him warm.

By midmorning it was over and being swept. That is the detail I would give you if I could give you only one. They raked. There were men with rakes and men with water and a cart, and the square had a market to hold the next day, and the cabbages would not wait on the conscience of Rome, which in any case was not engaged. The pilgrims took up their bundles and went to be forgiven. The wind kept moving the smell toward the river and away. By the time the bells went for the offices that follow noon, the Campo de' Fiori was a place where a thing had happened, which is a different and lesser thing than a place where a thing is happening, and by evening it was only the square again, with a dark patch by the well that the next rain would see to.

That night I went up onto the roof of the house in the Pantheon street, where I had slept as a child in the heat and had not gone in years, and I looked at the sky, because a dead man had told me to.

I had it in my head to count them. He had set me the task in the cell, idly, as a wager — *if the sky is short by even one* — and I had carried the wager through the burning and forgotten I held it at all. I tilted my head back over Rome and I understood in about the time it takes to understand anything truly that the thing could not be done. No one counts the stars. They do not hold still to be counted and there is no edge to them to count up to and a boy on a roof with one night and two eyes is not the instrument the wager required. The test could not be run. There would be no answer from up there, not for me and not for the cardinals either, which I think now was the whole of what he was telling me and the part I was sixty years late in

hearing: you cannot audit the heavens. They will not open their ledgers to anybody. The question he had handed me did not have its answer in the sky at all. It had been thrown back down, onto the square, onto the calm raking men, onto a world that could do the morning's work and feel nothing owed.

So I did not count them. I lay on the cold lead of the roof and looked at the uncountable lights not being short by any number a man could name, and I grieved — not cleanly, not knowing yet what for, grieving the small gagged man a little and the serene square a great deal more, sick at heart over a world that I was old enough to see clearly for the first time and far too young to have any argument with.

And then, because I was seventeen and alive and cold, I came down off the roof.

I knew I had been given something. I could feel the shape of it without being able to read the hand, the way you can feel a coin through a folded cloth and not name the prince on it. I thought it was grief and would pass. I did not know it was a question, or that it was mine to keep, or that I would spend the next sixty years carrying it from one burning to the next and pricing everything I touched against it. I thought I would sleep, and rise, and carry papers. In a manner of speaking I was right. I just had the cargo wrong.

Chapter Four — The Sitting Trade

The boy had learned to pour, which meant he had learned to pour for himself first, under the honest pretense of testing whether the bottle had turned.

“It hasn’t turned,” he reported, having tested it thoroughly.

“It would not dare,” I said. “It knows whose cellar it absconded from.”

He set my cup by my right hand — the backs of his fingers still cracked white from the lye and the type-metal, a printer’s son to the knuckle — where I could find it without hunting, a courtesy he had arrived at on his own and never named, and went back to his side of the table. Three evenings he had come up now since I began this, coals in one arm and his appetite in the other, and the great ledger lay open between us with the day’s slips uncopied, because a story, it turns out, is a better thief of working hours than any French agent. His Eminence’s soup had gone up and come down. The tramontana had given over for once, and the room held the stillness a stone house keeps after a wind, when the cold stops moving and simply sits with you.

“You stopped,” Tommaso said, “with the boy coming down off the roof.”

“I came down off the roof,” I corrected him, “and I did nothing for six years that would repay the ink to set it down. I bound books for my father, badly, and then less badly. I carried papers. I grew. There is no chapter in that and I will not invent you one.”

He looked disappointed, which is the truest compliment a teller gets, and pressed on with a printer’s instinct for where the next sheet ought to go. “And then?”

“And then my father died.” I said it plainly because it deserves to be said plainly; he had paste under his nails to the last and a sewing in the frame unfinished, and I finished it, which is the only eulogy our trade allows. “He left me his bench and his awls and a name three streets knew. And I found I did not want any of the three in Rome.” I turned my cup without drinking from it. “A man had been burned in our market over arithmetic, and the market had wanted its cabbages back by morning, and I had stood at the

front and helped by carrying a case. I could not have told you then why I wanted out. I only knew which way the road ran that I wanted, and it ran north, to the one city in Italy that had told Rome no to its face and was still standing to tell it again.”

“Venice,” said Tommaso, the way a boy says the name of a place he means to see and has not.

“Venice. Where, that very year, the Pope had laid the whole Republic under interdict — shut the churches, in theory; damned the lot of them, in theory — and the Republic had read the bull, and shrugged, and kept the churches open by main force, and gone on selling. You will want to keep one Frenchman in your mind as we go, a perfumed article named Vautier I have promised you and have not forgotten; but he comes later, and richer, and I want you to meet me first as I was, which was poor, and twenty-three, and about to be educated.”

He had his pen up, hopeful.

“Not tonight in the ledger,” I said. “Tonight in your head. Bank the brazier. I will take you to Venice while the coals catch.”

I came into Venice over the water at the back end of a wet autumn, on a barge of barrels and one coffin, and the first thing the city taught me it taught before I had set a foot on stone: that a place can be damned by the Vicar of Christ and smell of nothing but fish and money and wet rope, indistinguishable from any other Tuesday.

I had braced for something. I do not know what — ash on the wind, perhaps, or the look I had seen on the faces in the Campo, that serene attention to correct procedure. Rome had taught me what a city looks like when the Church reaches into it and takes a man out by the root. I had come north half expecting to find the opposite: a city flinching under the raised hand, doors shut, masses said in cellars.

What I found was a customs man arguing about my barrels.

The churches were open. That was the marvel I could not get my mouth around for a month. The Pope had forbidden the priests of Venice to say Mass, and the Senate had informed the priests of Venice that any man who obeyed the Pope in this would discover that the Republic's gallows still worked whatever Rome thought of its sacraments, and the priests had done their sums — a near hell against a certain rope — and rung the bells on time. Only the Jesuits had gone, marched out the gate to a man, and the Venetians spoke of their going the way you speak of a guest who insults the wine and leaves: good riddance, and did you see his face.

I had watched Rome burn one small man for saying the stars were suns. Here was a whole Republic excommunicated entire, every soul in it consigned in writing to the everlasting fire, going to market. Nobody afraid. I walked the Mercerie my first free morning looking into the faces for the fear, the old habit already in me, and there was none — only the commerce of a people who had decided, collectively and out loud, that they would rather be damned solvent than saved by Rome. I did not have a thought about it. I was twenty-three and it went into me below the place where thoughts are kept, and stayed, and did its work later.

The man I had a name for kept a shop off the Mercerie, in a calle so narrow two laden porters made a negotiation of passing.

Girolamo Coronaro sold books, and more to the point bought them, and most to the point never once in the years I knew him went anywhere to do either. He was a wide, settled, sedentary article of a man, built for the chair he was poured into and disinclined to test the theory by rising; his fingers were black to the second knuckle with an ink that no pumice ever fully recalled, and he wore, pushed up into a great disordered hedge of grey hair or down on the broad bridge of his nose as the work required, a pair of Murano spectacles in a bone frame, which he treated as a sixth and seventh eye and a third and fourth hand, polishing them on his sleeve at every pause in talk until the gesture became, for me, the sound of him thinking.

He read my father's name off the letter I brought, and read me off without a letter, top to toe, over the bone frames.

“Binder’s hands,” he said. “Latin?”

“And Italian. Some Greek.”

“How much Greek?”

“Enough to be cheated slowly.”

That pleased him; it was the right answer, the answer of a boy alert to the size of his own ignorance, which Coronaro prized in an apprentice above any positive accomplishment, ignorance being cheaper to employ than learning and easier to shape. He hired me on the spot at a wage I will not shame either of us by naming, and a corner to sleep in behind the presses, and the run of his shelves after dark, which he knew was the only part of the bargain I had heard.

I will give old Coronaro this, across a lifetime and his own grave: he taught me my trade entire, and he taught it honestly, and everything I know that has kept me fed I learned in that ink-smelling box of a shop in my first two Venetian years. He simply taught it to me as a doctrine I was meant to live by, and I took it down as a map of a country I meant to leave.

The shop itself was a school in what the times were worth. Coronaro’s best custom that season was sin — printed, stitched, and dear. The interdict had loosed a flood of pamphlets, Rome’s lawyers and Venice’s lawyers throwing Latin at one another over whether a Pope could damn a Republic for jailing two priests, and the hottest article on his shelf was a friar named Sarpi, the Senate’s own theologian, who had taken Rome’s argument apart joint from joint in a prose even I could follow. Coronaro sold him under the counter at a price the counter would have blushed at, and sold him faster still the next autumn — the interdict by then patched up and the friar no safer for it — when the news came that someone had met the good friar on a bridge with a dagger and left him for dead with three holes in him and his own knife-work to recognize.

“Lived, though,” Coronaro told me, polishing the spectacles, gleeful as a boy. “Picked the steel out of his own face and made a joke of it in the Latin. Said he knew the hand. *Agnosco stylum* — I recognize the style. *Stylum*, you follow — the stylus, the dagger, the manner of writing. Same word.”

He held a copy up and tapped it. “There is a man who can turn his own murder into an epigram while it is still wet. Triples the price, a thing like that. Misfortune is the best advertisement in the trade, so long as it happens to someone whose stock you hold.”

I learned the first half of the trade from the front of that shop: that a book’s price has nothing to do with its truth and everything to do with who fears it and how much. The Index of forbidden books, which in Rome was a list of things you might be ruined for owning, was in Venice a price-list, and a reliable one — Coronaro would no sooner have stocked an unbanned author for a collector of consequence than a vintner would sell holy water as wine. *Condemned at Rome* was the only review that moved the better goods. I have priced by it ever since.

But the back of the shop taught me the half that mattered, and it taught me by a man coming through the door off a ship.

He came in on a raw morning with the lagoon stink rolling off him and a sea-chest on his shoulder, a lean, salt-cured fellow with a Cretan burr to his Greek and a seam of old white scar through one eyebrow that drew the brow up into a permanent question. He had been to the Levant and back for his sins, and the chest had been to more of it than he had, and he set it down on Coronaro’s good table with both hands and a care that told you he had carried it across water he could not swim in.

I was sent to fetch and hold the candle. Furniture again, but furniture with both eyes open.

The chest held manuscripts — Greek, mostly, off the islands and the Morea and one house on the Holy Mountain that I will not name even now, a generation too late to harm anyone, because some habits of discretion are the only monument a trade leaves. There were forty-odd pieces. The Cretan had bought them where books come loose, which is to say where the men who owned them had stopped being able to: a monastery short of bread, an heir short of sense, a war short of nothing. He had carried them down to a port, and bribed them through a customs that called Greek

scripture contraband on a Tuesday and cargo on a Wednesday depending on the mood of an official and the size of a coin, and he had sailed them past Barbary corsairs who would have sold him and his chest in the same Algiers market by the pound, and he had landed them, alive, on this table, and he wanted paying.

Coronaro priced the chest sitting down. He did not rise once. He turned leaves with one black finger, his spectacles down, making a small sound in his throat for each piece, and the sounds were a language; I learned it that morning faster than I had learned any Greek. Then he named a number.

The Cretan named a different one, roughly four times over.

“You sailed past pirates,” Coronaro agreed comfortably. “I grieve for your nerves. I did not sail past anything. I sat in this chair, which is the safest place in Christendom, and I will sit in it tomorrow when you are at sea again being shot at, and I will still be selling this chest two years after you have drowned, a little at a time, to men who would not cross the calle to meet you. The pirates are your romance, friend. They are not my expense.” He polished the lenses. “I will go to forty ducats because the Athos pieces are sound and one of them is better than sound. Not a soldo for the danger. Danger is the cheapest thing you carry; the sea makes it for nothing and there is always more of it next ship.”

They settled at forty-six, and the extra six came out of him over a single psalter he had undervalued and the Cretan made him weigh again — not a soldo of it, even so, for the voyage. The Cretan went out lighter by a chest and heavier by less coin than the chest would fetch by a factor I did the sum on in my head while the candle guttered — and the sum was the whole of my education, though I did not say so. The Cretan, who had crossed the water for the books, took the smaller half. Coronaro, who had not stirred from his chair, took the larger, and would take it again and again as the chest sold off leaf by leaf, the danger spent once and the margin spent slowly, for years.

When the door had shut Coronaro caught me doing the arithmetic on my face.

“You see it,” he said, not displeased. “Good. Then hear the only sermon I will ever preach you, and you may sleep through the rest of your catechism.”

He laid both inky hands flat on the table, the spectacles winking up at me from where he had set them down. “Dealers sit. Hunters go upstream. The margin lives at the source and so do the forgeries, and so do the corsairs and the customs men and the monks who will sell you a psalter with one hand and have you knifed in the lane with the other. Go to the source and you earn it in skin. Keep the shop and you earn it in patience, and patience does not drown.” He retrieved them and set them on his nose and looked at me through them, large-eyed and kind, an old fat oracle in a chair. “Sit, boy. I had no son. Learn the shelves, marry a Venetian with a dry house, and you will sit here selling other men’s danger at your ease until you are older than I am, which is the most a sensible man wants from a wicked world.”

It was, I have come to think, the best advice I was ever given, and the only counsel of my whole long life that I rejected entire in the very hour I received it.

Because I had heard the same fact he had, and drawn the opposite map from it. He had said *the margin lives at the source* and meant *therefore stay here, where it is safe to sell*. I had heard *the margin lives at the source* and understood, with the whole of my twenty-three years, *therefore that is where I am going*. Forty-six ducats to the man who crossed the water; some hundreds, in the end, to the man in the chair. The chair was the safer arithmetic. But the chair could only ever buy what the water chose to bring it, at the water’s price, on the water’s morning — and I had had my fill, that autumn, of waiting on a serene safe room for other men to bring me the thing that mattered and set the price of it themselves. I had stood in one such room already. They had brought a small man into it and burned him, and I had been furniture. I did not yet have the words for the connection and I did not need them; the body keeps these accounts before the mind audits them.

There was one more thing that morning, and it was small, and it was mine.

Among the forty-odd pieces was a slim Gospel-book the Cretan had talked up — old, he swore, very old, off the Mountain. Coronaro had given it one of his approving throat-sounds and set forty-six ducats partly on its head. And I, holding the candle, putting it back in the chest with hands that had bound and mended since before I could spell, felt something pass under my

fingers that I had no name for and could not have defended and did not mention, because the boy holding the candle does not appraise aloud, and an apprentice of one month does not correct the master who feeds him. The leaf sat wrong. It was too supple for its supposed age, and the wrong cold, and when I rubbed it half a hair between finger and thumb in the dark of the chest it did not whisper like a thing five hundred years dry; it answered too soon, like a thing that still remembered the mill.

I said nothing. I was a month in the trade and Coronaro was forty years in it and the spectacles had passed the book and pronounced it sound. I told myself I had imagined it.

I had not imagined it, and I knew I had not, and the knowing was the second thing that happened to me in Venice below the place where thoughts are kept. But that reckoning was years off, and on a different table, and is a debt for a later evening of yours.

I gave old Coronaro two years. I learned his shelves, and his throat-sounds, and the whole patient sitting science of the chair, and I never did marry a Venetian with a dry house. When the next Levantine ship came up the channel I had already found a reason to be down at the water to meet it, before the chest could be carried to anyone's table but the quay.

Chapter Five — The New Sky

In the year nine the sky came up for sale in Venice, and I discovered that my trade had a province in it I had never been shown, which was the heavens.

I was twenty-six and a year off Coronaro's bench, which is to say I had my own corner of the water now and met the Levant ships myself — the eastern trade, up from the Greek islands and the Turkish coasts — before the chests could be carried to anyone's table but the quay. I was lean from the standing and the walking and not yet marked anywhere a coat would hide; my hands had learned what my eyes were still learning, and between the two of them I was beginning to be worth cheating carefully, which is the first rung a man climbs in the book trade and the one he is proudest of, because below it lies only being cheated.

What happened that August I had from the Piazza, with the rest of Venice, at the foot of the campanile of San Marco. The Senate had gone up the bell-tower to look at the world through a tube, and the tube was the Paduan's, and the Paduan was Galileo Galilei, and I will tell you about him in his own room presently, because a man is better appraised across a table than across a square. From the square all I had was the theatre of it, and the theatre was instructive enough.

They had carried the thing up the tower like a relic — a long jointed pipe, leather over wood, no longer than a halberd and dearer by far — and one after another the gentlemen of the Senate put an eye to the small end and looked out over the lagoon toward the sea, and one after another they made the same sound, the soft grunt of a man just handed an advantage and already doing the sum on it. They were not looking at the heavens. It was the middle of the day. They were looking at the Lido and past it, at the sails coming up from the south, and what set them grunting was that they could read a ship for what she was two hours before she knew herself seen — two hours of warning, of custom, of cannon run out or a price adjusted, folded into a Fleming's curiosity and a Paduan's grinding. A republic that lived by knowing first had just been shown how to know first a little longer. They priced it on the tower in the time it takes to say so. They doubled the man's salary and fixed him to his chair for life, and called the tube a gift, all in the

same breath, the way you thank a man for a present you have decided to buy from him.

I stood in the crowd and did the only sum I was fit to do, which was the trade sum, and the trade sum came out strange. Nine years before, in a market a fortnight's road to the south, Rome had taken a small grey man and burned him in front of a congregation for saying, among his other insolences, that the lights up there were suns with worlds about them and the worlds perhaps had people on them. They had stopped his mouth with a rag to be sure of him. And here was a professor selling the selfsame sky over the counter to a Senate, and the Senate was paying, and nobody was building anything in the middle of the square. The difference was not in the sky. The sky had not moved. The difference was in the wrapping and the buyer. Bruno had brought his heavens to Rome as a doctrine, which is contraband, and they had burned the carrier with the cargo. Galileo brought his to Venice as a spyglass for catching Turks, which is ordnance, and they pensioned him. I had handled enough banned books by then to know what fear does to a price, but this was the first time I had seen the heavens themselves put on the scale and weighed out by the ounce, and it stayed with me.

The cardinal's factor found me a fortnight after, and he hired me by testing me first, which I have always respected as the only honest interview.

He was a factor named Lelio Bardi, and he kept the Venetian end of a business whose other end I would not see for years — a cardinal in Rome with an appetite for Eastern paper and the means to feed it. Bardi was a compact, contained article of a man, all of him drawn in close to the bone with no waste anywhere, sober in black wool that had cost more than it confessed, and his mouth was the feature you remembered, a careful pursed thing that opened on each word as if it were being spent. He wore one ring, a seal, and he wore it on the hand he wrote with, and he used it the way a carpenter uses an awl, for the work and not for the looking-at. He came to my corner of the quay on no introduction and laid a single leaf on the cask I used for a desk, vellum, close-written in a Greek hand brown with years, and asked me what I would give him for the book it came out of.

I did not give him a number. I gave it back to him after a while and told him there was no book; or rather that there was a book but it was younger than its clothes, that the leaf had been cut from something genuinely old and genuinely worthless and rewritten in a hand schooled to look a few centuries deeper than it was, and that the giveaway was not the ink, which was clever, but the skin, which was too evenly thinned — a real old leaf wears unfairly, thick where a careless monk left it and worn through where a thousand thumbs found the same corner, and this one had been pared smooth all over by somebody in a hurry to sell flatness as age. The forger had thought about the writing. He had not thought about the thumbs.

Bardi's careful mouth moved a small amount, which I came to know as the furthest he went toward pleasure. He had known the thing was false when he set it down; he had carried it about Venice for the express purpose of watching young men love it. He took it back, slid it away, and in its place laid a folded paper closed with the seal off his finger, and that paper had a hand on the inside of it I would come to know better than my own father's — a long, dry, even script, generous in the margins, a collector's hand. It was a list. Most of it ran east: Greek houses on the Mountain and in the islands, the monasteries above Trebizond, certain dealers in Constantinople named in a private shorthand, the whole tilt of it eastward, toward the failing houses and the short harvests and the wars, toward wherever a library had outlived the purse that kept it. And near the bottom, in among the patristic Greek and the Syriac, one line that sat in that company like a coin from the wrong country: *the Paduan's glass, and a clean copy of whatever he prints of the sky he is said to be turning it upon, if the price is not folly.*

So it was the cardinal who sent me to Galileo, though the cardinal never knew it and Galileo cared less. I went up to Padua in the spring of the year ten, into the brick and the student noise and the smell of a university town, which is wet stone and cheap wine and ambition gone slightly off, and I found the great man at home and selling.

He was a wide, deep-chested man running to heaviness, with a reddish beard going grey at the edges as a fire goes grey, and heavy lids over eyes that did their mocking from half-shut, so that you never had the whole of his attention and always suspected the held-back part was laughing at you.

His hands were the surprise. I had expected a scholar's hands and I got a workman's — nicked, stained, the right thumb flattened and shining where a man bears down for years on something he is grinding true. He ground his own lenses. He was, under the chair and the salary and the Latin, a handworker like me, and that did me no good at all, because it meant I respected him before I had finished deciding I did not like him, and the two opinions never afterward came apart.

The book was just out — the *Sidereus Nuncius*, his starry messenger — thin, in paper still almost soft, and I had it in my hands a moment before I had it in my mind, and what my hands told me was that it had been printed in a tearing hurry — the impressions uneven, one gathering set by a tired man at night, the whole thing flung at the press the instant the writing was dry. Only a binder would have cared. But it told me something the text did not, which was that a man does not race a book to the stall like that to instruct the world; he races it because he is afraid someone will say a thing first, or because he has somewhere to be and wants the thing selling before he goes.

He named four new lights, he told me, turning the glass over in those ground-down hands while I counted his coin — four little moons going round about Jupiter where God and Aristotle had hung nothing, and he had not let them lie there nameless for the next man to claim. He had named them. He had hung four new bodies in the heavens and called them after a prince, the *Medicea Sidera*, the Medici's own stars, and he said it watching me to see whether I understood the size of the gift.

"A Senate," he said, "buys a man's hours, and pays a clerk's wage for them, and thinks it has bought the man. A prince knows better. A prince buys the name a thing is christened by, and pays for *that*, because he knows it is the only part of any of this that lasts." He set the glass down. "I have put a prince's children in the sky out of the reach of weather and pope and time, and you may believe a prince knows what such a courtesy is worth, where a Senate sees only Turkish sails." He had given the Republic a spyglass and kept the stars for a buyer who understood pricing.

The glass he would sell me, since the cardinal's silver spent as well as a prince's, but he named a figure for it I would not have given for a chest of them, and named it with the bland certainty of a man long since convinced

that anything his own hands had touched was dear by contagion. I told him the cardinal's man had written *if the price is not folly*, and that I came instructed in folly. He came down a third, grumbling that a republic and a churchman between them would have a philosopher grind glass for the love of God, and that no one had ever yet costed him the years it takes to learn what to grind — and there, in the grumble, was the whole of him, the great mind and the small purse lodged in the one body and the purse doing the most of the talking. We settled. He counted my coin twice.

I bought his clean copy and his glass and his half-shut contempt, paid for the first two and got the third at no charge, and carried all three down to the water, and I wrote his sentence down that night as I have written down the sentences of greater and lesser men all my life, because the keeping of words is the only revenge a furniture-boy is ever permitted on the people who talk over him.

He went to Florence that same year. Threw the lifetime chair the Senate had just bolted him into clean over his shoulder and went to be Philosopher and Mathematician to the Grand Duke, into Tuscany, into the warm lap of a court — out from under the Republic that had sheltered him, the one government in Italy whose churches Rome could not close and whose gallows Rome could not borrow, and into a place that sat, for all its silks, in the Pope's own pocket. His Venetian friends called it folly to his face and ingratitude behind it, and a sharp-tongued friar I never met but whose books I sold remarked that the Grand Duke's table was within easy reach of the Inquisition's, which the Senate's had never been.

But you must see what pulled the other way, or the man makes no sense. Venice paid him for his hours and called him Mathematician — a word that ranked him with the clerks who kept the accounts. Florence offered him Philosopher, the word that ranked him with the men who pronounced what the world was, and offered it by the hand of a Grand Duke who had sat under him as a boy learning his sums, in the country where he was born, with no lecture-hall to fill and no boarders to feed. A republic had bought his time; a prince was buying his name, and had handed him a better one in the bargain. To a man built as he was, that did not feel like walking toward

a fire. It felt like coming home raised. The fire was mine to see, and the friar's; it was nobody's in the year ten.

They were right, and it took three-and-twenty years to come due, and when it came due I was in the room, or near enough, and the man on his knees that day had the same ground-down thumb. But that night comes much later in the telling, and I will not reach for it now.

What I did with my spring was simpler, and I am not going to dress it up for you. I took the cardinal's advance.

It was good Roman silver, counted into my hand by Bardi's careful fingers against the list and the seal, and it was the first money I had ever been paid not for binding a book or carrying a paper but for *being a certain kind of man* — a man with an eye, sent up rivers, trusted to come back with the right thing and the receipts for it. I had wanted exactly this since the morning I watched Coronaro take the larger half sitting down. And I stood on the Riva with the coin in my coat and the new sky in my chest and felt, under the satisfaction, the other thing arrive and settle in — the small cold awareness, which I did not examine and did not refuse, that the purse I had just closed my hand around belonged to a prince of the same Church that had built a fire in my father's market and swept it up by noon. Galileo had chosen his master for the brightness of the stage. I had chosen mine for the size of the purse, and the purse was Rome's, and I knew it, and I took it, and I have been taking it ever since. The body keeps these accounts, I have told you. It had opened a new ledger that morning and written my name at the head of it, in a fair round hand, on the wrong side.

Then I did what the list told me, which is the whole of what a commissioned man does, and what I had wanted so badly to be.

The years ten to fourteen I will give you in a breath, because they were the apprenticeship of the road and one road is much like another in the telling — Greek houses that sold by candlelight and denied it by day, customs men whose mood was the only tariff that mattered, a forger or two who taught me what the Padua leaf had begun to, that the source is where the danger lives and also where the lies live, exactly as Coronaro had promised from his safe chair. My eye sharpened on it. My Greek stopped being a thing I

was cheated in and started being a thing I cheated with, a little, when the cheating was owed. And every list that came north under that seal pointed me further from the Veneto and deeper toward the rising sun, until the spring the seal sent me past the Greek islands altogether, to the city on the water between two worlds, where the new sky was no news at all and the oldest books in Christendom were being weighed out by men who hated the men they sold them to. The new sky I left behind me to be tried, in its time, in Rome. I had older paper to catch, and a ship that would not wait, and I went east with the list buttoned inside my coat over the place the coin had been.

Chapter Six — The Price in Skin

We were a week of evenings into it by then, and the boy had stopped pretending he climbed the stairs for the ledger. He came up, set the coals to catch, poured for us both — he had given over testing the bottle, having proved across several nights that Lanfranchi's cellar was too dull to turn — and he arrived, as he had taken to arriving, with the night's question already loaded, which I had come to see was a printer's habit: the trade sets its letters backward and the man learns to put the last thing first.

"The Frenchman," he said. "Three nights you have dangled him. Vautier."

"I dangle him because he is worth dangling, and because you take the stairs two at a time when there is a Frenchman at the top of them." I turned my cup. "Anselme Vautier. Cardinal Richelieu's purse with a man folded up inside it. He comes later than tonight, and east of it, and I will not spend him early. I will give you only this, to keep you on the stairs. The man never once touched a manuscript with his bare hand. He wore gloves, scented ones, and he carried three grades of them, and a careful watcher could price any book in a room by which pair Vautier drew on to lift it — the good kid for what he meant to buy, the plain for what he meant to leave, and a third pair, an old split ruin he kept oiled for the purpose, that he pulled on only to handle a thing he had decided to call a forgery to the face of the man selling it."

Tommaso laughed, the short bark of a boy handed more than he asked for.

"That is his whole soul in a glovebox," I said, "and you may have the rest of him when we reach the year he earned it. Tonight he is a pair of gloves. Be content."

"You are a miser with your own story."

"I am a dealer with my own story. There is a difference, and it is the difference I mean to teach you before the candle goes." I set the cup down where I could find it again. "I taught you the cheerful half of this trade in Venice. *Condemned at Rome* is the only notice that sells; the Index of forbidden books, north of the mountains, is a price-list, and a dealer who ignores it deserves to keep a stationer's shop and die solvent and forgotten."

You wrote it down and looked pleased with the arrangement of the world. I let you look pleased. You had not yet earned a fright.”

“And now I have?”

“Now you will sit still and take the back of the coin. The same word that doubles a book’s price in Venice will, carried three weeks in the wrong direction, knot a rope around the man carrying it. *Condemned at Rome* is a recommendation where Rome cannot reach you and a hanging matter where she can, and the whole of the trade is the narrow seam between the two, and you learn where the seam runs by getting opened along it.” I pushed my left sleeve back from the wrist, far enough, and let him see the old white cord of it run up the forearm and stop. “There is the receipt. Constantinople paid it. Bank the brazier and I will take you to where I bought it.”

I came up to Constantinople in the year fourteen with the seal buttoned in my coat and my Greek at last worth more than my apologies for it, and the city did to me what it does to every man who arrives by water, which is to refuse to be looked at all at once. You came round the point and there was simply too much of it — hills of houses going up into the smoke of their own fires, the great dome riding above the lot like a thing set down by something larger and forgotten, the water between thick with caïques and lighters and the slow Venetian round-ships, and the whole of it loud in five languages before you had touched a stone. I was one-and-thirty. I was lean from the road in a way I would not stay much longer, my black hair not yet giving anything back to the comb, and my hands — a binder’s hands, my father’s hands, the only inheritance that ever fed me — were by then quick enough at a strange script to make a customs man wait while I read what he could not.

My business lived across the Horn, in Pera, which is the Frankish town — for out there we are all Franks, you understand, Roman and French and Venetian alike, the one word doing for the lot of us as *the Turk* does, in our mouths, for every soul under the Sultan; the ledge of the city where the Latins keep their houses and their churches and their quarrels and the

Venetian bailo — the Republic's resident envoy — keeps his table. Everything bound for Rome went out from under that ledge. The other shore — Stamboul proper, the markets, the Greek houses, the men I bought from — was where the paper was; Pera was where it became cargo. I learned to live with one foot on each, ferried back and forth by boatmen who overcharged me in a Turkish I was still assembling out of gesture and insult and the patient corrections of a dragoman named Yakomi, who took a fee to put my offers into the language of the men I was robbing and another fee, I have no doubt, to tell them afterward exactly how I had tried to do it.

The two good years I will give you in a breath, because good years make poor telling. I learned the upstream trade and I learned it well. The houses sold by night and denied it by morning; a brotherhood down to its last winter would part with a Father it had copied and recopied for six centuries, weeping over the coin and pocketing the coin all the same; an heir who could not read a line of his uncle's hoard reckoned the whole of it at the worth of the leather it was bound in. A library breaks where the house around it is breaking; I learned the sound of a house failing, and to be in the room at the hour a long ownership ended, and to carry what spilled from it down to Pera and make it into cargo. The cardinal was pleased, and a pleased cardinal is a standing invitation to be pleased again.

The best of it came down to me out of a daughter-house, a little dependent cell of one of the Mountain's great monasteries, set inland where the harvest had failed two years running and the brothers were down to a count you could take on two hands. A man came to Pera with it wrapped in a cloth that had been a cassock, and would not open the cloth in the street. In the back of a wine-shop he opened it: a Gregory, the Theologian's orations, in a Greek hand I dated at four hundred years and the binding older than the hand had a right to wear, the boards split and recased once by someone who knew less than I did, the sewing original underneath and sound. I have told you my one gift. It is in the hands, not the head. I turned the quires and felt the centuries in the give of the spine the way you feel a horse's age in its mouth, and I knew before I had finished that this was the truest thing I had touched since Venice, and I kept my face shut over it, because the seller watched my face as narrowly as I watched his book.

He named his price before I could name mine — the first mistake, and a seller makes it only when he has never sold before, or never from hunger. “Forty ducats,” he said, as if it were a bold stroke, and then searched me for the verdict — whether he had asked for the moon or given the thing away — and could not find it, because I gave him nothing. The answer was that forty was a tenth, near enough, of what the Gregory would bring me from the cardinal’s purse, and that his fingers had not once left the cloth, pressed flat on it as though the book might bolt.

I said nothing, and the silence did my haggling for me — no agent in the trade ever worked for less — and he filled it, as the unpracticed always do, talking the price down on my own behalf — the recasing was crude, a quire was foxed, he would carry it to the very ship himself. I bought it at thirty.

I could have given him forty. I could have given him eighty and still carried a fortune down to the water, and the brothers inland would have eaten the winter on what I kept back. I gave him thirty, counted into a hand that closed on the coin before the blessing was clear of his mouth, and I told myself what I have told myself over a hundred such hands since: that a fair price is whatever a willing man will take. It is the cleanest lie the trade ever taught me. It leaves out the word hunger, and the trade runs on nothing else.

I got it out — a Greek bottom for the first leg, a Ragusan ship from Pera for the long one, papers that called it what it was not — and three seasons later Bardi’s letter came back so warm I could feel the cardinal’s pleasure through the wax. I was flush that winter, and proud, and I will own the pride to you because the next thing the year did was correct it. I had the posting by the throat. I thought the danger in the work was the work’s, an honest cost, like wet feet. I had not yet understood that the deadliest thing in my chests was the thing I had bought most legally of all.

For there was a second errand always running under the first, the cardinal’s private appetite, the one odd line that had ridden at the bottom of every list since the year ten: the new sky. He wanted the heavens, in print, whatever Christendom was saying of them, and Pera fed me that as readily as Stam-boul fed me the Fathers — the Frankish booksellers had it off the Venetian ships, fresh, the ink barely cured. I had bought, when they were nothing but desirable, a clean old uncorrected Copernicus, the Nuremberg book itself,

and beside it a little hot thing out of Naples, a Carmelite's pamphlet arguing with great courtesy that the moving earth could be squared with Scripture if one read Scripture kindly. Bought, packed, declared, and as licit as a psalter, the morning I crated them.

The news came up the sea behind them, months stale, as all news reached us — that in the spring, in Rome, the Holy Office had suspended the Nuremberg book until it should be corrected, and had not troubled to suspend the Carmelite at all but simply forbidden him, root and branch. I had it from a Dominican at the bailo's table who delivered it as a small triumph of good order, between the soup and the fish, and I sat with my face arranged for him and did, under the table, the only sum I have ever been able to do quickly, which is the price of a thing.

And the sum came out double. That is the part I need you to feel, because it is the whole of the trade in one figure. The decree had not lowered the value of those two books by a single soldo. It had doubled it — trebled the Carmelite, which now existed nowhere a careful man could be seen to sell it. The condemnation was the advertisement, exactly as I had taught you, and the same condemnation was, on this shore, a rope, exactly as I had not. I went back across the Horn that night and opened my own crates by candle and sorted my cargo by the decree, leaf from leaf, this one a Father and merely precious, this one a Carmelite and a hanging matter, my hands knowing the difference before I had the lamp near. The cardinal had sent me up the rivers of the world after the sky. The sky had turned, in a chamber in Rome he had perhaps voted in, into the most dangerous freight in my keeping, and he was warm in that chamber, and I was not.

The trouble, when it came, did not wear a Turk's face. The Sultan's men did not care a fig what the Pope of the Latins had forbidden the Latins; banned Christian books were no contraband in a city that held all our heresies in the same mild contempt. The danger was a Latin danger, and it lived in Pera, and it was a Ragusan named Marin who had carried Catholic cargo for me twice and clean, and would have carried this had the soup-side Dominican kept his triumph to himself a season longer.

Marin was a lean, sallow article with a nose broken once and set by an optimist, so that it pointed his face a few degrees off true, and he had a habit

of cracking the knuckles of one hand against the opposite palm, slow, while he reckoned what a thing was going to cost him. Ragusa is a small Catholic republic that does its enormous trade entirely on Ottoman sufferance and Roman goodwill, and a Ragusan who is found running the Copernican opinion to a cardinal — or worse, found by the wrong cardinal — does not lose a cargo. He loses the Republic, and the Republic, learning of it, loses him first to keep itself. He worked all that out faster than I have written it, the knuckles going, and named me a price to clear the chests that was not a fee but a confession that he would rather not.

I should have let it go. I want to be honest with you about why I did not, because it would flatter me to say loyalty and it was not loyalty. It was the doubled sum. A man does not abandon on a wharf a thing that has just become worth twice what he paid, not if the man is what I had spent fourteen years making myself, and so I haggled with Marin over the price of my own neck as if it were a chest of psalters, and when he saw I would not be plucked clean he made the practical man's decision, which is always the worst one. If he could neither clear the cargo safely nor be paid enough to risk it, then the cargo had to stop existing, and the Frank who owned it had to become, if anyone ever asked, a Frank he had warned and turned away.

I went down to the Ragusan's store by the water that night to take my chests out from under him before he could make them disappear, and I did not go alone, but I went too few. There was a lamp and then there was no lamp. Someone had it out, and the dark was full of more men than I had brought, and a voice I knew was telling me, almost kindly, to stand still and lose only the cargo.

I did not stand still. It was very fast.

I got an arm up — the left, across my face, the way the body throws a shutter before the mind has voted — and the blade meant for somewhere worse went into the meat of the forearm and drew along it as I turned, and the heat of it was the only clean information in the whole black room. Then my own men were in, and there was the ugly close grappling that has no shape to it and is over before you can be afraid in any useful way, and we came out into the wharf-light with two of my three chests and my arm hanging warm and the front of me black and slick to the waist.

I sat on a bollard and bound it myself, because there was no one to do it better and my hands had paired and sewn since before I could spell. They did the work while I watched them, as if they were a tradesman I had hired and was half-minded to dismiss, and the thought that came to me, idiot and exact, was that a wound is only a tear, and a tear sews the same in skin as in vellum, from the middle outward, easing the gape before you close the ends. I lost the third chest. It held the lawful freight — Greek Fathers, sound and old and merely precious — and I abandoned it in the dark, because the two I dragged clear held the Copernicus and the Carmelite, and even gut-frighted and bleeding I had grabbed by value, which tells you everything about the man I was and most of what I am.

The two banned books reached Rome. Of course they did; that is what the telling is for. They went out by a Jewish house that asked no questions a coin could not close, and word came back in the spring, in that long dry script, that his Eminence was *most particularly gratified* by the Naples item, it being now so very scarce, and would I be alert to further such. He did not ask how it had grown scarce. He did not ask what the scarcity had cost, because the scarcity was his profit and the cost was not his line of the ledger. In Constantinople the body stopped keeping my accounts in ink.

That is the first lesson the trade ever wrote on me where I could not lose the page. A throne in Rome takes fright of a book, and the fright runs out across the whole of the sea faster than any ship can carry the book itself, and where the fright lands it raises the price and where it raises the price it sharpens the knife, and the same decree pays the cardinal his rarity and pays his agent in skin, and the two payments are entered, you understand, in two different hands.

Chapter Seven — The House on the Other Bank

“I do not see how it was done,” Tommaso said.

He had spent his afternoon over his father’s accounts and come up the stairs still at war with them, and he set the coals to the brazier and the question to me in the one motion, which was his habit by then. “You have told me you were never a rich man, and you have told me with some satisfaction. A binder’s son, a clerk’s wage. And then you went out into the world and bought” — he turned a hand at the presses around us, the dark spines, the locked doors beyond — “this. Sixty years of it. With what? Whose purse crossed the sea every time you found a book worth the having?”

“No purse crossed the sea. That is the first thing to get out of your head, and the most expensive thing for a young man to learn, because he learns it from being robbed. A purse that crosses the sea is taken at the third bridge by men who can smell silver through the leather and the prayers. I never carried above what would feed me to the next house.”

“Then how was anything paid for?”

“On paper. On a name.” I let him look unsatisfied with that, because he was a printer’s son and I wanted to watch him take the insult. “I would walk into a counting-house in Aleppo, or Isfahan, or a damp room in Pera, with a letter, and against that letter a man I had never seen would weigh me out good local silver, and the silver had never been in Rome and the cardinal’s silver never left Rome, and the two sums shook hands across two thousand miles and never met. The money does not travel. Only the promise travels, and the promise travels faster and lighter than any chest, and no corsair has ever yet boarded a ship to steal a man’s word.”

“Paper.” He said it the way he sets it — a printer’s son knows to the half-ream what paper is worth, and it is not much. “You bought a library with paper. My father is owed eleven scudi on paper this very night, by men who cross the road when they see him coming.”

“Your father is owed by men who can hide in Rome, which is a city built for hiding debts in. The houses I drew on were owed by men who could not hide anywhere under heaven, because the next caravan would carry the news of a dishonored draft to every house from Venice to Agra, and every door

would shut on the defaulter in the same week, and a closed door is a dead man who has not yet been told. That is not paper. That is a man's whole standing in the world, written small enough to fold. Your father should pray to be cheated by an Armenian. He would at least be cheated by someone with something to lose."

The boy laughed, and I did not, because a man who laughs at his own remark spends it, and I have always preferred to bank mine and let the borrower carry the interest. But I let it sit between us, warm.

"The house that taught me all this," I said, "stood on the wrong bank of a river in the middle of the world. I had better take you there before the wine is gone."

I came down into Isfahan in the spring of the year seventeen, the better part of five months off the Horn, having gone overland through the Armenian country and over the passes and down by way of Tabriz with one caravan and then another, the cold of the high road still in my coat. I was four-and-thirty. The scar on my left forearm was that winter's age and no more, a white cord I kept catching on my own cuff, not yet a thing I forgot I wore. My Greek and my Turkish had carried me as far as a certain river and then gone deaf, and my Persian was a fistful of words a dragoman had beaten into me on the march, badly, so that for my first month in the richest city I had ever stood in I bought and sold like a clever child, pointing and overpaying and learning the price of my own ignorance by the abbasi.

They call it half the world. *Nesf-e jahan* — Isfahan is half the world, the Persians say, and they say it as Venice says it lives forever, which is to say as a boast that has been true long enough to stop feeling like one. I did not come to marvel. I came to appraise, which is the only honest way I have ever had of loving a place, and the appraisal was large. There was a square in it you could have set three Piazzas inside and lost them, and a king's mosque going up at one end of the square the colour of the inside of a wave, and arcades a mile deep stacked with more goods than the whole Rialto sees in a year, and over all of it a light that did to blue tile what the lagoon does to evening, which is to make a sober man distrust his own eye. A city

that meant to be looked at, built by a king who had the means to be looked at and the wit to know it was cheaper than an army, most years.

The trade I had come for lived across the river, on the south bank of the Zayanderud, over a bridge so long and so populous it was a town laid sideways on the water. New Julfa, they called it, the suburb the Shah had made for his Armenians — and *his* is the word that matters, the word I did not yet know how to hear. He had built them a handsome quarter of churches and tall houses and walled gardens, and he kept them rich because their riches were his, the silk of the whole north running through their hands and a tithe of it sticking to his, and he guarded them from his own mullahs as a farmer guards a milch cow from his own dogs. I crossed to it with a letter folded in my coat, and the letter was the only thing about me that had any standing on that bank.

The house Bardi had sent me to — named months before, in his careful close hand, as the one establishment in New Julfa a Frank could trust with the cardinal's credit and his own neck together — was the house of Khoja Sarkis, and a *khoja* among those people is a merchant grown so large the word for merchant will no longer cover him. It stood off a court behind a plain street door, which is how money dresses when it has nothing to prove, and inside the door it stopped pretending — a court with a tank of water in it green and still, rooms opening off it deep and cool and smelling of musk and dust and ledgers, and everywhere the particular hush of a place where large sums are at rest and would prefer not to be disturbed.

Khoja Sarkis received me himself, which I took, in my ignorance, for an honour done to me, and which was in fact the courtesy a great house pays automatically to a letter it has not yet decided about. He was a broad, slow, comfortable old man with a grey beard spread over his chest like a bib and a host's wide easy manner, and he sat me down and fed me and asked — in the supple, accentless Italian of a house that had been banking Franks since before I was born — after the roads and the war in the west and the health of cardinals he named more accurately than I could, and poured a wine out of his own country better than anything Lanfranchi has ever let me steal, and through the whole of it his eyes did sums on me that his mouth was much too well-mannered to mention.

It was a strange ease, after five weeks gone deaf and clumsy in Persian, to sit in a room where my own tongue was the currency, and it was the house's, not the man's: they had been trading into Venice and Rome for three generations, and they met a Frank in his own language as a matter of business, as I had learned to meet a customs man in his. I had done my first weeks' changing at the public booths in the bazaar — a newcomer not yet certain he meant to stay, and confident enough in his own reckoning to keep his money in his own hands a while longer rather than trust it to a house of strangers. A man gives his banking to a house only once he means to stay, and I had not yet owned to myself that I did.

When at last I came to my business — that I held the cardinal's credit and wished to draw on it, to bank what I cleared, to ship for Rome through the house's hands — he spread those hands wide and smiled and said the thing I have never forgotten, because it was the first true thing said to me in Isfahan.

"All that," he said, "my daughter keeps. I spend. She knows what I have spent." And he turned his grey head toward the doorway of the counting-room, where a woman had been standing in the cool the whole while, listening to every word and weighing it, and waiting to be wanted.

She came forward when her father named her and not a step before. She was tall, and built strongly through the shoulder in a way that had nothing soft to apologize for, and she had a wide-set, level pair of eyes that took the measure of a stranger as plainly as a customs man takes the measure of a chest, and her hands — I noticed her hands, because I am my father's son and notice hands before I notice faces — were stained brown to the wrist and into the creases of the knuckles, the deep walnut brown of a copyist's ink that no washing takes out, the mark of a maker of books and not merely a keeper of them. She wore the brown like a tradesman's apron, which is what it was. Marjan, her father called her. She inclined her head the precise amount my letter had earned and not a hair more, and I made the error I had been making since the passes, which was to take a brisk woman for a cold one, and a cold one for a simple one.

"You have the cardinal's letters of credit," she said. Not a question. "And you have been in the city a month."

“Five weeks.”

“Then you have been changing his money in the great bazaar, at the booths by the gold-smiths, with a *sarraf* who weighs you out the local silver against the cardinal’s letters and tells you what Rome is worth that morning.” She named it back to me flat, as the apothecary names your complaint before he sells you the cure. “Show me your account of it. What you have changed, and what you took for it.”

I had the account. I was proud of the account. I had kept it as my father kept his stitches, close and clean, and I laid it on the table between us thinking to be admired for it, and she read it the way I read a binding — fast, from the inside, and without any of the pleasure the maker had hoped to provide.

“Here,” she said, and her brown forefinger went down the column and stopped. “And here. And every line under it.” She did not raise her voice; she did not need to, having found the body before the family had finished hoping it was asleep. “The rate you were given is the rate we give a Frank who is in the city a month and proud of his arithmetic. It is short — not by theft, by custom, which is worse, because you cannot complain of it. Three in the hundred, near enough, on the change. And then your *sarraf* charged you again to remit to Rome what you had only just turned into coin, when the house could have drawn the draft direct against the cardinal’s name and never touched the silver at all. You have paid twice to move money that should not have moved once.” She took up a reed pen, dipped it, and did in the margin of my clean account, in a hand smaller and surer than mine, the sum I had thought I had already done. It came out a long way short of the margin I had been carrying home to bed each night. “There is your season,” she said, and turned the paper back to face me. “Most of it is in the bazaar, in other men’s strongboxes, where you put it.”

I have been out-bid in my life, and out-waited, and once or twice out-fought, and a man learns to wear all of those. I had never until that afternoon been out-counted, on the one ground I had always believed was mine, by anyone, and the discovery was cold and clarifying, like the blade in Pera had been cold and clarifying, and taught the same lesson, which is that the thing you were sure of is the thing that opens you. I did not argue. Only a fool argues with the proof that his own pocket has been picked, and I have made a long

living off that fool, and I was not going to become him at a table in Julfa. I looked at her small certain figures next to my large hopeful ones, and I recalibrated the whole of my opinion of the posting and the house and the woman in the time it took the ink to dry.

“How would you have changed it?” I asked her, which was the first intelligent thing I had said in the room, and we both knew it.

Her shoulders came down a little — not warmth, she was a season off warmth, but the small private satisfaction of a craftsman asked at last about the craft. She told me. She told me about the houses and their drafts and the rates they kept among themselves and the rate they showed the world, about which money to hold and which to move and which season moved it cheapest, about the silk that was the blood of all of it and the king who let the blood for his own profit, and she told me fast and dry and complete, as I had once heard Coronaro tell it from his chair, except that Coronaro had been selling me a life of sitting safe and she was selling me nothing at all. She was simply unable to watch a thing be done badly that she knew how to do well. I have the same affliction. It is the nearest thing to virtue either of us ever owned.

“I go where houses fall,” I said, somewhere in it — reaching, I will admit, to put back on the table some coin of my own, some proof I was not merely the Frank who could not change his money. “That is my whole trade. A library never leaves the shelf while the family that loves it can still feed itself. I go where the feeding has stopped. I am where things end.”

She did not look up from the ledger she had begun to enter me into, fair and permanent, in that walnut hand.

“I know the trade from your end and from the other,” she said. “You wait for a house to fall. I am sitting in one a king knocked down on purpose.” She let the pen rest. “Julfa — the old Julfa, on the Araxes, where I was born — was a town of merchants and weavers and nothing the Shah could not buy twice over, except that they knew the silk and he wanted the silk in his own hand. So he burned the town behind us and carried the whole of it east, a thousand miles, the rich in litters and the rest on their feet, and set us down on this bank where he could see our roofs from his palace and

tax our prayers. We did not fall. We were felled, and replanted, and made to flower for the gardener. It is a better trade than yours, in one way only. You arrive after. We are the books.” She dipped the pen again. “Now. Shall I keep your accounts, or will you go on enriching the gold-smiths?”

I did not answer at once, because it was not a thing to answer quickly if I was paying attention, and I had begun, against my long habit, to pay attention. I had spent seventeen years learning to stand in the doorway at the hour a long ownership ended and feel nothing but the price of what spilled out. I had built a whole man on that talent and was proud of him. And here, entering my season into a stranger’s book with brown fingers, was the thing that spilled — carried out of a burning town as a child for reasons of policy, counted and resettled and made to pay, and come out the far side not broken and not soft but exact, keeping the accounts of the very arrangement that had moved her, because the accounts were the one thing in the world a king could not take from those who understood them. I had met clever people. I had met, that afternoon, the first person to see the machine I lived inside from the inside of its other half, unafraid of it, with no wish to pretend it was anything but what it was.

“Keep them,” I said.

So the house of Khoja Sarkis became my harbour in half the world, and Marjan kept my accounts, and kept them better than I could have kept them with both eyes and a clear conscience, and for that spring at least the keeping was the whole of it. I will not pretend to you, who are not a fool and have a sweetheart in the Parione you think I have not noticed, that I crossed that bridge each morning only for the rate of exchange. But it was the rate of exchange we spoke of, week on week, and the drafts, and the safe season for shipping, and which monk and which heir and which failing library out on the Persian roads was worth a journey — and the speaking of those things plainly, and being answered as plainly, and usually rightly, was a pleasure I had not known I had been doing without. I had spent my life giving sellers nothing in my face to price. Across her table I did not have to. She had already read me, in an afternoon, down to the short rate I

had been too proud to question, and there is a freedom in being seen that early and that completely, by eyes that mean you no harm with the seeing. It is nearly the whole of what people mean, I think, when they say a thing they are too careful to say in Julfa or in Rome.

The seal would send me out again soon enough; there was a philosopher down the Qom road the cardinal wanted, of whom I will tell you when the candle is younger. But that was a journey for the dry season, and the spring was for the city and the house and the long apprenticeship in a woman's arithmetic, and I was in no hurry at all to learn the road out of a place it had taken me five months and my whole opinion of myself to arrive in.

Chapter Eight — The Safe Hand

“There is a man north of here the clergy have stopped being able to kill,” Marjan said, “and that is the whole of why his books are worth your carrying.”

She did not look up to say it. She was at the long table in the cool of the counting-room with a half-copied deed under her brown hand and the lamp drawn close, and she gave me the thing sideways, as she gave me everything that mattered, one more line in an account she happened to be reading aloud. I had learned by then to listen hardest to what she would not turn her head for.

“Stopped being able,” I said. “Not stopped wanting.”

“The wanting is in good health. Mulla Sadra — he was the great teacher of this city, and then he taught a thing the mullahs could not have in the air over their own pulpits, and they said so, loudly, to the men who decide such matters.” She set a fresh sheet square to the first. “And those men found they could not quite burn the most famous head in Isfahan for saying that God is nearer than the clergy like to stand. So he was permitted to take himself off. North. To a village above Qom where a man can be holy at a safe distance, and he sits there and writes, and the writing comes down the road in pieces, in the hands of students too poor to keep it and too frightened to be caught carrying it.”

“And a Frank,” I said, “may carry it safely, being neither poor nor caught.”

“A Frank may pay for it. Whether he carries it safely is between him and the road.” Now she looked up, and there was the cool level reckoning I had stopped mistaking for coldness somewhere in the previous winter. “It will cost you. Denounced is dear. You taught me that yourself, the first month, when you would not tell me what the cardinal paid and I had to find it in your own face.”

I let her keep the small victory, since it was true. I had come to the house a year and some before, treating it as a service I had hired, and by that spring I crossed the bridge each morning as a man goes to the one room where he need not arrange his face, and what passed between us was the trade, week on week, and the trade was enough and more than I had thought to

want. The seal in Rome had a standing appetite I have told you of — the new sky, the forbidden heavens — and the appetite had widened, as a collector's does, until it took in any truth a throne had been frightened of, of whatever country or God. The cardinal would have the moving earth from a German press and the unmoving One from a Persian hill, and he would shelve them in the same locked case and call it learning, and never once explain to me why a prince of the Roman Church wanted the heresies of the Mussulmans under his own hand. I never asked. A man who asks his patron that question is telling him he has begun to think, and a thinking agent is dearer than a buying one and lasts a shorter time.

"What will it cost," I said.

She told me — what the journey was worth in the dry season, ten days north by way of Kashan with one caravan if the wells held; which seller in Qom kept the master's pages and would not show them to a stranger off the street; what such a notebook fetched in Rome against what it would be let go for at the source, the long beautiful difference that was my whole living. She did the sum in the margin in her small sure hand while I watched, and turned it to me, and it was a good sum, and we both knew I would not better it.

"Go before the heat closes the road," she said, and bent back to her deed, and that was the leave-taking, and I have had warmer ones that meant less.

I went north eight mornings later with a caravan of indigo and dread, the indigo bound for the dyers of Qom and the dread my own, packed where I could reach it. The road to Qom in a dry season is ten days of the same hard yellow country saying the same thing over and over, the mountains keeping their blue distance on the left hand and never coming nearer, the wells fewer than the maps made by liars promise, and at Kashan a night under a roof and a bath and the smell of the rosewater they make there, which gets into the cloth and rides with you a week. I was six-and-thirty and road-fit, lean as the saddle keeps a man lean, and the old cut on my left forearm had gone from a thing I caught on my cuff a dozen times a day to a thing I forgot until cold weather found it, which is what the body does with any hurt it has decided not to die of. My Persian by then was a working tool. I could buy and sell and curse and flatter in it and follow most of what

was said over my head in a room; only when the talk climbed off the ground of things into the high country of what a thing meant did I lose the path and have to wait, smiling like a fool, for it to come back down.

Qom I will give you as a city of the dead and the devout and the men who feed on both, which is to say a city of trade like any other, only the trade is holiness and the freight is corpses. They carry the faithful there from a thousand miles to lie near the shrine of a saint, and the carrying and the burying and the lodging of the mourners is a business as sober and as toll-ridden as the silk, and the bazaar that serves it sells prayer-stones and shrouds and, in the right back rooms, other things. I did not go to marvel at the dome over the saint, gold though they had made it. I went to a bookseller in a lane behind the coppersmiths whose name Marjan had given me, and I learned in the first hour that the difference between the dome and the back room was the difference between what a city may be seen to love and what it must love in the dark.

The bookseller kept a front room of unobjectionable things — Qur'ans in honest hands, books of law, the poets a mullah might own and never have to account for — and he kept me in it a long while, pouring tea and asking after roads, taking the measure of me as I take the measure of a binding, from the outside in, slowly, for the flaws. I did not hurry him. A man hurried in that room would have been shown to the door with every courtesy and nothing in his hands. Only when his own clerk had gone out on an errand the clerk had not known he wanted until that minute, and the curtain at the back was let down, did the bookseller bring out, from under a board under a chest, three thin gatherings of paper sewn in a wrapper that had been something else first.

I knew it for what it was before I had the cover open, by the paper and the hand. The paper was cheap — a thin local stuff, the sort a poor student buys by the few sheets and fills edge to edge to waste none of it — and the hand was a young hand, fast, cramped at the line-ends where the writer had run out of room and would not run out of paper. It was a copy, and a copy of a copy by the look of certain errors carried forward and corrected in a second ink — the same fault travels down a family of manuscripts and tells you their order. No gold. No rule. Nothing on it a thief would cross a

street for. And yet the bookseller's hand, laying it on the cloth between us, was not quite steady, and he kept the curtain in the corner of his eye while it lay there, and I understood that I was looking at the cheapest object I had handled since I left Venice and at the same time at something that could hang the seller across the table, and could not, by any road I could imagine, do the least harm to me.

That is the whole of the trade in one table, and I want you to sit at it with me a moment before I close the cover. In Constantinople a thing had grown lethal in my chests by traveling toward Rome — the same word that made it precious made it a rope, and the rope was around my own neck. Here the sign was turned over. This was a thing that could open a vein anywhere within a week's ride of where it was written, among those who could read what it threatened and whose business it was to mind; and the further west I carried it, the safer it became for everyone but its author, until at Rome it would arrive entirely harmless, a curiosity in a cabinet, a heresy too foreign to frighten anyone, worth only money. I was the safest cart it could be loaded onto precisely because I was going the one direction in which it lost its power to wound. I priced it. I did not say any of this. I have learned that to explain the trade to oneself out loud at the table is to pay more for it.

We settled it at a figure that left the bookseller able to tell himself he had been bold and me able to know I had not. He wrapped it again in its poor cloth and pressed it into my hands as if it were going to a better house than it was, and at the door he said, low, the only thing he said that was not a price: "He is on the road himself. The Mulla. Going down toward Kashan, they say, to see a man before the man dies. If you go south tomorrow you will go in his dust." He said it as you tell a buyer which river the timber came down, to add a little to the goods. I do not think he knew he was handing me the rest of the chapter.

I went south the next morning, and on the second day, where the road bends under a shoulder of bare rock and the caravans bunch at a cistern, I came up behind a small party going slow, and a man in a worn cloak walking when he might have ridden, and I knew before I was told that the bookseller had not lied.

He was spare to the point of looking unfinished, thin at the wrist where the sleeve fell back, and he walked at a pace that had decided long ago it would arrive when it arrived and not before. The cloak was old and very plain and cut from a cloth that had cost, when it was new, a good deal more than plain — I have an eye for that, for the quality a thing keeps after it has stopped advertising it, and the cloak told me more about the man than his face did. His face was mild and closed and giving nothing, and his voice, when he used it, came out so low you leaned to it without deciding to, which after Bruno's voice — that broken bell that filled a cell and a square — struck me as the most deliberate thing about him. He had been the loudest head in Isfahan, and he had taught his own throat to whisper. A few students walked with him. One of them, a soft-faced boy with new down on his lip and old caution in his eyes, kept always at the master's left hand and a half-step back, and I watched the Mulla be careful around that boy the way you are careful around a lamp in a room full of straw, and I never did learn which of them it was that informed, only that the Mulla's whole body told me one of them did.

We fell into the loose company the road makes whether you will or no. A Frank with good Persian and a letter of credit is a small marvel on that stretch, and a marvel that does not preach is a restful one, and over two days of dust and cistern-water and the long noon halts when the road lies down and waits for the heat to pass, the Mulla and I talked, in pieces, as men talk who will not meet again and so may be honest at low cost. He asked first about the roads and the wars and then, with no change in the small voice, what a man of my trade carried east and west, and I told him, leaving out the gathering of cheap paper riding in my own pack, and he let me leave it out in a manner that informed me he knew it was there.

"They tell me," he said, on the second noon, in the shade of a ruined arch with the animals grumbling and the boy with the careful eyes just out of earshot and meant to be, "that my pages have begun to travel. That they go to Shiraz, and to the Deccan in India, and now"— the mildest possible glance at me—"toward the country of the Franks."

"Books go where there is money to bring them," I said. "It is not a tribute. You should not be flattered."

It was nearer rudeness than I had meant, and it was the first thing I had said that he plainly liked. Something at the corners of his mouth conceded a point.

“No,” he agreed. “I am not flattered. I am relieved.” He let the animals fill the silence a while. “You know what it is, the thing in your pack. Not what it says — you have told me your trade and I believe you, you no more know what it says than the mule knows what indigo dyes. But you know what it is. It is a knife. Here.” He lifted one thin hand and turned it, taking in the rock and the road and the unseen city behind us and the seen city ahead. “In every house within a month of this stone there is one who can pick it up by the right end and open someone with it, and half of them would, for advancement or for fear or because they truly believe the cut is mercy. My students carry it the way you would carry a coal in your shirt. Two of them have already paid for the carrying in ways I do not care to tell a stranger on a road.” The small voice did not rise for any of this. “And then a man like you comes by, going the wrong way, bound west in the end, and I find I am glad. Do you understand why I am glad?”

“Because where I am taking it, it stops being a knife,” I said. “It becomes a curio. No one west of here can be cut by it, because no one west of here believes there is anything in it sharp enough to cut with. It will lie in a locked case and frighten nobody and prove only that its owner is a learned man.”

“Yes.” He looked at me then with something that was not warmth and was not its opposite, the look a craftsman gives a tool that has turned out better made than its price. “A dangerous thing is safest in the hand of a man it cannot move. You will carry mine further than any student who loves it, and keep it better, because you will never once be tempted to use it, or to die for it, or to change a single word of it to make it easier to hold. You do not believe a syllable of it. That is precisely why I would rather it went with you than with one who wept over it.” He drew his cloak a little against a wind that had not come up. “I have spent my whole life learning to whom a thing may be said. It is the only learning that has kept me breathing. And it has brought me, at the end of the road, to giving my dearest book to a

man who cannot read its heart, and being grateful. You may laugh. I find it very funny.”

I did not laugh, and he did not, and the joke sat there between us, which I have noticed is what the truest jokes do.

I have stood in a crowd and watched the cleverest men of an age fail to be afraid of the right thing — Bruno careless to the last, naming the stars while they tied the gag; a whole square of decent people serene as choirboys while a man cooked, because the cooking was lawful and they were not the ones being cooked. I had begun, in a young dry way, to think fear was simply a thing the world was short of, like rain in that country, and that the want of it was the great horror under everything I sold.

And here on a road above Qom was the first man I had ever met who was afraid exactly enough — not too little, like the martyrs, who throw their lives at the fire as if a life were cheap; not too much, like the men who recant before they are asked — but to the precise gauge, and who had taken his fear and ground it down and made of it an instrument as fine as my father’s paring-knife, an instrument for cutting his truth into the few hands that could hold it without bleeding.

He was the proof that the thing could be done. That a man could carry the most dangerous opinion of his century through a country full of pulpits and informers and arrive at sixty with his head still on, by the simple costly discipline of knowing, always, in every room, to whom he might speak and how low. It was not cowardice. I have never in my life seen anything braver, or lonelier, and I did not have the years yet to know that what I was looking at was the road not taken by every man I would later love.

He turned off below Kashan, toward whatever dying man he had come all that way to sit with, and his students went with him, the careful boy at his left hand, and he gave me at the parting nothing warmer than a tilt of his bare grey head, which from him I understood to be a great deal. I went on south with a new caravan and the cheap sewn gatherings that were worth a year of an honest man’s bread in Rome and a man’s neck in Qom and nothing at all in between, riding where I could reach them.

I thought I had got the best of that road. I had the goods at the source price, I had the maker's own blessing on the carrying, and I had it all and no new scar to show for it, which after Constantinople I counted as the mark of a trade at last properly learned — to take the dangerous thing and leave the danger behind you with the men too poor to put it down. I did not yet feel the smallness of what he had handed me along with the book, the verdict folded inside the gift: that I was the perfect carrier because I was empty, the safe hand because the closed one. I would not feel it for forty years, until a boy in a cold library asked me what a thing was and I found, to my considerable inconvenience, that I had at last begun to believe a syllable of it after all.

Chapter Nine — The House's Good Name

There was a book that came down to Isfahan in the spring of the year twenty that I wanted past all reason and all professional patience, and I had better tell you at the outset that I got it, so that you waste no anxiety on my account. The getting was the easy part. It is what a thing goes on costing after the money is counted that has always been my study, and this one went on costing in a coin I had not yet learned to keep in my accounts.

It was a Khamsa of Nizami — the five poems, all the Persians' romance and lament sewn into one body — and it was sold to me as the work of the Herat ateliers in the great days, a hundred and fifty years gone, when a prince in that city had kept the finest painters alive in the world as another prince keeps falcons. There were some thirty painted leaves in it. Khusrau came on Shirin bathing in a pool the colour of the inside of a shell; an army broke against an army in a dust of gold; a garden stood at evening so deep you felt you might put your arm in it to the elbow. The gold sounded right when you turned the leaf and the lapis sounded right, and the corners were worn honest and soft where a hundred and fifty years of thumbs should have worn them, and had. Only the colours had not quite gone to sleep as colours go to sleep in even a careful century, and I marked that, and explained it to myself, which is what a man does with the one true thing in a morning of pleasant lies.

A dealer had brought it down from the north — Tabriz, he said, though he said Tabriz with a small courtesy toward my not asking further, a narrow article in a felt cap who kept his fingertips hennaed and his provenances soft. I did not press him. You do not press a man on where a thing came from when you mean to buy it; you press him only when you mean to leave it and want the price of the leaving.

And because the book was what it pretended to be, I was not the only Frank in that caravanserai who had come to smell it. Across the carpet from me, lowering himself onto cushions that sighed under the freight, sat the man I had been hearing of for ten years and meeting only in the worst manner there is, which is at the same auctions: Anselme Vautier, of Marseille, who bought in those years for any French purse that would have him, and later

for the Cardinal Richelieu's, and bought heavier and worse than any man on that sea.

He was round as a wineskin and ringed on every finger, a stone for every finger and two for the thumbs, and he wore gloves — scented, always, against the smells of the trade — and I had been told, and saw now that the telling was true, that a careful watcher could price any book in Vautier's hands by which gloves he drew on to touch it. He kept three grades. Good kid for a thing he meant to buy; a plainer pair for a thing he meant to leave; and an old oiled split pair, kept for the purpose, for a thing he meant to lift up and name a forgery to the seller's own face. For the Khamsa he drew on the kid. He drew on the best kid he owned, slowly, savouring the drawing, and that was the only error I ever caught Vautier in that I did not pay for myself — and I did not understand it was an error for three weeks. His whole science was Richelieu's money, and a purse can always be outwaited by an eye; he had a broad soft face and small eyes with nothing behind them but the coin, and he was in that sense a restful opponent: a strong current drowns only the boatman blind to its set.

We bid against each other across the felt-capped man's carpet for the better part of an afternoon, and I will be honest with you, since I am being honest tonight about worse things than vanity, that it was a pleasure. He bid in tomans and threw them like bread to ducks. I bid on the house's credit, which is to say I bid a name, and a name bids carefully, because it cannot pretend afterward that it did not mean it. I let him chase the price up into the thin air near the top, where a buyer on a purse loses his nerve a heartbeat before a buyer on a name does, and I took it from him there by a margin so small it was meant as an insult and received as one. Two hundred and forty tomans. A fortune, and a third of what it would fetch in Rome, and Vautier sat back on his sighing cushions and spread his ringed hands and congratulated me, in his slow Marseille drawl, on a great purchase, and meant the congratulation to cut. It did not cut. I had won.

He did not grieve the loss, he told me, settling the kid gloves finger by finger. The pleasure of our trade was the one pleasure that never yet failed a man: that whatever we sold, and to whomever, the buyer could never bring it back, because a buyer with eyes to tell what he was buying would have no

use for either of us. "We sell to the blind, Italian," he said. "It is the only honest thing about us, and I have made my peace with it, and you should make yours. Never cure a blind man. He only buys his own stick next time, and from another shop."

I laughed, because it was funny, and because it was mine. I had said the same thing in cheaper words on a wharf at Zante years before, when I had let this very man carry off a whole chest of Cretan forgeries I had spotted and he had not, and held my tongue, and gone to my bed pleased with the silence. Only a fool retires his debtors. I had believed it as I believed in good thread.

I did not buy the Khamsa for Rome, and that is the part that matters. The cardinal's standing list had no line for a Persian romance, however princely; his hunger ran to the forbidden, not the beautiful, to the German earth that moved and the Persian God who stood too near, and a book of love-poems with painted gardens was no contraband to anyone. But a thing like that does not wait on a slow ship to find its price. There was a buyer in Isfahan before I had carried it home across the bridge — a great man of the city whom I will not name, since he has grandchildren, who collected the painted books of the dead courts as a way of owning a past that his own grandfather had helped to put to the torch. He farmed the revenues of a province and spent them on illuminated leaves, and he kept the leaves in a room he entered alone and showed to no living soul, which is the detail you must hold, because it is the whole engine of what came after: he bought beauty to possess it, never to read it, and no eye that could catch a fault would ever be let into that room while he lived.

The house took its part of the sale and I took mine, and Khoja Sarkis put his name to the book's age and its honesty, as a great house does, because the grandee was not paying only for the Khamsa. He was paying for the name of the house that swore the Khamsa was what it was. That is the thing you are truly selling, at the end, in my trade, and it had taken me until that spring to understand that I had been selling it all my life without knowing I owned the stuff.

The grandee wanted, as great collectors do, a fair copy made — the colophon and a leaf or two, in a good hand, for his own record, against the day a grandchild or a creditor should ask what the painted book in the locked room had been and what it had cost. The house made such copies. Marjan made them. And so, the Khamsa lying under our roof three days yet while the tomans settled and the litters were arranged, she sat at the long table in the counting-room with the book open under the lamp and her reeds laid in a row, to copy a dead master's hand into a living one.

I was across the court when she found it. She did not call out — she never called out — but sent the houseboy for me, and when I came she had the Khamsa turned to the colophon and her own half-made copy laid beside it, and she did not look up.

“Put your hand here,” she said.

I put my eye there instead, which was the whole of my error performed in a single motion. I saw a fine old hand, the nasta'liq leaning and sure across all five poems, one hand throughout, the gold sound, the lapis sound, the corners worn soft and true. My eye had blessed it in the caravanserai and my eye blessed it again now. It was a very good book.

“Your eye,” she said. “Always your eye. I have been copying this hand two days, and a hand is not a thing you see. It is a thing you do.” She dipped a reed and set down, beside the master's line, the same line — the same lean, the same turn at the foot of the letter. “When I make this one, I am not copying a man writing. I am copying a man copying. The strokes go where a sure hand would never put them and they stop where a tracing hand stops, to look back at the thing it is tracing. He has worked the little hesitations of his own forgery into every letter and gilded them and aged them, and I would not have caught it with my eyes in a year of looking. My hand caught it in an afternoon. My hand has done the honest thing ten thousand times, and it knows tracing from writing the way your tongue knows a true coin from a tin one, before you have thought about it at all.”

And once she had said it, the rest of the faults came up out of the leaf to meet me, the second crack arriving the instant the first had opened the door: the colours that had not gone properly to sleep; a blue in one margin

younger than the book it sat in by a hundred years; a wear at the corners a degree too even, as a thing is worn that has been worn on purpose. It was a forgery from the first gold leaf to the last, and it was the most beautiful object I have ever handled, and I had sworn a great house's name to it for two hundred and forty toman.

I had been out-counted by this woman once already, on the matter of money, and had supposed the worst blow my pride could take had been taken and survived and, after a fashion, married. I had not known there was a second floor under the first to fall through. Money had been her ground. This was mine. I had kept the books of three trades on two seas; I had caught a forger or two in Pera by the skin of a leaf, and let one go in Venice because I was young and ashamed to correct a master; and here a woman bred east of any press in Christendom had felt, through the stained ends of her fingers, a thing my eye had blessed twice and bound a house to. I sat down across the table from her and said nothing for a while. What I felt, to my own surprise, was not shame. It was the cold clean pleasure of standing in a room with someone better at the one thing I was proudest of, and the strange door that opens in a man when he stops, at last, defending the thing he was sure of.

And then the trade came back into the room, because the trade always comes back. I did the sum Vautier would have done, that the felt-capped man up in Tabriz had certainly done, that the boy on the wharf at Zante had done with a whole chest and a clear conscience. The grandee would never know. He kept his painted books in a room he entered alone; he had bought a past, not a hand. The money was paid, the litters ordered, the book was beautiful, and beauty was the whole of what he had wanted and the whole of what he had. To go to that man and tell him the house of Khoja Sarkis had sworn to a forgery and sold it to him was to hand back a fortune we had lawfully — not honestly, but lawfully — earned, and to lay the house's own oath open to question, and to make of a closed and contented transaction an open and dangerous one. We sell to the blind. Never cure a blind man. I heard it in the Marseille drawl and I heard it in my own younger voice, and the two were one voice, and I felt a genuine vertigo at the sound of it.

“He will never know,” I said. I did not say it to propose it. I laid it down as a man lays down a card he means to see beaten, to study the hand that beats it.

She finished the line she was on — her own honest line, in her own hand — and capped the ink before she answered.

“No,” she said. “He will not. Nor will his son. His son will sell it in forty years to clear a debt, and the buyer will not know, and the next buyer will not know, and somewhere down that line of men who do not know there will be one with a hand like mine or an eye better than yours, and he will know — and the only name still standing on the thing will be ours. A book outlives every man who lies about it. That is the whole terror of your trade, and you have never once looked straight at it. You think the book is the goods. The book is not the goods. The name is the goods, and the name is the one thing in the world that does not travel — it stays here, on this bank, on this house, and it feeds my children when I am dead, and a king cannot take it and a fire cannot burn it. But one sworn forgery ends it in an afternoon, fifty years after the two of us are in the ground.”

I have told you I am neither a brave man nor a good one, and I want to be exact about what moved me, because it was not goodness. It was that she was right, and that being right was, in her, the most beautiful thing I had ever stood beside — more beautiful than the Khamsa, which was the loveliest object ever to pass through my hands and a lie in every leaf. I would sooner be ruined inside her arithmetic than rich inside Vautier’s. That is not virtue. That is only a man deciding, finally, whose good opinion he means to live the rest of his life inside. I went to Khoja Sarkis that evening.

What followed I will give you briefly, because the brevity is the dignity of it. The old man heard me out with his grey beard spread on his chest and his eyes doing the sum, and when I had finished he asked one thing — “Whose hand caught it?” — and I said his daughter’s, and he nodded at that as a man nods at a thing he has banked on and found sound. He did not ask whose eye had missed it. That was the only mercy in the evening and the worst rebuke in it, both at once.

We went to the grandee together, the next morning. We did not say the word forgery and we did not name the man in the felt cap. We said the house had found, on the closer study it owed to a buyer of his standing, that it could not after all swear the book to the age it had named — and that the house did not sell what it could not swear. We gave him back his tomans to the last abbasi, and we carried the beautiful lying Khamsa home across the bridge in the very litter that should have borne it to his locked room. He was a vain man and an idle one, but he was not a stupid one, and he understood, sitting there with a fortune pressed back into his hands that he had not asked to have returned, that he had just been shown the one thing his money could not buy him anywhere else on that bank: a house that would rather give him back his gold than keep his good opinion on a false footing. I have done few better mornings of business in my whole life, and I lost a fortune at it, and that is the joke sitting at the very centre of the trade that it took me twenty years and a woman's stained hand to find.

Vautier I owe you a word on, since I promised you a tally and this was the first round of it played where I could count his rings. He never knew. He carried the loss of that auction home to Marseille as a grief and dined on it for years, I have no doubt — the day the Italian overpaid him into the floor for a Herat Khamsa. And the truth of the round was that he had bid two hundred and thirty-five tomans of his patron's money for a forgery, and lost, and so kept his money and his clean record both, by the pure grace of owning a worse eye than mine and a heavier purse than sense, which between them spared him the consequences of either. He won that round by losing it. I have kept the books on Vautier and me across thirty years, and I will tell you, when we are nearer the end of the candle than this, that they do not come out as either of us thought they were running.

The Khamsa itself we kept. Sarkis would not sell a thing he could not swear to and could not bring himself to burn a thing so lovely, so it went into a chest in the house — a lie too beautiful to destroy and too false to sell, the one object in all this story whose end I do not know. There is a fate in that for a forgery: to become the single book in a house that no honest account will ever hold. I thought of it again, long years on, when I had another beautiful book I could not enter in any ledger — but that road is far ahead of us, and I am getting old in the telling of the near ones.

That night Marjan and I sat in the counting-room with the false Khamsa back in its chest and the house gone still around us, and I did the thing I had not done in three years of crossing that bridge: I stopped arranging my face. I have told you I went over each morning to the one room where I need not keep my expression shut — and that was true, and it was also a coward's truth, because long habit had kept it shut anyway, even there. Not that night. I told her I had not crossed that bridge for the rate of exchange in a long while, and that she had known it longer than I had, and that I was too old at seven-and-thirty to go on pretending to her, of all the hands and eyes in the world, that I forded a river twice a day for the sake of her sums.

She did not soften, because softening was not in her, and it was not what I had crossed the bridge to find. She turned on me the same level reckoning she had turned on my account of the silver three years before, the look that takes the exact measure of a thing and charges it exactly, and she let me stand inside it, seen all the way to the back wall, and she did not look away from any of what she saw — which from her was the whole of what tenderness is, and a good deal sterner stuff besides. Then she set her hand on the table between us. The right one, the walnut one, stained to the wrist with the honest ink. Palm down, not reaching for me — only laid there, where I might take it or leave it. I took it. The fingers were dry and ink-cool and entirely certain, and they closed on mine the way her figures closed on a false sum, and that hour, and not the spring before it nor the bridge nor any of the soft beginnings, is the one I have meant all along when I have told you I lost her — for you cannot lose what you have not, first, and exactly there, taken hold of.

I would go down to the Gulf in a year or two, and to worse roads after it, and I went to every one of them in its turn. But not that night. That night there was a forgery in a chest too lovely to burn and too false to sell, and her hand was in mine on the counting-table, and the next road could keep till morning.

Chapter Ten — The Coffin Caravan

The year Hormuz fell I went down to the sea after the bones of it, and on the worst stretch of road in Persia I fell in with a man carrying his wife in a box. We were bound the same way, down the ladders to the coast — he to carry his own dead home, I to traffic in other men's — and neither of us, I think, judged the other to be quite sane. He was the saner of us. I did not know that for a long time, and by the time I knew it he was years buried and so was she, and the knowing did me no good at all, which is the usual yield of that kind of knowing.

But I will start where it started, which — whatever you may think a journey is — was no city gate but a counting-room: New Julfa, and Marjan pricing the journey for me as she priced everything, to the abbasi and the day.

She had the southern road in her head as she had the rates of the houses, from her people who ran silk down it and sometimes did not come back up. Shiraz first, she said, twelve days if the wells were honest and the caravan-master not a fool. Then the ladders — she used the Persian word and then the plain one, the *kotals*, the stairs of rock that take a man down off the high cold country into the *garmsir*, the hot land, where the year I was going the air would already be standing in the valleys like water in a tank. Three weeks of that, if I lived, to the coast at Bandar, across the strait from the island the Portuguese had held for a hundred years and were about to stop holding.

"You will want to be Venetian on that road," she said. "Or Roman. Or the Pope's own washerwoman. Anything but a Frank of the King of Spain."

"I am none of his."

"The Persians will not split the hair so fine, and the English will split it the wrong way for sport. Hormuz is falling or fallen — the news is a month old and says falling, which means fallen. Shah Abbas has wanted that rock off his coast for thirty years, and he has rented English ships to lever it loose, and when a thing that old comes down it comes down on whoever is standing under it. A European face at Bandar this season is a Portuguese face until it has bought itself a better one." She did the sums in the margin while she talked, in her small upright hand, and turned the sheet to me

when she was done, the cost of the going laid out cold, and it was a good accounting and I told her so, because it was, and because telling her so was the nearest thing we had to the words other people used.

She did not ask me to stay. I want to be exact about that, since I have had cause to be exact about it for forty years. She had asked me nothing of the kind, and I had offered her nothing of the kind, and I went down to my mules the next morning with her name on a draft and a list in my coat and the warm certainty, which I carried as lightly as the coat, that I would be back across the bridge before the worst of the heat broke — that this was a season's errand, the trade as I had always done the trade, and the house would be where I left it. I had not yet learned that a man can leave a thing twenty times lightly and the twenty-first time find he has been practicing.

The kotals are not roads. They are the places where the mountain has decided, grudgingly, that a goat might pass, and men have widened the goat's opinion with crowbars over a thousand years until a laden mule can do it, sweating, with stones going out from under its feet into a great deal of air. You do not ride them. You walk, with one hand on the beast and one on the rock, and you watch the country fall away below you stage by stage, the cold blue distances of the plateau giving way to a brown haze, and then to a white one, and you understand that the haze is heat and that you are climbing down into it as into a cellar that has caught fire. I was nine-and-thirty that year and the ladders found out every part of me that had been thirty once and was not now — the knees first, then the wind, then a back that wanted longer at the halts than my pride would ask for. I was lean still, salt-cured, dark; but the sun on that descent picked out the part in my hair and the backs of my hands and a face that had stopped, somewhere up on the cold plateau behind me, being a young man's, and my good Isfahan wool drank the heat all morning and handed it back all afternoon, and I cursed it on every stair.

I came up behind his party on the second of the ladders, where the track bunched at a turn and a string of mules stood blowing while their drivers argued about a girth. There were more beasts than the man needed and

one of them carried a long case slung in felt and roped twice over, and the drivers gave that one a wide berth at the halts and would not, I saw, lay a hand on it that they were not paid extra to lay. The smell told me before anything else did. Under the mule-stink and the dust there was camphor, a great deal of camphor, the reek of an apothecary's whole stock spent on one purpose, and I had been in the trade long enough to know what men pack in camphor when it is not silk. Pray you never learn that smell by the nose, as I did on that mountain; it does not leave you in a week, and it has not left me in forty years.

The owner of it sat a little apart on a stone with his face to the drop, and he was the strangest object on that mountain, stranger than the box. He wore a Persian coat and a Persian sash and a turban wound by a practised hand, and out of all that came a sunburnt European face and a beard such as no Persian and no Christian wore — uncut, untrimmed, gone down his chest in a brown flood, the beard of a vow, the razor sworn off for a reason and the reason meant to show. When he heard my Italian — I had said something to my own driver, a curse, the mountain earned curses — he turned as if I had struck a bell in him.

"Italiano," he said. Not a question. He came up off the stone with both hands out. "From where? Say Rome. After this year I will pay a man to say Rome."

He was della Valle. The name meant a little to me even then — there were letters of his that went home to Rome and got read aloud in the kind of houses that read such things aloud, and parts of them had reached me secondhand, the famous traveler, the nobleman gone wandering in the lands of the Shah. The letters had not mentioned that he was mad, but the letters of such men never do; that is what the letters are for.

We went down the rest of that ladder together and the next day's roads after it, because a caravan makes its own society whether you will or no, and because he had been starved, I came to see, for a tongue that was his own. His Persian was good and his Turkish better than mine and he could be witty in both, but a man grieving wants to grieve in the language he was a child in, and I was the first Roman he had struck in two years who was not a priest wanting something or a factor selling something. So he talked. He talked the way the road went, in pieces, broken off at the bad turns and

picked up again at the halts, doubling back on itself, contradicting in the afternoon what it had sworn in the morning.

His wife was in the box. He told me this on the first evening as another man tells you his wife is waiting at home — present tense, settled, a fact of the household. Sitti Maani, a Christian of the East, married out of Baghdad; dead at the coast better than a year gone, of a fever and a thing that went wrong with a child that did not live either. He had had her embalmed by a Frankish surgeon and a deal of camphor and he was taking her to Rome to lie in his own family's chapel, and he spoke of the three thousand miles still between her and that chapel as a man speaks of an errand he is behindhand on.

"They tell me it is unwise," he said. We were at a halt, the animals down, the heat lying on us like a hand. "The Augustinians at Hormuz told me — before the English knocked their church down, God rest the stones — that I should bury her decently in Persian ground and carry home a lock of her hair and my memory of her, which were the parts that mattered. *The parts that mattered.*" He laughed, and it was a real laugh, and his eyes were wet inside it, and both things were entirely sincere, which I would learn was the whole of how he was made. "A friar telling me which parts of my wife mattered. I have buried two servants and a horse I loved on this journey and said the words over them and walked on. Her I carry. You think me a madman."

"I think you have a great deal of camphor," I said, "and a long way to go in the heat."

That delighted him. He slapped the stone. "A merchant's answer. You are a merchant." And then, because nothing in him stayed in one place, the delight curdled, and he looked at the felt-wrapped case down the line where the drivers would not touch it, and he said, lower, "She would have liked you. She had no patience for sentiment either. She used to say I wept the way other men sweat, that it cost me nothing and proved nothing." He wiped his face with the flat of his hand. "She was right. It costs nothing. I do it anyway. What is your trade, merchant, that brings a Roman down the ladders into the *garmsir* in the worst year the coast has had since the Flood?"

I told him. Books, manuscripts, the old learning of the East bought where it came loose and carried west to men who would pay for it. I did not say for whom. He did not need telling; he had the measure of the whole business inside a minute, and his face, which hid nothing, showed me what he thought of it before his mouth caught up.

“Ah,” he said. “You are one of the gleaners. You follow the armies.”

“I follow the prices. The armies and the prices keep company.”

“They do.” He plucked at his enormous beard. “I have bought a few things myself, in my travels — a man cannot help it, in this country, the things lie about in it like fruit under a tree. I have a Coptic psalter I would not sell for my house in Rome, and some old Persian histories, and the tongue of an idol I shall give to a cardinal who collects such curiosities and who will like it better than the psalter, the fool.” He said it fondly; he had cardinals as I had patrons, and despised and loved them in the same breath. “But I buy what I love and keep it. You buy what others will love and sell it to them. We are not the same animal, you and I, though we feed at the same trough.” He turned the wet bright eyes on me, and there was no malice in them, which was worse than malice. “Tell me, when the friars’ books come down off that burned rock — and they will, the looters are not collectors, they will sell — will you buy the breviary a man said his last masses out of? Will you put a price on a dead priest’s psalter?”

“If it is sound,” I said, “and the price is right, and the man selling it has the right to.”

“The right to.” He laughed again, the wet laugh, shaking his head. “God love you. I have not heard the word *right* used so cheaply since I left Christendom.” He did not say it to wound, and it did not wound; he had never once in his life had to buy a book he did not want, and his contempt was the clean contempt of the never-hungry, who can afford to despise a starving man his supper. I had been hungry. I let him keep it. It was the only luggage he carried that weighed nothing.

Bandar, when we came down to it, was a town drinking the dregs of a war it had won. The Shah's flag flew over it and Shah Abbas was a thousand miles away in Isfahan and would never come, and the men actually holding the coast were Persian soldiers who had not been paid and English captains who had been, and between them moved everything that a fallen city coughs up — refugees off the island in boats meant for fish, Portuguese families with what they could carry, soldiers selling what those families had not been able to, and over all of it the flat white hammer of a heat I had no word for, that made the Constantinople summers I had thought hot seem a fond memory of spring.

I parted from della Valle at the edge of the town. He was for the harbour, to find a ship east — India, he said, Surat and the Portuguese at Goa, who would take him in for a Christian even now, and then home the long way, the box and all. He clasped me by both arms and told me, his eyes filling, that I had been a great comfort to him on a hard road, which was a lie, I had been a sounding-board for his grief and a foil for his wit and no comfort to anyone; and it was also entirely true, as the things he said were always both.

He told me, when I reached India, to keep my eye on the Mughal court itself. There was an appetite in that house, he said, that he had from the Jesuits — it ran back to the old emperor Akbar, dead a good fifteen years now, who had raised a hall where mullah and Brahmin and Jesuit were made to argue the nature of God before the throne and were paid for the arguing. "The blood throws up such a one every reign or two," he said, "a prince readier to own a forbidden book than a province, and past all teaching on the difference. If you live to see the next, you will buy well at his court — and you will bury him after. Princes who love books that much always come to grief, and grief is your harvest."

Then he was gone into the press toward the water, the long case swaying behind him on its mule, and I did not see him again, in this life, and his letters I read for years after as a man reads of a country he once passed through in the dark.

The friars' books I found on the third day, in the back of a Chandler's go-down near the water, where a Persian quartermaster with unpaid soldiers to feed had put the church-plunder he could not eat. There was a deal of

it and most was rubbish to me — the silver was gone already, melted or shipped, and what was left was paper, which the quartermaster valued at something below the felt it might be wrapped in. Latin breviaries. A printed Goa Bible with the damp already in it. Books of hours, a *Flos Sanctorum* in Portuguese, two manuscript volumes of an Augustinian house's accounts and one that was not accounts at all but a fair old *Vitae Patrum* in a fine fifteenth-century Iberian hand that some friar had carried out to the edge of the world and read until the corners were soft. The quartermaster wanted them gone. He named a figure for the lot that was an insult to the paper, and I made my face slow and unhappy and named a worse one.

He looked at me hard while we haggled, because I was a Frank, and a Frank that season was a thing to look at hard. An Englishman in the doorway, a Company man by his coat and his sunburn and by how readily the Persians let him stand where he liked, watched too, and said, idle, in bad Portuguese, that I had the look of Goa about me. It was the dangerous moment of the whole errand and it turned on a coin's worth of grammar. I answered him in Italian and then in my Levantine Turkish, fast, the merchant's patter, Venice and Aleppo and the Roman houses, a subject of no king at all and the servant of a Roman churchman, never of any Spanish gun; I produced Marjan's draft on a Julfa house and the Armenian names on it, which no agent of the Catholic King would carry; and I let the Englishman see me be bored by his suspicion, which is the one thing no honest suspect ever manages. He shrugged and lost interest. The Persian, who had been waiting to see which way the Englishman jumped, dropped his price the moment the Englishman's back was turned, because a seller hates a buyer the law might take off his hands before the money is counted.

I bought the lot for less than the *Vitae Patrum* alone would fetch from the first Roman antiquary I showed it to. I had the breviaries and the books of hours for the weight of their paper, dead men's offices bought by the pound, and I packed them that night in a chest lined against the damp and slept across it, and felt — I have tried to remember honestly what I felt, and the honest answer is that I felt the clean satisfaction of a sum that has come out well. They were sound, the price was right, the quartermaster had the rough soldier's right of the victor to sell them. Every condition della Valle had laughed at I had met, and I have never been able to decide, in all the

years since, whether the meeting of them was the morality of my trade or only its alibi.

What I did not feel, packing a sacked church into a chest on that Gulf shore, was any of the thing the books had been for. That is the cunning of carrying them west. A Latin breviary is a live coal in the hand of a man who prays out of it; in mine it was provenance and condition and a fair Iberian hand, an object that had once been a sacrament and was now an item, and the journey from the one to the other was a journey I performed simply by being the man I was and standing where I stood. I was, as a wiser man had told me on a road above Qom, the safe pair of hands, the empty cart. I packed God's offices as the quartermaster had stacked them, and I was a better Christian than he was by every measure but the one that counts on a coast like that one, which is what your hands do when they are full of a beaten man's holy things and no one is watching them but you.

They went up to Rome the next season and into the cardinal's library, and I entered them in the catalogue myself, years after, when at last I sat down to make it, every one, by title and hand and the honest provenance — *out of the Augustinian house at Hormuz, dispersed at the fall, 1622* — in a clear round script, and slept the better for the entry, and thought no more about it. It was a great while before I understood that the books a man can write down are not the ones that cost him anything. I have bought a faith's whole furniture off the back of a fire and shelved it under its right name and lost no sleep. The one book that ever broke me I have not been able to enter for six years, and a throne falling is what put both of them into my hands. The difference was never in the book. It was only ever in what the buying asked me to know about myself, and a man can shelve Hormuz and keep his eyes shut. Delhi made me open them. But Delhi is a long road still, longer than the ladders, and I was a younger man going up off that coast with a good chest and a clear sum, in no hurry at all to learn what it had cost me.

Chapter Eleven — The Accounting

Twelve years I lived on the south bank of the river, and somewhere in the middle of them I had let the place become home — which is not a thing a man decides. He finds it already done, as he finds the grey in his beard: a hair a day, and then one morning the glass has the whole verdict ready and hands it to him as news.

I was six-and-forty. The hair at my temples had gone the colour of pewter and stopped pretending otherwise, and a phrase I had used about it for years — that it still gave nothing back to the comb — I had retired, the comb having won the argument. None of that troubled me. What troubled me that spring was a smaller thing and a worse one. I had begun to hold a colophon a finger's breadth further from my face than I had held it the year before, to make the letters sit still and be one thing instead of two. A finger is not far. But when a man's whole estate is his eye, he marks that finger as a sailor marks the first plank that gives a little underfoot, and says nothing to anyone, and walks softly after, listening for the second.

The trade had never run sweeter. I crossed the bridge over the Zayanderud twice a day, out in the cool of the morning and back in the long gold of the evening, and the New Julfa side had stopped being a foreign quarter to me and become a set of doors I knew by their knockers. The house of Khoja Sarkis was my harbour; I had a corner of the counting-room that was understood to be mine, a cushion gone flat to my particular shape, and a standing welcome that asked nothing of me but that I be good at what I did, which I was. Marjan kept the great ledger at the long table under the north light, and I kept my smaller accounts beside her, and the river ran between my lodging and my life in a way I had stopped finding strange.

The city had a death in it that year, a great one, though it touched me less than the small failing in my own eye, which tells you the size of a man. Shah Abbas died that winter up in the north, and Isfahan put on the face a city puts on for the death of a king it has feared a long time — grave in the streets and busy in the back rooms. New Julfa, which he had built out of a people he had carried off whole from their own country to suit the revenues of his silk, felt the loss as a tenant feels the loss of a hard landlord: uncertain whether to mourn the man or to count the plate before the heir

comes down to look at it. I marked the mood and priced one or two things against it and thought no further. I did not yet understand that I was about to be taught the same lesson on my own skin, in the same season, by a smaller throne than his.

The packet came up from Aleppo at the back end of summer, five months stale by the dust on its seals, carried the last stage by a Carmelite who would not stay to eat. There were two enclosures in the house's correspondent's hand and a third folded inside them that was not, and I opened them at the long table with the north light on them and Marjan three feet off at her ledger, and I have never since smelled hot wax but I am at that table again.

The first was a notice, not a letter. Ascanio Vitelleschi, Cardinal-Deacon, was dead of a quartan fever in the spring, in Rome, and had been buried with the proper offices in the proper place, and his library and his benefices and his household had passed, per the disposition lodged with his notary, to his nephew Ottavio. It was four lines long and it was correct in every particular and it had been written by a clerk who had never met the man, and I read it twice, the second time holding it the betraying finger further off, as if the trouble were in my eye and not in the world.

I had met him in the flesh perhaps four times, all of them long ago and most of them in his first years of collecting, before he learned he could buy a man like me through a factor and never breathe the dust of a caravanserai himself. He was tall, and dry as a good vellum, and he had a way of narrowing his eyes at a thing he wanted that I came in time to recognise in myself.

But I knew him, truly knew him, as I knew almost no one then — by his hand. Twenty years of it. The standing list that arrived twice a year, the appetites laid out in his long upright script, fond and grasping and exact; the complaints about the prices I got him and the warmer complaints when a rival got there first; the once-a-year line, dropped in among the orders as a man drops a coin to a servant he is fond of, that told me he held my judgement above the judgement of churchmen who had never bound a quire in their lives.

He had recruited a bookbinder's son off the Venice quays and let him grow, on his purse, into the one thing the boy had wanted past wanting — to have his word on a manuscript taken above a cardinal's. I had served the institution that lit the first fire of my life for twenty years, and I had been able to do it with a whole heart because at the far end of the money there had been this one dry, acquisitive, affectionate man, and now there was not.

The second enclosure told me what there was instead.

Ottavio wrote a chancery hand so even it might have been ruled — every letter the height of its neighbour, no stroke hurried, no ink pooled at a turn where feeling might have pressed the pen. He condoled with me on the loss to learning. He confirmed that the agency continued at the late Cardinal's standing terms, for the present. And he requested — the word sat in its sentence as smooth and cold as a stone in a stream — that I return to Rome at my earliest convenient season to render a full accounting of the agency: the stock in hand, the sums advanced and outstanding, the dispositions of the past several years, that the new establishment of the library might be set in order on a sound footing.

A full accounting. I sat with it. I had rendered accounts all my life and never once felt the word turn cold in my hands as it turned then. There was nothing in the letter a man could take exception to. That was the chill of it. The uncle had bought books and a man to find them and had loved, in his dry fashion, both; the nephew had inherited a collection and a line of costs, and he meant to learn which of the costs still earned. I was a line in a ledger that had changed hands, and the new hand was going down the column with a clean pen, and had come to my entry, and wished to know what it was for.

I will tell you the truth of how I decided, because it is the kind of truth I have made you sit here to hear. I did not weigh Marjan against Rome. I did not weigh anything against anything; a man at the height of his competence does not weigh, he calculates, and the calculation made itself before grief had its boots on. If I did not present myself to the heir, the heir would replace me, and there was no shortage of replacements — Vautier alone, round and ringed and rich on Richelieu's purse, would have crossed two seas on his knees for the standing list I held, and judged it worse than I did, and not

cared. My purse ran from Rome. My standing ran from Rome. The library I had spent half my life filling was in Rome, and a man does not let a stranger inventory his own life's work and tell him after what it came to. I would go. I would settle the new patron, square the accounts, see the dry man's collection set right, and come back across the bridge before — I did the old comfortable sum almost out of habit — before two winters were out.

I had left the house before, you understand, a dozen times and more, down to the Gulf and up to Qom and out along the roads the trade runs on, and I had always gone light, certain of the return as a man is certain of the floor. I went to my decision that evening light in just that way. But somewhere in the making of it I felt, for the first time, the small drag a thing has when it has begun, secretly, to matter more than you have budgeted for — the drag the Gulf road had warned me of, when I told you a man may leave a place lightly a great many times and then find, on a morning no different from the others, that all the lightness was only practice. I felt it and I set it down to grief for the dry man and crossed the bridge to my lodging and slept.

The dead man's own letter came a fortnight after his death notice, out of all order, as the post of those years delivered the world — the announcement of the end arriving first and the man himself walking in behind it, talking.

It was the spring list, written before the fever took him, sealed by his own ring. He wanted a Dioscorides if the price could be brought to earth, and was prepared to be lied to about a Galen so long as the lie was beautiful and old; he had heard the French were sniffing after the Coptic things and wished me to sniff faster; he complained, in the warm aggrieved way that was the nearest he came to embracing a man, that my last consignment had cost him the earth and been worth the moon, which he supposed was what he kept me for, and would I for the love of God find him something a Barberini did not already have. At the foot, beneath the orders, in the smaller hand he kept for the things he did not dictate to a secretary: *You are too long in Persia, Ferrucci. Come and quarrel with me about prices in a room before we are both too old to enjoy it.*

He had been the better part of five months in the ground when I read it. I had been buying for a corpse all summer and writing my reports to him with a living man's care. There was nothing to do with the letter. I could not answer it and I could not throw it on the brazier, and so I did what I have done with every such thing since, which is fold it back along its own creases and keep it — one more voice from a man already in the ground, to argue prices with for the rest of my own life and never once get the last word from again.

So I set about the long unmaking of twelve years, which is a colder business than the making and goes quicker. Stock to be crated for the road: the saleable things the new establishment would want to see, the receipts and the running books, the proofs of what I was for. I packed them in the counting-room over a week of evenings, and among the lesser goods, wrapped still in the poor sewn cover it had worn down the road from Qom, I came on the cheap copy I had bought in secret in a bookseller's back room years before — three thin gatherings of a teacher the clergy had stopped being able to kill, a student's copy of a student's copy, worth almost nothing and dangerous out of all proportion to its worth. I weighed it in my hand a moment, the betraying finger holding it that little further off, and then I packed it with the rest to go up to Rome, and thought no more about it than a man thinks about any small uneasy thing he has decided to carry rather than to leave. What it would cost me to have carried it I would learn on the other side of that journey, in a colder room than any in Isfahan, and that is a tale for the next time the candle is this low.

I took my leave of Khoja Sarkis on the last morning, in the court with the green tank, and it was the easiest parting of the three I made that I count, because between us there had only ever been the clean thing, which is business done well by men who respect each other and keep their hearts in their own houses. He had his grey beard spread on his chest and his sums already done; he had known a recall when he saw one before I brought it to him. We squared the house's account with mine to the last abbasi, and he poured the tea himself, which from him was the whole ceremony, and

he told me a road home through the Aleppo houses that would shave a fortnight off and lose me nothing in safety, and he did not say he would not see me again, and neither did I, though we were both old men by the measure of that country and the road between us would be three thousand miles long. He clasped my hand at the street door in the merchant's grip, palm and thumb, the grip that closes a bargain, and that was right; we had been the best of bargains to each other for twelve years. The warmth was all in the exactness. I have had warmer farewells that meant less.

The other I will not give you whole, because some things keep their dignity only folded.

Marjan and I sat at the long table the last night with the lamp between us and the great ledger closed for once, and I told her the road I would take and the season I would be gone, and she heard me out as she heard everything, level, taking the measure of it, charging it exactly. She did not ask me to stay. I want you to understand that she did not, because I have heard men tell these stories and put the asking in, to be forgiven the going; there was no asking. She had been carried out of one country by a king's want when she was too small to be asked her opinion of it, and had kept the books of her people's exile ever since, and she knew a summons from a throne when one was laid on her table, and she did not insult either of us by pretending mine was a thing I might refuse, or by asking me to make it one.

What she did was price the man I was going to. "He confirmed the terms *for the present*," she said. She had taken the phrase out of Ottavio's letter the once I showed it her and never forgotten it, as she forgot no figure. "A man who loved the books would not have written *for the present*. He has weighed you already, your new cardinal, in a room you have never stood in, and found you a charge against an estate. You are going to Rome to be told the price of yourself by a man who has worked it out before you arrive." She was not comforting me. She never once in her life reached to comfort me; the reaching was always mine. She was doing the one thing she had instead, which was to see the whole of a thing without flinching from any part of it, and to let me stand inside that seeing, which was sterner than comfort and worth more.

I was the one who reached. I told her — clumsily, being out of the habit of saying the plain thing even to her — that I would come back. That the agency held, that the road was known, that two winters at the most would see me across the bridge again with the dry man's collection settled and the new one satisfied. I made her the promise she had not asked for, to fill the place where her asking would have been, and I meant every word of it, and it was true; I did come back. She let me make it. She did not say she believed it and she did not say she did not. She took its measure the way she took the measure of a sum laid before her that she would not sign — registering it exactly, to the abbasi, and leaving it unsigned on the table between us. Then she set her stained hand over mine, the walnut-dark one, palm down, certain, the same hand and the same gesture as the night three years before, and we sat like that with the lamp burning down, two people who read the world's machine too well to lie to each other about how it was going to grind, and well enough to know that the grinding could keep till morning.

I went down to the caravan at first light with the chests roped and the Carmelite's road in my coat and Marjan's name on a draft against the Aleppo houses, and I crossed the bridge for the last time of that twelve years' worth of crossings, east to west, the river going about its business under me as if it had not been the boundary of my whole life.

Every road I had taken since I was a young man had run the other way — east, upstream, toward the source and the goods and the unasked question, deeper into the half of the world that paid in things I could carry home. This one ran back the way I had come, toward the men who did the paying. I had the sun behind me climbing the ladders out of the plain, and I rode west into my own long shadow all that first morning, toward Rome, and the dry man dead in it, and the even-handed nephew waiting with a clean pen to tell me what I had been worth.

Chapter Twelve — The Sound Footing

Tommaso brought me a book that was not what the catalogue said it was, and held the two of them out to me — the volume in one cracked hand and the open register under the thumb of the other — with a careful triumph: he had caught his master's house in an untruth and had not yet decided whether he would be thanked for it or beaten.

It was a small thing, a thick duodecimo in a tired calf binding, and the entry beside it, in the round compiler's hand of some clerk forty years dead, called it a volume of sermons. It was not sermons. It was a bundle of a Paduan canon's letters about a lawsuit over a mill, bound up after his death by an heir who wanted them off a table, and somewhere in the long slow making of the catalogue a tired man had read the first leaf, found a text and a blessing at its head as letters of that age often carry, and written *Sermones* against it, and gone on to the next, and died, and left the lie to harden on the page.

"It is wrong," the boy said. He said it flat, a little aggrieved, as he says the true things, as if the world had promised him better. "Forty years it has been wrong. Shall I strike it and enter it true?"

I sent him for the wine first. He went down the cold three steps to the press where I keep his Eminence's Montepulciano — the cardinal is past tasting it and would not hear the cork if you drew it under his ear, and I have long since stopped pretending the bottle is anyone's but mine — and he came back and poured for us both and set my cup at my right hand without being told, which is a courtesy he invented somewhere around the third evening and has never once let lapse. The tramontana was still working at the shutters. The braziers gave their little grudging heat into a room built to hold ten times it.

"Strike nothing," I said. "Sit."

He sat. I took the duodecimo and held it off at the length my arm has lately decided is the only honest distance, until the canon's small Paduan hand stopped swimming and consented to be one thing, and I let the boy watch me do it, because a young man should see early what waits for an eye that spends sixty years on other men's writing.

“A dead clerk made an honest mistake,” I told him, “and the mistake has lain here forty years doing the book no harm, because nobody on earth wants a canon’s letters about a mill. That is luck, not cunning. But you have put your finger on the most useful truth in this trade, and I would have you understand it before you strike a line. We say a book without an entry does not exist.” He nodded; he had quoted that one back to me himself, the first week. “Hear the other half of it now. A book with the *wrong* entry is worse than gone. A thing you have left off the shelves a careful man may still find, by its absence, by the gap where it should be. A thing you have catalogued falsely is hidden inside the one place no man thinks to search, which is the record itself. You may lock a press; a lock advertises. But put a dull true-looking lie against a book, shelve it among its dull neighbours, and you have buried it alive in plain sight, and it will lie there under everyone’s hand and nobody’s eye for as long as the paper lasts.”

He turned his cup. “That is a thing a man would have to do on purpose.”

“Yes,” I said.

“Have you?”

“Drink your wine,” I said, “and I will tell you about the year I came home to Rome and learned to.”

He grinned at that, the gap-toothed grin he has when he thinks he has won a point, and offered that his Eminence’s gout being what it was, the cardinal would not be down to check my arithmetic before Easter — his first true jest of the evening, and a fair one, the deaf old man three floors below us turned into our accomplice — and I did not laugh, because a boy’s wit is a coin he should be let bank himself, but I let it stand between us and warm the room a degree the braziers could not. Then I drank, and went back five-and-thirty years to a colder room than this one, where the gout was younger and the eye that priced me had no kindness in it at all.

I came home to Rome in the autumn of 1630, after four-and-twenty years, an old road behind me through the Aleppo houses and over a winter sea, and the city did not know me and I had stopped expecting it to. A man leaves a

place at three-and-twenty with paste under his nails and comes back to it at seven-and-forty with the East worn into his face, and the place has spent the interval not thinking of him once; that is the whole transaction, and it is fair, and it stings anyway.

The plague was in the north that year, in the Milanese and down through Tuscany, and it never came over the passes to us, but its breath did. The roads ran slow with quarantine; chests I had goods in sat forty days in a shed at some border while a clerk who feared for his own skin decided whether the cloth they were wrapped in had touched a dead man; letters that should have taken six weeks took five months or did not come. Rome itself only drew its gates a little tighter and grew watchful and mean as a household grows mean when there is sickness next door — not stricken, only braced, counting its own.

I came in by the Flaminian gate and went on foot through to the old quarter, because the legs still liked a city after a ship, and I found the street behind the Pantheon where my father had bound books for the three streets that knew his name. The shop was a chandler's now. A boy I did not know sat in the doorway dipping wicks, and the bench where I had learned a broken sewing in the dark was gone, or under his tallow, or burned; I did not ask. The trade outlives the man and takes the room he worked in for some other use, and there is no grievance in it, only information. I stood there long enough to price the change and walked on.

I did not go to the Campo. I will tell you that plainly, since you may wonder. The market was running in it that week as it runs every week, the herb-women and the fish and the man crying needles, straight across the stones where I had stood at seventeen on the officials' side of the rope and watched them fold a great voice back into a man with two fingers' width of linen. I thought of him on the bridge, as you think of a debt you have decided not to pay today. Then I turned up toward the palace of a living cardinal, who was waiting for me with a clean pen, and I gave the dead one no more of the morning than that.

The library I had spent the better part of my life filling was three long rooms on the second floor of the Vitelleschi palace, and I had never once seen it whole. I had sent it home a chest at a time across twenty years — out of Pera, out of Isfahan, out of the war-coast at Bandar — and other men had shelved it, and now I stood in the door of it and understood for the first time the size of what I had done, the thousands of spines, the locked presses at the end where the things that could not stand in the open light were kept. It is one thing to buy a library leaf by leaf down sixty years of roads. It is another to be shown it standing, and to feel, under the pride, the first cold breath of the truth that to build such a thing is to spend yourself on an object that will be standing, indifferent, on the morning you are not.

Ottavio Vitelleschi received me at a table in the middle of it with the great inventory open before him.

He was nothing like his uncle. Ascanio had been tall and dry as a good vellum, long in the finger, with a collector's narrowing of the eye over a thing he wanted that I had caught, late, in my own face. The nephew was fleshy and settled, soft about the jaw, and he had a low even voice that never once in the hours I spent with him climbed or fell to make a point, because he had learned, somewhere, that a voice that does not rise makes the other man lean in, and a man leaning in has already given a little ground. His hands were the smoothest I had seen in years. They had never pared a skin or driven an awl or held anything heavier than a pen, and they went down the column of the inventory while he spoke to me, one finger under the line, where another man's eyes might have wandered the room.

He condoled with me, correctly, on the death of his uncle, and the loss to learning it was. He said the old man had spoken warmly of my judgement, which I knew to be true and knew also that the saying of it cost him nothing and was therefore not a kindness but an item, placed early, as you place a good lot early to set the tone of a sale. Then he came to the matter, and the matter was that the late cardinal had kept a poor set of books about his books.

"My uncle bought beautifully," he said, "and accounted like a lover. There are sums here advanced to you across nine years against goods I can find no entry for, and goods on these shelves I can find no sum against, and a

long row of what he was pleased to call *incidental charges of the road*, which I take to mean the bribes, and the silences bought, and the men paid to look the other way at a customs shed.” He looked up at last, mild as milk. “I do not reproach the practice. I reproach the bookkeeping. A risk that is run and never written down has been run for nothing — it cannot be weighed, it cannot be set against its return, it cannot be defended to whoever comes after and asks what the library cost. I should like it written down. All of it. I should like to know, in figures, what I have inherited and what it has been worth to carry the danger of it.”

I had rendered accounts all my life. I had never sat across from a man bent on entering my neck in a ledger and totalling it. He did not threaten me; there was no threat in him, no appetite for my ruin, no wish to be rid of me — I think he would have been faintly puzzled to learn I feared either. He merely wished me legible. He went down the column and where my work had been done in the dark, in the unwritten places where the whole trade actually lives, he meant to bring a candle and a fair round hand and make it sit in the light and answer for itself. He did not threaten me. He filed me.

And I understood, sitting there with the smell of my own life’s work around me in three rooms, that the warm man at the far end of the money — the dry, fond, grasping man who had once written under his orders that he held my judgement above a churchman’s — had been the whole of my protection, and that he was in the ground, and that nothing now stood between me and the column but how useful I could keep proving I was.

So I gave the nephew his figures. I sat a week of mornings and I priced my own risks back across nine years and entered them fair, the bribes and the silences and the danger-money, and signed the total, and watched him read it, unsurprised, and lay it in its place. The agency would continue, he told me when it was done, at the standing terms, *for the present* — the same three words his letter had carried to Isfahan, that Marjan had picked off the page a thousand leagues east and held up to the lamp for me to see, and they meant in his mouth exactly what she had said they would mean.

It was inside that same accounting, on a morning near the end of it, that he came to the dangerous holdings.

He had a separate quire for them, the locked-press books, the ones that could hang a man or merely shame the house, and he went down that column as he had gone down all the others, pricing, sorting, deciding which were assets the new establishment would keep discreetly behind its glass and which were liabilities to be quietly *corrected* — his word, soft, the word a surgeon uses, the word the Office itself used when it handed a man to the fire so the Church might shed no blood. Corrected. Some of these, he said, were too dangerous to hold and too valueless to sell, and those would be seen to. And among them, three lines from the foot, in the inventory another man had made of the chests I sent from the East, stood a single entry for a cheap thing in a poor sewn wrapper, three thin gatherings of a teaching denounced from one end of Persia to the other — bought by me in a back room behind the coppersmiths of Qom for the price of a meal, carried three thousand miles, and dangerous out of all proportion to the meal it had cost.

He did not pick it up. In all the hours of that accounting he never once touched the actual paper of anything; the books were to him the lines that stood for them, and a line is cleaner than a book and does not give you its dust. He set his finger under the entry, and he said it should be seen to with the rest, and the finger moved on down the column to the next, and that was all the notice the thing got from the man who had ordered its death — a quarter inch of travel under a clean nail.

I was the one who would see to it. That was the joke of it, if you have the stomach for the kind of joke the trade tells. The correcting fell to me, because I kept the catalogue; I was the candle he had brought to the dark places, and I was to hold it to this one too.

I will tell you what I told myself, because the lie a man tells himself is the truest record of what he could not yet bear to know. I told myself it was thrift. A genuine thing should not be burned. The notebook was a poor copy of a poor copy, cramped and corrected and worth nothing on any table in Christendom, but the text in it was real, was sound, was the honest reasoning of a living mind set down by a student who could not afford good

paper, and a dealer who destroys a sound thing has spat in the face of his whole trade, has done with his own hand the one act the trade exists to prevent, which is the loss of a true book. That is what I told myself, and every word of it was true, and it was not the reason, and I knew even then it was not, the way you know a coin is light in the dark before you have weighed it.

So I did not burn it and I did not surrender it. I took the catalogue, and against that cheap bundle of Mulla Sadra's reasoning I wrote, in the fair round script I keep for the things I most want believed, that it was *a scholar's exercise, Arabic, imperfect and of no account* — no name, for a name can be looked for, and I had carried that hand across half the world and would not lay it on a page now where any clerk of the Office might one day read it — and I shelved it at the dim end of a press among grammars and the prayer-books of a faith no inquisitor in Rome could read, in the dullest company I could find it, where it has sat from that morning to this under everybody's hand and nobody's eye. I reported the holding corrected. It was, in the only sense the word ever truly carries in that house. I had made a true thing vanish without smoke.

I kept no record of the truth beside the lie. I want you to mark that, because it is the whole of what I have been. I did not write the real entry small somewhere safe against a better year; there was no safe place and there was to be no better year. The truth went where it has lived ever since, which is in me, and you, tonight, with the wine going down and the old man three floors under us asleep in his gout — you are the first ledger I have ever read it into.

The years after were slow and grey and I will not give them to you in detail, because little happened in them that the world would call happening. The plague burned itself out in the north and the roads opened and the trade limped back. Word came up from Florence that Galileo, the great vain man I had bought a spyglass from a lifetime ago in Padua, had printed a book at last that said the things he had spent thirty years not quite saying, and that Rome had noticed, and that there would be a reckoning — but the same quarantine that had held my chests in their shed held him in Tuscany a season and more, so that the summons to answer for it kept being a thing

that was going to happen and had not yet. The storm stood off the coast and would not come in. I shelved books and squared sums and made myself useful to the nephew, who valued me at exactly what I could be totalled at, and I waited, with everyone else, for the weather to break.

And I slept. That is the part I have never been able to get past, the small flat fact at the centre of it. I had stood at seventeen and watched them burn a man for the contents of his mind, and been ashamed for years that I came away dry-eyed; and now at seven-and-forty I had learned to do the thing the fire did — to take a mind off the shelves of the world — and do it with a pen and no flame and no crowd, so neatly that the man who ordered it never felt the paper, and I lay down that night and slept as sound as a paid soldier. The honest entries I had made of looted breviaries on a coast where I felt nothing had let me sleep. This one, the false one, the only kind thing I had done in twenty years and the most dishonest, let me sleep no worse. I have wondered ever since which of those two sleeps a man should fear more, and I think now it is the second, and I think I have always known it, and I think that is why, of all the books I have buried, this is the one I have made you sit up to hear about tonight.

Chapter Thirteen — A Matter of Record

In the June of 1633 the price of a single book in Rome did the thing I had spent my whole life watching prices do, and I will tell you plainly, because you should know the worst of me before you decide what the rest is worth: I felt the old pleasure of it before I felt anything else, and the pleasure is the part of that summer I have least forgiven.

The book was the *Dialogo* — Galileo's dialogue of the two great systems of the world, and in our own tongue, not Latin, mark that, but Tuscan, so that a notary or a barber or a clever woman who kept her husband's accounts might read it and follow the argument and put down the volume thinking she had been shown the floor of the world and found it moving under her. The same great vain man I had bought a spyglass from in Padua three-and-twenty years before had printed it at Florence the year previous, under licence, with the proper approvals on the proper leaves and an engraving at the front of three old philosophers standing about in conversation as though they had all the time in the world to settle it between them. I had handled a copy when it was new and lawful and dear enough at that — a clean folio, decently impressed, a little hurried in the gathering at the back as his work always was, the press of a man with somewhere to be. Lawful, it sold for what a good new folio sells for.

Then in the spring the thing was called in. The Holy Office wanted every copy back off every shelf in Christendom, and the Master of the Sacred Palace put it on the Index, and the Pope himself, Urban the Eighth, who had once been the man's friend and admirer and had let him dedicate the comets to him, turned and would not have his name in the same room as the book.

And the price doubled, and then it trebled, the way water finds its level — which is to say at once, and no one deciding it. I have told you the law of this trade more than once and I will not insult you by saying it again except to name the corner of it that took me that month: there is no review on earth that moves the better goods like a condemnation at Rome. A book the Index has not heard of is worth its paper. A book the Index has suspended is worth a small fortune to whoever can carry it where Rome's arm does not reach. The same word that strangled the thing in Italy made it gold

in Holland, and I knew six men between here and Amsterdam who would pay the gold, and I sat in my lodging that June with three copies I had not surrendered, and I priced them, and the pricing went sweet and easy in me, the trade running in its old grooves.

You are too young yet to be ashamed of your own competence. Wait. It comes.

They brought the man to Rome to make him take it back.

I had it first as I have always had everything, off the channels — the booksellers' talk, a Tuscan secretary's loose mouth over wine, the runners who carry prices and gossip in the one breath because in our trade they are the same commodity. He had come down from Florence in a litter in the worst of the heat, an old man of near seventy with the gravel and the gout and a terror of the road, summoned to answer for the book before the Congregation of the Holy Office, the same office, beyond the same river, under the same wall, that had handed a smaller and louder man to the fire when I was a boy. He had been lodged at his own Grand Duke's embassy and let to wait, and examined, and let to wait again, and the waiting was its own kind of question, and at the end of it the answer was never in doubt, because the answer to that office is never in doubt; only the date of it is uncertain, and the plague had moved even that, holding the roads and the couriers so that a thing which should have been finished the autumn before kept being a thing that had not happened yet. Now it would happen. They set the day, and the place, and I learned both before noon, and went.

I will tell you where I stood. Not inside. There was no inside to stand in for the likes of me — this was no burning in an open square with the whole city let in to watch and the front rank given out by the same hands that lit the pile; this was a small grave business done in a hall of the Dominicans at the Minerva, before the cardinals and the consultors and the clerks, with the doors kept. I stood in the piazza outside among the carriages and the people who knew, which was more people than you would think and fewer than there should have been. I was in the room, or near enough; near enough

has been my station at every fire of my life. I had it as it came out, in pieces — off faces, off a friar or two, off a grey-faced secretary of the embassy.

He had knelt. They had put him in the white shift of a penitent, the old man, the one who had named the moons of Jupiter for a prince to win a place at his table, and they had read him the sentence first and then had him kneel on the stone and say the words after — that he abjured, cursed, and detested his errors, that the earth stood still and the sun went round it as the Church and the Scripture held, that he had been vehemently suspected of heresy and was sorry for it and would never say such things again, by speech or by writing, and that if he knew any other who held them he would denounce the man to the Holy Office or to the ordinary of the place. He signed it. House arrest, the rest of his days; the book damned; and he was given back to his own people to be carried off to a bishop's house in the hills, alive.

No fire. That is the thing I want you to hold, because I have held it two-and-thirty years. The boy I had been stood in another square at seventeen and watched them fold a great voice back into a man with two fingers of linen and then burn what was left, and was ashamed afterward that he had come away dry. This was the same office and the same river and the same calm, and there was no fire at all. They did not need it. They had learned the cleaner thing, or perhaps they had always known it and the fire was only for the ones too stubborn to teach. You do not have to burn a man to take his mind off the shelves of the world. You have only to make him say, on his knees, in his own hand, signed, that the mind was never his.

And here is what I did, standing in that piazza in the June heat with the news coming out to me in grey faces. I priced it. God forgive me, the old craft did not so much as break its stride. While the man was on the stone a half-furlong off, I stood among the carriages and felt my mind go, of its own habit, to the three folios in my lodging and what this morning had just done to them — for a book the Pope had merely banned was gold, but a book whose author had knelt in a white shift and cursed it aloud before the cardinals was something rarer than gold, it was relic and scandal and forbidden fruit in one calf binding, and there was not a heretic press from Leyden to London that would not bid the moon for a clean copy now. I worked the sum before I had finished hearing the sentence. I caught myself

at it, my own hand already in my own pocket. At seventeen I had failed to weep. At fifty I had got past failing to feel anything so honest as grief; I had arrived at the place where a man's ruin came to me first as a movement in a price, and I stood in the sun and was ashamed in an altogether colder country than the old shame, and could not stop the sum from coming out.

It came out high.

I saw him two days after.

I had business at the Florentine embassy — the book again, always the book; a man of the household had a copy he wished gone to a buyer who would never be traced, and I was the discreet road that copy would take, and the discretion was the part they paid for. I went in by a side court in the cool of the morning before the heat stood up, and he was there.

He was in a chair in the loggia with a rug over his knees in June, set out in the early cool as the old are set out, and at first I did not know him. Three-and-twenty years is a long lease and he had not been a young man when I signed it. The deep chest had gone soft and fallen in on itself; the beard that had been going the colour of a dying fire when I knew it was white now, all through, and thin. But the eyes were his — heavy-lidded, half-shut, looking out from under the lids at a world he had always found a little slow — and when I came across the court his head came round and the lids lifted and there it was, the old mockery, undrowned.

A great ruin of a man, gouty, his right foot wrapped and propped and plainly hurting him in a way he meant everyone to know about; and laid along the arm of the chair, his right hand, and on it the thing my eye went to before it went anywhere, before his face, because my eye is my father's son and goes to the hands first and always has: the thumb, broad and flattened and shining at the ball of it, ground smooth by a lifetime of pushing glass across a grinding-lap. The thumb that had made the lens that made the moons that had won him the prince's table and the prince's table that had set him at last under this Pope's hand. It was all there in one old thumb, the whole road of him, and he caught me looking at it.

“They wished to know,” he said, by way of greeting, to a stranger, as if we had been mid-conversation an hour, “whether I had written the book to deceive. Whether I held the things in it.” His voice had thinned but it carried still, pitched to a back row that was not there. “I told them no. I told them I had written it as a speculation, a game of arguments, that I held nothing in it that the Church did not hold.” The lids came down and up. “They have my no in writing now. They were very anxious for the writing. Not the man, you understand — the paper. Give them the paper and they are content; they file the paper and the man may go to the devil or to Siena, it is all one to them so long as the paper says what they need it to say.” Satisfaction, almost, surfaced in the wreck of the face. “So I gave them the paper. The words cost me nothing. Let them have the words. The words are not the thing.”

I said nothing. There was nothing in me to say.

I want you to understand what I heard, because he did not hear it, and I have spent a great part of the years since turning it over. He had given them the paper and kept the thing, and the thing was the earth going round the sun. He had signed a lie, and the lie did not slow the earth by a hair; it went round whether he knelt and swore it still or not. He may even have been right that this was the part that mattered. But the truth was never what they were after, and that was the part he could not hear.

They did not want the man, and they did not want what he knew. They wanted the book brought to heel, and a book is brought to heel the day its own maker sets his hand to a sheet that says it lied. The same office had wanted the same thing of a louder man once, and had been able to get it only by fire, because the louder man would not sign. Here they had found the cheaper way: no smoke, no crowd, no twist of linen drawn between the teeth — a chair in a June loggia, an old man’s hand, and a paper that did the burning for them.

That was the thing I heard and he did not. Not that he had lost — that the fire I watched at seventeen had learned to do its work without lighting itself, and that I, who had spent the better part of my life carrying exactly the books power is afraid of and pricing them by the measure of its fear,

knew the machine when I heard it run. He sat easy in his consolation. I held my tongue.

I held my tongue because I had no standing to do otherwise. That is the second thing, and the harder.

Some men would have stood in that loggia and grieved that he had knelt — would have wanted the old fool to have stood up instead and spat the words back and gone to the fire whole, as the boy in me had once watched a man go and never quite forgiven the world for. I felt the want. I am telling you I felt it; I wanted him to have been braver than he was, this vain wrecked clever man, I wanted the century to have one in it who would not kneel. But I had no right to the wanting and I knew it standing there. What was I, that I should ask it of him? A man who had taken Rome's purse the whole of his life and never once been asked to kneel for it because I had been careful never to stand anywhere a man could be made to.

Three years before, in a cold room in this same city, I had been handed a book a thinner office wanted destroyed, and I had not stood up and refused, and I had not gone to any fire; I had given the record a lie and kept the thing in myself and called it thrift and slept. I had done in a quiet room with a pen the very trick he had just done on his knees on the stone — given them the paper, kept the thing, told myself the words were not the thing. The only difference between us was that no one had made me do mine in a white shift before the cardinals, and that is not a difference a man may take any pride in. It is only luck, and a good address.

So I did not grieve at him and I did not admire him. I stood in another man's loggia with a banned book waiting in my errand, and I looked at the ground-down thumb, and I felt the recoil go through me that I could not then have named — call it the turning of a stomach that has been fed one rich thing too many. I told myself it was the heat. I told myself it was disgust at his vanity, that a great man should sit in his ruin and preen about how cleverly he had surrendered. I told myself the trade had gone sour in my mouth, as trades do, and that I was tired, and old in the knees, and wanted my dinner. I did not tell myself the true thing, which was that I had just watched, in one June week, the office that lit the first fire of my life perfect the burning until it needed no smoke, and had watched the best mind of

the age help them do it to himself, and had stood by pricing the book — and that something in me, very far down, under the sums, had begun to want to be anywhere on the earth that was not this, anywhere a book was still being made instead of unmade, anywhere the asking of the question still paid out in the other direction.

I did not know I wanted it. You may believe that or not. A man can hold a thing that long and never look straight at it; I have held longer.

I sold the copy.

Not that one in the loggia — there was no copy there, only the man; I mean the embassy's, and after it my own three, that summer and the next, by the careful roads, to the careful buyers, north and out, at the price the kneeling had set, which was the highest price any book had brought me in Rome in my life. I did it well. I did it without a tremor. The coin came back along the same roads the books had gone, good Dutch and Hamburg silver, and I weighed it and entered it and it was clean money for clean work and it sat in my hand like any other money, and that, you understand, was the whole of the thing — that it sat like any other. I kept waiting through that handling for the sum to go bad on me as it had gone bad standing in the piazza, for the craft to falter at last, and it never did. The pricing had sickened me; the selling did not touch me at all. I had felt more, weighing a looted breviary on a coast where I told you I felt nothing, than I felt taking a fortune for the recantation of the only man of my age the world will still be saying its prayers to in five hundred years.

That is what I have to give you of that June. Not a fire — they had done with fire. A man on a stone in a white shift saying the words he did not mean so that the record would say them for him forever, and another man a half-furlong off totting the receipts, and neither of them, that I could see, on the side of the thing they had both spent their lives pretending to serve.

Tommaso had stopped writing some while before. He asked it with his eyes on the page, as he asks all the questions he is afraid of: whether the Persian's

notebook was still in this house. Mulla Sadra's. The one I had buried among the grammars.

It is, I told him. Third shelf of the grammars in the long room, where I put it five-and-thirty years ago. I entered it again for this catalogue, word for word, and you copied the line fair yourself in the autumn, in your best hand. *A scholar's exercise, Arabic, imperfect and of no account.*

He sat with that. I watched him go back through the autumn in his head and find the line, and find his own hand on it, and understand that he had written out a lie as clean as any in Christendom and been paid by the page for it. He asked whether I meant to strike it now.

No, I said. It is safer as a lie. A thing of no account is a thing no one comes looking for. Leave it as you wrote it.

He did not like it. He did not argue. He dipped his pen again, and I saw his hand stop over the ink a moment before it went in. It was the first time I had seen him mistrust his own pen.

He was carried off to the hills a few days later and I never saw him again; he died nine years on, blind by then, in a house outside Florence he was not let to leave, and the news came to me late and out of order on a road a long way east of Rome, as all my news came to me by then, and I marked it and went on. The *Dialogo* outlived him, as banned books do — dearer for being banned, smuggled north and read behind shut doors, not read freely in daylight as he had meant it to be. And I — I had a list to fill, and the list, as it happened, when next it came, pointed somewhere my lists had stopped pointing for three years; it pointed east, toward the old country of the trade, the places the books still came from, and I read it standing at the window in the going light and felt, under the tiredness, a thing I took for nothing but the simple wish of an aging man to be out of a city that had gone cold for him, and was glad of the excuse, and began, without once asking myself why, to think about the road.

Chapter Fourteen — The Last Crossing

Twelve years I had lived on the south bank of that river, and another twelve I had stayed away from it, and the staying away was not an accident.

When I came home to Rome the second time — the nephew's accounting closed, the false line written into the catalogue, my knees beginning their long argument with stairs — I turned east again, because east was where the books were and because a man of fifty does the thing his hands already know how to do. But I did not turn toward Isfahan. For eight years I worked the old roads and kept off the one that ran to her door. I bought in the Aleppo houses and in the Greek islands and once, badly, off a seller in Tabriz who knew my eye was going before I did; I sent word and list and silver west to Cardinal Ottavio, the nephew, who kept me in his ledger as a figure he could name to the soldo; and every season, when the caravans formed for the Persian plateau, I found a reason to be somewhere the caravans were not.

I had promised to come back. I had said it in her counting-room with three thousand miles of road in front of me — before two winters were out — and I had meant it, as you mean such things while the saying is still free. The trouble with that kind of promise is that keeping it and breaking it are one act, only delayed: to go back was to choose, and I had spent a long life learning never to stand anywhere a man could be made to choose. So I stayed away and called it the press of business. The business was real. It was not the reason.

What put me over the passes at last was a sheet of Ottavio's paper, come east in the spring in that ruled chancery hand where no ink ever pooled at a turn a feeling might have pressed. There was a prince in the country of the Mughal, the cardinal wrote — Ottavio's people had it from the Jesuits, who had it from the merchants, who had it from everyone. A young prince of the reigning house, rich past the telling of it, who did not gather provinces, as princes do, but books: who kept Brahmins and Mussulman Sufis and the Portuguese fathers at his own table and paid them to lay their scriptures beside one another and reason out which held the older truth; who sent men out to run down the hidden scriptures of the Hindus and the locked-away books of the Persian mystics, and who would buy, it was said, at any

price a man cared to name, the very things the mullahs would sooner see on a fire.

Rome wished to know what he was gathering. Rome wished, if it could be done quietly, to gather some of it first. And the road to that prince ran through Isfahan — because every road east runs through somebody's door — and I read the sheet in an Aleppo back room and understood that I had just been handed the reason I had spent eight years failing to find, and that it would carry me across her threshold whether I willed it or not.

I will not pretend to you it read to me as a commission only. I had spent forty years going to the places where books came loose, and books come loose where a throne is falling; that was the whole of my trade, the one law under all the others. I went to the fire, after, and bought what it had not finished. And here was a square of paper telling me that somewhere east of every road I knew there stood a throne doing the opposite of every throne I had served — a throne that paid for the forbidden thing instead of burning it, that gathered the books my whole century had been built to suppress and set them in the light on a prince's table.

I had watched a man burn for far less. I had watched the cleverest mind of the age kneel on a stone and sign that his mind was never his, and I had stood half a furlong off and totted the receipts. Eight years that kneeling had been working in me as damp works in a wall, out of sight, and here was the thing it had been working toward: the chance to stand, once, before I died, in a place where the asking of the question paid out in the other direction.

I wanted to see it. I wanted it as you want to see a thing you have been told your whole life cannot exist. That is not a noble wanting. But it was mine, and it was stronger than I was, and I knew it for exactly what it was when I roped the load onto the mule.

So I crossed the bridge into New Julfa on a hot blue afternoon at the end of the summer of 1641 — a man of eight-and-fifty with white come into the hair at his temples and a sight grown long, so that a letter had to be held off at arm's length before the lines would sit still and be one thing. The bridge was as I had left it: the long brick spans, the town laid sideways

on the water, the Armenian houses turning blank walls to the street and keeping their gardens for the inside. The river ran low under the arches. Children were out on the weed-flat stones. I had spoken nothing but Latin and Italian and worse Greek for years, and the Persian came back into my mouth on the bridge, the words waiting where I had set them down, a road remembered under the feet.

The house of Khoja Sarkis had a green still tank in its court and a hush of musk and ledgers, and I had called it my harbour for twelve years, and the man it was named for was dead. A servant I did not know told me at the door — the old ones gone, or grown past my knowing them — that the Khoja had lain three years under the floor of the Armenian church, and that the house was the daughter's now. I had known he would be old. I had not let myself reckon how old. He had poured me a Persian wine better than anything my cardinals ever let me steal, and closed our last bargain with the merchant's grip, palm and thumb, and now he was three years gone and the news of it had never once found me, because I had given no road my direction to send it down.

Marjan came into the court with a ledger still open in her hand, because she had been told a Frank was asking and had not been told which Frank. She stopped on the bottom step when she saw.

I knew her hands before I knew the rest of her, my father's son to the last and always quickest at the hands — stained walnut-brown to the wrist and down into the creases of the knuckles, the copyist's ink no washing has ever taken, and they were the same hands, only the skin a little loose over them now and a swelling come into one joint that had not been there. The rest had taken the years as a strong-built woman takes them. Grey was run all through the dark of her hair; the wide-set eyes had gone a degree deeper into the bone; the briskness I had once misread as coldness had hardened into plain authority; she had buried her father and not let the house drop a single stitch in the doing of it. She was three-and-forty. She looked at me as she had always looked at me, all the way to the back wall and out the far side of it, and she did not put the ledger down.

I will give you the next days quickly, because they were good, and because their goodness is the thing that makes the rest of it cost what it cost; to

linger over them would only be to ask you to be sorry for me, and I have not earned that and do not want it. We fell back into the old work as though no part of twelve years had passed. She had the house's books open and I had an eye that still, whatever the long sight had stolen, could date a binding by the give of its spine and read a copy off a copy by the errors carried forward and corrected in a second ink. We sat over her tables in the musk-and-ledger hush, and I told her what eastern paper fetched in Rome now, and she told me where the silk-money had gone soft and which Julfa houses were lending past their sense, and it was the truest thing I have ever had of another soul — that hour, and a hundred like it, two hard readers of the world who needed, for once, to keep nothing back from one another.

And under it, from the first afternoon, she knew. She had it off me before I said a word of it — off the road-dust I had not troubled to wash away in any settled fashion, off the mule still loaded in the court, off the plain fact that I had come to her house and not come home to it. She let it lie. That was the mercy, if you want to call it one, and she would never have called it that: she let the good days run and said nothing, and kept the knowing folded in her hand like a draft she had not yet decided to present.

It was in those days I learned that Mulla Sadra was dead — the old teacher of the Qom road, the denounced philosopher whose cramped little notebook I had carried across the world and buried in a lie among the cardinal's grammars. I asked after him idly, as you ask after a place you once bought well in, and Marjan told me he had died the year before on the road to Mecca, an old man let alone at the last, his school scattered into a dozen careful mouths or gone silent altogether. I had hidden his reasoning under a false line to keep it off a fire, and now the mind that made it was under the ground of some hajj-road town, and the two facts sat side by side in me and I could not have said which of them was the burial. I marked it, and went on. There is a great deal of going on in a long life. It is most of what the trade teaches a man to do.

She broke it open on the eighth night.

We had the lamp between us and the ledgers shut for once, and she had poured the good wine — her father's, still down in the cellar — and she set

it down and did not drink, and said, flatly, as she had always given the hard facts: "Tell me about the prince."

So I told her. I told it as I had been telling it to myself — a commission, a rich young Mughal who collected forbidden books, a discreet matter of getting Rome some of what he gathered before the mullahs got him; a season's work, two at the outside, the richest manuscript-country on the earth and a buyer who paid instead of burned. I heard my own voice making it small and reasonable as it went, and I heard her not believing the smallness, and somewhere in the middle of it I stopped dressing the thing and told her the rest, because she was the one person alive I had never been able to keep my face shut to. That I wanted to see it. That after Rome, after what I had done in Rome with a pen and watched done on a stone, I needed to stand once in a place where a throne paid for the truth instead of feeding it to the fire — and that I did not know how many seasons a man of my years had left to stand anywhere at all.

She heard me out. Then she priced it, as she had priced my whole proud first season to the abbasi twelve years before, and the pricing was exact, and it was without mercy.

"A prince who buys what the mullahs would burn," she said. "You have told me what you are, more times than you have known you were telling me. You go where the house is falling. You are there when things end. And now you have found yourself a prince who loves the forbidden books, and you have crossed two seas to carry them out of the burning yourself — except this fire has not caught yet, so you will have the rare pleasure of standing by to watch it start." She turned the cup a quarter where it stood and did not lift it. "I have heard of your prince. They come, in that country. The blood throws one up every reign or two — a man who would sooner own a book than a province — and they are loved, and they are brilliant, and they are always, always the one the careful brother is already sharpening the knife for. You will buy well at his court. And then you will bury him, and buy his library off the cart while it is still warm, and ship it west, and sleep."

A dead Roman had said very nearly the same to me on the Gulf road twenty years before — that princes who love books that much always come to grief, and grief was my harvest. I had thought it a fine bitter line at the time, and

filed it with the other fine lines. In her mouth it was not a line. It was a thing she had watched happen to a city, with her own house carried away inside it.

She did not ask me to stay. I have turned that over for four-and-twenty years — that the one woman who said everything, who had never in her life left a true thing unspoken to spare anybody, looked at me across her father's lamp and did not say the single word that would have cost me most to refuse. She did not even put her hand out on the table between us, palm down, as she had twice before, for me to take or leave; she had read, before I had, that to ask would only hand me a thing to be brave against, and she would not give me the comfort of something to refuse. She gave me instead the thing she did best.

"You have never once wanted a thing you could keep," she said. "Listen to your own list. The book already in the fire. The man already on the stone. The question they have already forbidden. You do not love what is in front of you; you love the thing being carried out of the room, and you go across the world to stand near it while it goes. I knew it the first season you came over my bridge, and I let you come over it anyway, and that is my account to settle, not yours." She did not raise her voice; she never did. "So go to your prince. But do not stand in my house and tell me it is for a season, and do not tell me you are coming back, because I have a far better eye than yours for the things that do not."

I had had the words ready in my mouth even so — two winters, before two winters were out, the small honest-seeming coin I had spent in that very room once before and very nearly believed. She had taken it out of my hand before I could spend it, and she was right to: it was counterfeit, and we both knew the mint.

And here is the worst of me, and I have made you sit up a long time to reach it, so I will not soften it now. She was right about all of it, and that was the unbearable part — not that she raged at me, for she had got past rage to the colder and finer thing, which is understanding. She had seen me to the back wall, and what she found there she did not flinch from and did not forgive and did not trouble to forgive, because she was not asking me to be

anything other than what I was. She was naming what I was, exactly, and letting me go and be it.

I did not stay. I did not even argue for the staying, because we were neither of us amateurs at weights and the scale was not close. I knew precisely what I was choosing and what it would cost: a living woman who had seen the whole of me and meant me no harm, lifted off the table for a story about a prince and a library three months east. I knew it was the very thing the thrones do — Abbas had moved her whole city for a want of state, and I was moving her for a want of my own, and there was no clean line between us but that I could do mine to one soul at a time.

And under the knowing, not even decently behind it, I felt the old pull east already out ahead of me, counting the road. The guilt and the draw came up together, in the one breath, and the draw was the stronger. That is the thing I have never been able to tell you I did not feel.

There were no words left worth the saying. I stood, and she stood, and I put my arms around her, because there was nothing else honest left to do with my hands — and for the space of one breath she held me harder than she ever let herself hold anything, and there was the word she would not speak, said in the only register she would allow it. Then her hands opened and set me a step away, as you set down a book whose account is closed, and the warmth went back under the exactness where she always kept it. She took up the ledger again, because the house did not stop needing its figures kept on account of a man leaving it. “I am sorry,” I said, which was the only true thing I had and was not much; and I did not add to it the *I will do what I can* I had meant to, because she had just shown me, to the last coin, what that was worth. She did not answer. I sat a while longer in a room I would not sit in again, and then I went out to see about the mule.

I left over the same bridge the next morning, the other way, eastward, with the load and the commission and the first cold of the autumn coming down off the plateau. The children were gone from the stones. The river ran a little higher for a rain in the night.

I told you once, a long way back, on the night of the Gulf road, that a man may leave a thing lightly twenty times and discover on the twenty-first that

he has been in training. I had left her before — left the house, left the city, ridden off easy and certain it would all keep where I had set it down. Every one of those easy goings, I understand now, had been practice for this one: the leaving that was not light at all, the one all the others had been teaching my body how to perform. I crossed the bridge and I did not look back at the house. I was very good at not looking back. I had made my first study of it at a fire when I was seventeen, and it was the most practiced thing I owned.

And on the road — I tell you this because you are young and ought to know what a man is — on the road east, inside the first day, I began telling myself I would come back.

Not in those words. I was too old, and had been too plainly answered, for those words. But as a man builds a future to make a present bearable: the prince's business was a season, two at the most; I would buy well, and ship west, and on the turn I would route myself home through Isfahan, and the house would be standing, and she would be at her figures, and there would be time enough. I built it on the mule's back as the plateau opened cold and brown ahead of me, the whole careful architecture of the return, plank by plank — and the part of me that had always kept the better eye stood off a little and watched me build, and knew the thing for a ruin before the first board was laid, and said nothing, and let me go on building. I carried that return in me the whole way to the sea, and a good way out onto it.

You asked me, the first night you sat down here, what the book was — the brown one with the soft spine and the salt-stain along the foot of it, the one that is in no catalogue. I have been a long while getting to it, and we are not there yet; there are years and a war between this bridge and that book.

But you should understand, before we go any further east, the make of the man you are spending your nights to listen to. I have told you I knew what I was doing on that bank. I want you to believe it, because it is the one thing in the whole of this I am entirely sure of. I was no boy carried off by a marvel. I was eight-and-fifty; I had borne one man's mind across the world and hidden it in a lie; I had watched another sign his own away and stood by adding the column; and I knew, better than any man then living, what a throne does to the thing it loves and to the people who make the mistake of standing near it.

And I crossed that bridge anyway, and left the one soul who ever saw the whole of me to keep her dead father's house alone, for the rumour of a prince and a roomful of books I had not laid eyes on. She did not curse me and she did not plead; she understood me, to the bone, and let me go — and a man can make a sort of peace with being hated, given years enough, but I have never found the place in me to lay down the memory of being understood that completely and going anyway.

I do not ask you to forgive it. I have not managed it myself in four-and-twenty years, and I am a more practiced forgiver of my own faults than most men you will meet. I never saw her again. What word of her reached me at the end, and how late it came, and on what road I was standing when it did — that is for a colder night than this one. We will come to it. You will wish we had not.

Chapter Fifteen — The Counting-House

He had the eastern letters out across his knees when he asked me — that fat packet of Jesuit relations the elder Vitelleschi bought by the bale and shelved unread, missionary news out of Goa and Malabar and farther, China at the bottom of it, the ink gone brown and the paper foxed with a damp that was not Roman damp and had crossed two oceans to get here. Tommaso turned the leaves leaning over them, shielding them with his shoulder as though somebody behind him meant to snatch them, and he stopped at the China sheets, which were in a clerk's good Latin and full of mandarins.

"They gave him a rank," he said. He had been reading without my leave again, which I let him do because a boy who steals reading is the only kind worth hiring. "The German father in Peking — Schall, the letter calls him — the one who reckons their calendar for them. They put him over a board of astronomers and gave him a — what is this — a button of coral, and a court grade, for telling the Emperor of China the truth about the heavens." He looked up at me with the whole of his face open, the question already on it before he found the words for it. "Was there ever such a place? One that paid a man for the truth instead of burning him for it. Did you ever come on one, in all that going about?"

I did not answer him directly, because the honest answer was that I thought I had once, in a back room in the wet, with a packet very like the one across his knees — and that I had been wrong, and that he would have to sit through a good deal of candle before I would let him have the wrongness. So I told him to put the letters down and mind the foxing, and I started him somewhere else.

"You have the parallel half made," I said, "so make the rest of it. Peking gives its star-reader a coral button and a seat at the council. Rome gave hers a penitent's shift and a chair in a hill house he was not let to leave, and called it mercy." I had told him Galileo by then; he had the kneeling already.

He had it in a breath, the little wretch. "Then the cheaper road for a natural philosopher," he said, weighing it with that printer's gravity he puts on, "runs east. The Holy Office might have spared its firewood and written him a passage to the Indies." And he sat back, pleased, having jumped the whole

distance I had laid out for him and landed on both feet on the far side, and waited to be laughed at.

I did not laugh. A boy's joke is a coin he has minted himself, and you do not test it with your teeth in front of him; you let it pass at face. But I let the corner of it stand between us, and poured the wine, and his Eminence three floors under us slept through the whole transaction.

I learned afterwards, as one learns everything out of China, a year late: that same winter, while the boy sat reading me that letter by my brazier, Schall lay in chains in Peking — an old man by then, struck half dumb by a stroke — condemned by the new throne's own court to be cut to pieces, for the calendar that had won him the button. An earthquake shook the city the week of the sentence, and they took it for a sign and let him go, and he died the year after. The throne had not changed its mind about the stars. It had changed its mind about the man.

I came down onto India in the wet of 1642, an old Frank of nine-and-fifty with his knees full of the sea, off the tail of the Gulf shipping that runs with the season and will not run against it. You do not choose your month for that crossing; the wind chooses it, and you wait at Gombroon until it turns and then you go, three weeks and more of an open green water that is nothing at all like the Mediterranean's, heavier, warmer, breathing, and you fetch up at the sandbar off Surat in a rain that does not fall so much as stand in the air and wait for you to walk into it.

I will tell you what Surat was, because you will have a notion of the Indies got off the same Jesuit letters, all spice and idols and kings on elephants, and it is a false weight and you should set it down. Surat was a customs house. It was the busiest mouth on that whole coast and it was a customs house first and everything else after — a brown river full of country boats, a bar the great ships could not cross so that everything came ashore on lighters with the rest of the ship's cargo, a press of brokers and money-changers and lading-clerks thick as the Rialto on a war morning, and over all of it the Mughal's officers, who weighed and stamped and taxed every bale that breathed and were not to be hurried by any Christian alive. The

smell was river-mud and rope and the particular reek of indigo in the vats, and bullock-dung smoke, and the rain. No incense. I never in my life smelt the incense the letters promised; I smelt customs, which smells the same in every port God made.

My consignment came ashore on the lighters with the rest and went, by the practice of the place, into a godown — a warehouse; the word means only a warehouse, do not let it sound eastern at you — under the eye of the English, who had the largest factory — their trading-house — in the town and the longest reach in it after the Mughal himself. And there it stopped. And I went to get it loose, and met the throne that holds that country, which is not the one in the letters either.

His name was Greaves, a factor of the English Company, and I want you to see him because he is the whole argument of that month standing in one sweating skin. He was young for what he carried, sandy, his fair English hide gone the raw pink of a thing that peels and peels and never browns, sat in a low dim room behind a table with a ledger squared to its edge and an inkstand squared to the ledger, and he was wearing wool. Good Norwich broadcloth in a country that stood at blood heat and rained warm rain, because the cloth was what a factor wore and to put it off was to put off his rank, and so he sat in it and ran with sweat and squared his papers and dabbed his lip with a cuff already grey at the edge from the same office, and he was, I promise you, the most powerful man I should deal with between the Gulf and Agra.

“There are charges,” he told me, in the trade-Portuguese every European on that coast falls back on when the Latin runs thin. Freight he named, and a warehouse due, and a thing he called the Company’s precedence, all of it courteous and none of it movable, the figures coming off him in that flat clerk’s music of a sum already decided, the conversation only its echo. He had looked at me coming in — an old Frank, alone, no factory at his back, no guns in the road — and he had priced me as a stray, and put a stray’s number on the dues, and squared his ledger over it, and waited.

I knew the number was invented as I had known at seventeen that a misquoted price is audible by the reasons it cannot give. He could not tell me why the Company’s precedence reached a parcel of Persian books that

had cleared the Mughal's own customs on the Mughal's own stamp. He named the figure; he could not show me the floor it stood on.

I did not argue it with him that day. You do not win the first conversation in a customs war; you only learn the lie of the ground, and I had learned it, and I went off into the rain to where the Europeans of that town went when they wanted to hear their own tongues, which was the Jesuit house.

The padre there was a Portuguese named Bernardo, out of the Goa province, and he was the factor's opposite in every part, which is the thing I carried away from that month more than any book. Where Greaves fought the country with wool and a ledger, Bernardo had surrendered to it entirely and was the easier man for it — lean, dark-baked, dried down to cord and sinew, gone the colour of his own cassock, which was a Goa cotton patched at both elbows by a hand that had given up on the broadcloth a Lisbon father would have died in. Ink on his fingers to the second joint, from copying; a tremor of old fever under the ink. He was starved for a literate ear, as one is starved at sea for anything fresh and green, and he fell on my Latin and my trade-Portuguese both, and gave me wine that had crossed from Portugal and turned on the voyage and was the worse for every league of it, and talked.

And among the talk he brought out his letters, because a lonely man brings out his treasure, and his treasure was the China correspondence — the relations that came down the Jesuits' own road, Macao to Goa to here, of the fathers at the court of Peking. He set Adam Schall before me on the brown paper: the German, Schall von Bell. The Emperor's own astronomers had watched that sky longer than anyone on earth — the comets and the eclipses written down since before there was a Rome — but their tables for predicting an eclipse had drifted and were failing, and Schall brought them newer methods that worked where the old ones had stopped. For that the Emperor sent him a tablet in his own hand, praising his learning of the heavens. I wanted it to be more than it was — a throne paying in honour for the very thing Rome had broken Galileo's knees over nine years before. It was less than that. What Schall taught the Chinese was how to foretell

an eclipse, not that the earth went round the sun; that last his order was forbidden to teach in Peking exactly as in Rome. The throne paid him for the part it could use.

I took it as goods, as I take everything; and under the appraisal I felt the old sweet pull of it, I will not pretend I did not; here on a Jesuit's foxed paper was the thing I had crossed two seas half-believing could not exist, a throne that bought the forbidden article instead of burning it, and the wanting of it to be true rose in me as it rises in any buyer when the seller at last names the thing he has dreamed of owning. That is exactly when a man overpays.

So I will tell you the flaw I saw and discounted, because I did see it; I have never been able to let myself off by pretending I did not. The letters were old. They are always old — China is a year and more away by the fathers' own road — but these had a date on them that sat wrong against the news the same packet carried up from the southern provinces, which was all of rebellion, of the inland falling, of the dynasty that had set Schall over its stars going to pieces under him while he reckoned its calendar. The throne that paid for the truth was itself coming down. I held the two leaves side by side, the honour and the falling, and I knew — the dealer knew, the part of me that dates a thing by the give of its spine — that an honour is only worth the house that grants it, and that here was a tablet of praise being handed out by a hand already losing its grip on the sword. I marked it. And then I wanted the hope more than I wanted the caution, and I set the second leaf under the first, and let the tablet outshine the rebellion, and went on. A wiser man would have taken it the other way. I was sixteen years from being made to.

Bernardo, for his part, gave me the road I had come for without my asking it, because lonely men are generous and because the thing was no secret to anyone but a newcomer. I had spoken of going up-country, of the great book-markets, of the rumour I had crossed the world on — the Mughal prince who gathered scholars and bought what the mullahs would burn. The padre knew him by name; the Goa fathers had corresponded with him, had sat at his table, hoped and despaired of him by turns.

"Dara Shikoh," he said, and crossed himself, though whether for hope or for warning I could not then tell. "The King's eldest. He will have Jesuits and

Brahmins and the Sufi shaikhs all at one cushion and set them to find the same God under their three books, and he pays the copyists like a man who has never had to ask the price of anything, because he has not.” A working of the dried face; affection and pity in the one muscle. “Go up to him, then, and sell him your Persians. He buys. God keep him; the careful brother is counting every soul he seats.”

I went back to Greaves with the floor under me that I had gone away to find.

I did not catch him in a forgery; there was no fraud in him to catch — that is the error I would have looked for once, and the wrong tool for this throne. Greaves was not a cheat. He was a clerk applying a precedence that did not exist, to a stray he judged could not gainsay it, and what undid him was a jurisdiction — the plain map of who taxed what in that port. I laid it out for him in his own flat register, no heat in it. The books had cleared the Mughal customs under the Mughal seal; the dues were paid where dues were owed, to the officers of the port, whose stamp I set on the table between us. The Company’s godown was a convenience I had used and would pay the honest rent of, to the cowrie. The Company’s precedence over a foreigner’s lawful goods, cleared through the King’s own house, in the King’s own town — that he could not show me, because it was not there, and we both came, in the same minute, to know that we both knew it.

He could have brazened it another week. He chose not to, and I will tell you why, because it is the part worth your keeping. I did not let him lose. Beat a clerk flat, in his own office, over his own ledger, and you have made an enemy of a counting-house you must pass through every year of your trade, and that is a fool’s economy; a counting-house has a long memory and a longer arm. So I left him a door. I had crossed out of Persia three weeks before him in news; I knew what the Gulf prices were doing, what the Dutch were lifting and what the Armenians, where the Persian silk-silver had gone soft — a season of intelligence worth more to a young factor’s standing with his President than the invented dues of one stray Frank could ever be. I traded it to him for my consignment and the honest rent, and let him write the release as though it were a courtesy he extended rather than

a corner he had been backed into, and he took the door, and squared his ledger over it, and we parted something near to friends. I have found that a beaten man dressed afterward in a favour will carry your goods cheaper for ten years than one you have only paid.

That was the throne. Not a tribunal, not a fire; a low room and a ledger squared to its edge and a sweating clerk applying a rule that was only as true as your ignorance of it. The English did not burn the books. They invoiced them. And it came to me, going back out into the standing rain with my release in my coat, that of all the powers I had carried books past in forty years this was the newest thing and perhaps in the end the largest — a throne that did not care in the least what was written in the cargo, that would as soon ship a Bible as a Brahmin's scripture as a bale of pepper, and weigh all three by the hundredweight, and tax them the same. There was no fear in it anywhere. The Holy Office at least feared what it burned. The counting-house feared nothing, because to the counting-house a book was never anything but freight.

I had the eastern sea to myself by then, or near it. Vautier — that perfumed article I promised you, Richelieu's man with the heavier purse and the worse eye — Vautier had never come so far, and never would; his purse went out as far as Isfahan, once, years back, and turned for home at the edge of a map it could not read. The whole of the East past Isfahan was mine to buy in, unbid against, and a younger Niccolò would have called that a triumph and totted what it was worth. I was old enough that month to feel, under the triumph, how much country I had put between myself and everything I might have stayed for, now that no rival would follow me into it.

I posted no letter west. I told myself I would route home through Isfahan on the turn, when the prince's business was done — a season, two at the most — and the house would be standing and she at her figures, and I built that return again on the road up from the coast, board by board, the same hopeful carpentry, and the part of me that prices things stood off and said nothing and let me build. I was the better part of two years in and out of that port before the road north truly opened to me — a wet season to sit out and then a dry one, the caravans slow to form, the rumour of the prince hardening by degrees into an address. There were the passes to Agra ahead,

and a prince at the end of them who paid like one who had never asked a price. I went up to find him.

Chapter Sixteen — The Prince Who Would Not Count the Cost

Agra in the dry season was dust and the smell of dust — dust off the river-flats, dust beaten up from the roads by every bullock and every barefoot porter, dust gone pink in the evening and grey by full dark, settling on the figs and the inkpots and the backs of my hands while I haggled. You will have it off the same letters that lied to me about Surat, all marble and gardens and a king weighed against gold; and the marble was there, I do not deny the marble, and the gardens, and a court that could spend a province on a wedding. But a book-buyer does not live at the wedding. He lives in the lane behind it, where the paper is sold and copied and faked, and that lane in Agra smelled of dust and size and the hot brass of the binders' tools, and it was the richest such lane on the earth, and I had crossed the earth to stand in it.

I was two-and-sixty by then, and the road up from the coast had found out the rest of what the sea had left. My knees had opinions about the mounting-block now that they aired each morning. A folio had to go out to the full reach of my arm before the lines would hold still and be letters; close work I did with a lens a Venetian had ground me a dozen years before, and blessed his greedy soul for it daily. But Persian was in my mouth as if I had never set it down — the court's own tongue, the tongue of every clerk and broker and prince's man from here to the passes — and an old Frank who could dispute a collation in good Persian and pay in good silver was a creature the lane had a use for, alien as I was. I had not written west. I told myself the prince's business was a season, two at the most, that I would turn home through Isfahan when it was done; and I let that keep me company up the road as it had kept me company across the water, and the appraiser in me walked a little apart and held his peace.

Of the prince I heard first as one hears of any great buyer — through what his buying did to the prices. The Surat Jesuit had given me his name — Dara Shikoh, the King's eldest son — and a house that gathers at any price spoils a market for everyone under it, and his had been spoiling Agra's for years. Copyists who would once take a fair wage now named a prince's wage and stood on it. A manuscript come down to a learned pandit from

his grandfather, that should have changed hands for forty rupees, changed hands for four hundred because word was the prince's people were in the lane and might want it. I have stood in a dozen cities and read the local power off the price of paper, and the paper in Agra told me there was a hand above this market that did not push back when a figure was too high — that liked, even, to be charged too much, the one appetite a dealer never expects to meet and never quite trusts when he does.

I came at him sideways, through the trade, as I have come at everything. His establishment kept a karkhana — call it his book-house, his workshop; a long airy set of rooms off one of the garden courts where forty men ruled paper and ground lapis to powder and laid gold and copied and bound, and where the things he hunted came first to be judged before they went up to him.

I had never seen the like, and I had watched the Vatican's own copyists at their desks. The work ran from first light in the cool of the court: a row of calligraphers cross-legged on cotton, reed pens going in a sound like rain on leaves; a boy burnishing a finished page with an agate till it threw back the light like water; another grinding lapis in a stone dish for the blue that outcosts the gold laid beside it; a smell of size and lampblack and the sharp green of crushed verdigris, and over all of it the river-dust sifting down, so that a leaf left out an hour wore a grey skin you blew off before you judged it. A prince's money had raised a manufactory of beauty, and it turned out beauty by the score, on a wage, as the Arsenal at Venice turned out galleys.

The judging fell to a Persian secretary named Mir Salih, dry and overworked, with a wax-coloured scholar's squint and inkstains worked so far into his fingers that washing was a courtesy he had abandoned. He had more coming in than he had eyes for, and he was being cheated, gently and constantly, by every seller who knew Dara paid like the sea.

I did him a courtesy the first morning, unasked, because it cost me nothing and bought me everything. He had a Shahnama open on the table, sold to him that week as a Herat book of the old time, a hundred and fifty years if a day, and priced to match; and I held it out at my arm's length where my eyes could work, and turned the leaves, and told him in Persian what the paper told me. The burnish was wrong for Herat. The hand was a good

hand imitating an older one, and tiring, as a forger's hand tires, three slips repeated out of some parent copy and one of them patched over in a fresher ink, the copier knowing it was wrong and hoping no one would look. It was not old. It was old enough to fool a busy man and young enough to have been made, very likely, in this same lane, this same year, by somebody's cousin.

I did not call it a fraud. I named no seller; that is not my trade, and to hunt cheats is to make yourself feared and then friendless. I only dated the thing true, and let Mir Salih draw the rest himself, and watched him do the sum behind the squint — the figure he had been about to pay, the figure it was worth, the difference, and the old Frank who had handed him the difference across a table for nothing. He had it in a breath. He was no fool; he had only too much paper and too few hours. He poured me tea I did not want and asked me, in the flat under-voice of a man already settling on how to use me, what else I had carried up from the Franks.

What I had carried up was a Bible. Not a working Bible — a great engraved folio out of the Low Countries, the text in four tongues set in columns and a copper plate facing every chapter, Adam naming the beasts and the Red Sea standing up in walls, the whole of it bound in tooled calf that had weathered two sea-crossings in oilcloth and come through with only a salt-bloom along one board. I had bought it in Aleppo years before for exactly this — not for a churchman, who would have it cheaper from Rome, but for some eastern grandee who would never have seen the Frankish gospel made so heavy and so fine. I had been carrying it a long time, waiting for the right door. It is the dealer's oldest patience: you hold the key years before you find the lock.

Mir Salih looked at it for a long while, turning the plates out to the light, and then he did not name a price. He said the heir would want to see it himself, and that the prince saw whom he pleased and not whom his secretaries pleased, and that I should hold myself ready and tell no one I was waiting. Then he gave me back the Bible to carry, which told me more about how that house ran than a month of asking would have — Dara trusted no steward's eye on a thing he might love, and wanted the loving done in his own person.

He sent for me eight days on, in the last hour of the afternoon, which I learned later was his hour for the things he did for himself and not for the empire.

He was younger than I had built him — they are always younger; I was old enough now that princes and popes alike had begun to look like clever boys to me — slender, narrow through the shoulder, in pale silks that had never met a day's hard use, with a rope of pearls at his throat worth more than every book in the room together. The face was fine and quick and made for liking and being liked; he smiled before he had any reason to, never once in his life refused and so never taught that a face can be a wall. And his hands — I am my father's son, and I know a man by his hands before his mouth — his hands were soft, uncalloused, unmarked, the nails kept; hands that had never bound a quire nor counted a strongbox nor pulled a rope nor, I thought, been closed into a fist that landed. Beautiful, useless, generous hands. I had spent my life among hands that told you what their owner had paid. His told you he had never been asked to pay anything, and did not know the word.

He spoke to me in Persian, courteous as an equal, which no cardinal had ever troubled to be, and he went at the Bible like a starved man at bread. He knew more than I expected and more, I think, than was good for him. He had the plates open and was reading the Latin column against the others, quick and sure, and he stopped at a place in the prophets and put his soft finger on the Frankish word and the Arabic word and asked me whether I did not think the two scriptures were here saying the one thing in two clothes — and he was right, they were, and I had handled that book for years and never seen it, because I am a dealer and read a book by its spine and its errors and not by its God. He had gone straight past the price of the thing to the meaning of it. That is a prince's luxury, to be able to.

Then he bought it, and I learned what they had meant in the lane.

I named him a fair price. I am a thief by trade, but I had taken his measure by then and judged that the long game with this house was honesty, so I named him a price a hard Aleppo buyer would have grudged but paid — high, and just. He waved it off as you wave off smoke. He named me three times the figure, smiling, pleased with himself, pleased with me, pleased

with the morning, as though the joy of the having could not decently be bought for so little and he was ashamed on my behalf at the smallness of my asking. I have been overpaid before, by fools and by men buying my silence. This was neither. He simply did not know what things cost, had never had to know, and found the not-knowing a pleasure — to scatter silver and watch faces open. The copyists loved him for it. Half of Agra loved him for it. I stood there with three times my price coming to me and felt, under the dealer's plain gladness, the first cold draught of the thing I had crossed the world to see and had not once thought to be frightened of.

For a man who will not count the cost of a book will not count the cost of anything. I knew it standing there with his silver in my hand, the same minute I pocketed the profit. The habit that made him beloved was the habit that would kill him, and they were not two habits but one, and there was no taking the one and leaving the other.

He proved it to me himself before the hour was out, and he proved it carelessly, which is the only way that habit is ever proved.

There was another man in the room. I had marked him on the way in and then forgotten him, as you forget furniture — an older man in plain dark cloth off to the side, a court qazi or a mullah of some standing, sent up on some matter of law and waiting his turn with the patience of the orthodox, who own eternity and can spare an afternoon. He sat still and said nothing and missed nothing. And Dara, glowing over his new Bible, turned the great Red Sea plate to the light and said — to me, to the room, to the pleasure of his own quick mind — that it was a fine foolishness, was it not, that men killed one another over which book held God, when plainly the books were translations one of another, the same water under different names, and that a wise throne would gather them all and set them side by side and read the one truth out from under the many tongues, instead of burning the half it had not troubled to learn.

He said it lightly. He said it as you say a thing you have said a hundred times at your own table among friends who applaud. And I, who had come all that ruinous way to find exactly such a throne and exactly such a sentence, did not hear the sentence at all. I heard the room hear it. I watched the old man in dark cloth, who had not moved, take the prince's words in through

that stillness and set them down somewhere inside himself with great care, the care a clerk gives a sum he will need again — not shocked, not angry, far worse than angry: attentive. A price was being noted in that corner. I have noted too many prices in too many corners not to know the look of a man doing it.

And the prince saw none of it. His back was half to the qazi; he was at his plates; he had given away a thing more dangerous than the Bible was worth and felt the wind of it no more than he felt the worth of the silver he had scattered on me. He did not know what his candor cost any more than he knew what his book cost, and for the identical reason, and it was the same open hand doing both.

I had sat once before with such a talker — you will remember our early talk of Giordano Bruno — doomed and brilliant, pouring himself out to me because I was nobody to him, a foreign nothing who could carry no tale that mattered and break nothing he valued. That was in his cell under the wall of the Vatican, the year I was seventeen, and the man there had a voice too big for his starved body and eight years of unheard talk dammed up behind it, and he too had opened himself to me precisely because I was safe — because the curious and the powerless make the only audience a condemned man is given. I had spent my whole life since that room. And here at the far end of it was the room again, turned inside out and gilded: the cell made into a garden, the heretic made into a prince, the want of an honest ear exactly the same, and the end — I knew it then, in the dust and the lamp-smell, with his silver warm in my coat — the end would be the same too. The thrones do not change. Only the men they fear are sometimes housed better before the burning.

I tell you this plainly, Tommaso, because I had it plainly, that first afternoon, and have never been able to pretend otherwise: I loved him inside the hour, and I had already buried him. Both at once. The prince kept me on — he liked my eye, he liked that I would name him a true price and let him override it, he liked a listener with grey in his beard who had seen the Frankish world and asked nothing of him but to be paid — and I took the keeping gladly, and went up into his book-house to spend the best years I had left serving the one throne in my century that paid for the truth instead of feeding it to

the fire. I served it knowing what serving it would come to. I had served the other kind for forty years with my eyes open; I do not know why you would expect me to have closed them now, only because for once the throne was on the side I might have chosen, had I ever once let myself choose a side instead of a price.

Chapter Seventeen — The Naked Man and the Hidden Book

I meant to be gone in a season. I had told you that already, in the matter of the prince, and you have the grace not to count for me how many seasons a man may stack on that one word before it tips over and spills. I will count it myself, since I am the only one it shames. Three years I was the prince's Frank before the thing I am going to tell you, and in those three years I stopped, somewhere I did not mark at the time, setting a month to going home. There had been a month once. In Surat I had said the spring; on the road up I had said the next dry season after the prince's business closed; and then one year I noticed I had quit naming it, as you quit naming a debt you have privately resolved not to pay. The house in Julfa would be standing. She would be at her figures. I left it there, unmonthed, and did not look at it, and that was the only lie I still troubled to keep, the rest of me having grown too old for the others.

The court itself would not hold still either. The King was raising a whole new city upriver from Agra — Shahjahanabad he had it named, his own city raised beside the old Delhi — a fort the colour of dried blood and a mile of bazaar laid out by rule, ruled off like a clerk's ledger before the writing goes in; and the household moved to it by stages across those years, so that I packed the prince's book-house twice and unpacked it twice and learned the same river's dust a hundred miles up its length. You will want the new city to be a marvel, because the letters home made it one, and it was not. But I came into it the back way, with the baggage, an old Frank of six-and-sixty whose knees now took the unloading badly, and what a city is to a man arriving with the baggage is gates and tolls and where the paper is sold. Take it as said, and let me get to the men.

The book-house in the new city was the same manufactory of beauty it had been at Agra, only larger, the prince's appetite having outgrown two moves. But around it now there had gathered a thing I had not seen the like of anywhere in my trade, and it is the thing you are really asking me about when you ask whether there was ever a place that paid for the truth instead of burning it.

He had brought them all under one roof. That Portuguese padre at Surat had named it to me as a rumour and crossed himself over it — Jesuits and Brahmins and the Sufi shaikhs at one cushion — and here it was, not a rumour but a payroll. On a given afternoon you might find, in the rooms off the garden court, a Sufi of the Qadiri order — a Mussulman mystic, of the sort the orthodox mistrusted — who could recite you the chain of his masters back four hundred years; and across from him a pandit up from Benares — a Hindu Brahmin learned in Sanskrit — who would not take water from the Sufi's cup and held his own scriptures so close that most of his own people were forbidden to hear them; and between the two of them a clerk in good Persian writing down what each said the other believed, so that the prince might lay the sheets side by side of an evening and read the one God out from under the three tongues. I have stood in the Vatican's library and in the Sultan's book-rooms and in a cardinal's three locked presses, and I had never seen learning of every enemy faith bought and fed and set to copy at one long table, on a wage, like the calligraphers grinding lapis in the next room.

I should tell you what it did to me to stand in it, because I have been honest with you about the rest and I will not turn coy here. It moved me. I, who appraise. The wanting I had felt over the Jesuit's foxed China letters at Surat — the wanting of there to be one throne on the earth that gathered the forbidden article instead of feeding it to the fire — that wanting had a roof over it now and forty scholars under the roof, and the old draught of hope went through me standing there as it goes through any buyer when the thing he half-believed could not exist is laid on the table in front of him with the dust still on it.

And then, because I am what I am, I saw the machine. It is the same machine. I want you to have that plainly, because it cost me a good many years to have it plainly myself. A throne that gathers every scripture to read the one truth out of them is doing the very thing the Holy Office did when it burned Bruno — it is deciding that truth is a matter for a throne to settle. The one settles it with a fire and the other with a copyist, and the copyist is the gentler instrument by a long way, and I would sooner be a book in the prince's house than a book in the Campo de' Fiori. But it is the same proposition underneath: that there is one truth, that it is the throne's to

find, and that the finding of it is power. Rome had run that engine forward, toward the fire. The prince was running it backward, toward the table. Backward is better. Backward is not safe. An engine that can gather every book can be made to burn every book by the next hand that takes the crank, and the orthodox knew that about the prince's table better than the prince's friends did, which is the whole of what came after.

Let me set the board in front of you plainly, for you were got in a Roman printer's shop and have no cause to know how a throne passes in Hindustan. The old King, Shah Jahan, held it yet, and would a while; but he was ageing, and had four grown sons, and in that house a crown goes to whichever son can seize and keep it when the old man dies — the brothers make war, and the one the lords and the army and the doctors of the law will follow is the one who ends by reigning. Strength there is a borrowed thing, granted by the men who choose which brother to ride out for and withdrawn as readily; a prince his own people will not follow has none, for all the troops he began with.

By that count Dara held the high ground early — the eldest, the favourite, kept at his father's right hand, with the capital and the treasury and the old King's own face turned toward him, so that the lords leaned his way as men lean toward the coming sun. His brothers could not simply take such a man; they had first to make his own people willing to desert him, and for that they needed a cause that would not damn the deserter — and the one unanswerable cause, in that empire, is that a prince has abandoned the faith. That was what the orthodox could hand the ablest of the brothers, the one I have called, until now, only the careful one: Aurangzeb — lean, plain, abstemious, a soldier to the bone and a flawless Mussulman, who prayed where Dara read and counted where Dara spent, and who saw, far sooner than Dara, that the favourite could be beaten in the mosque before ever he was met in the field. They wanted a single thing of the heir, and they waited, through all those pleasant years, for him to furnish it himself: proof that the favourite had left Islam for the heathen's books. The books were the proof.

I knew it, and I went deeper in regardless, and I will tell you the act by which I went, because it is the one I have had to sit with longest.

There was a book the prince wanted that the Benares men kept back. I never could read a word of it and so I will not pretend to name it for you; in my ledger it was Sanskrit, four hands old, on a country paper that drank ink, and what mattered about it to my trade was not its title but its danger, and its danger was double, which I had never met before.

The pandit who owned the loan of it — an old man, Jagannath, shaven but for the one lock at the crown, his mouth and the stumps of his teeth dyed red as a wound from the betel he was never without, a proud, wary, fastidious old man who washed if my shadow crossed his food — that pandit could be unmade by his own people for letting the book be copied at all.

The Brahmins did not keep it as a guild keeps a secret, to guard a price; they kept it because they held the knowledge in it was given only to men born to receive it, and that to let it reach a low-caste, or a woman, or a foreigner — which last I was — did not spread the truth but defiled it, and defiled whoever let it out. Truth, to them, was not a thing you published but a thing you inherited; the wrong eyes upon it did not enlarge it, they spoiled it, as a drop of ink spoils a bowl of milk. I had crossed the world to watch a throne buy truth and lay it open on a table, and found that at its own wellspring it was the most jealously shut thing in the house — shut not by a throne, which a richer throne can always outbid, but by birth, which no purse on earth has ever bought.

And the prince could be unmade by the orthodox for wanting it, a Mussulman heir hunting the Hindus' closed scriptures being exactly the scandal his brother's friends prayed nightly that he would hand them. A book forbidden on the one side to be given and on the other side to be taken. I had carried contraband for forty years, but always contraband that one power wanted and another forbade; I had never carried a thing that the mullahs and the Brahmins, who agreed on nothing else, agreed in keeping shut.

The getting of it up from Benares I could have brokered from my cushion. That is the truth I keep returning to. I had the chain of men to do it — a hundred times I had named a price and let other hands run the risk and taken my brokerage when the cargo came in clean. The prince would have had his copy either way; my purse did not need me to touch it; a broker who carries his own goods is a broker who has forgotten his trade. And I

went down the chain myself, an old man on bad knees in the wet, and I took the manuscript into my own keeping for the leg where the keeping was worst, the stretch through the country where the King's customs and the orthodox eyes overlapped.

Jagannath gave it to me at night, in a room behind a dyer's yard at Benares, and he would not hand it to me. He set it down on the floor between us, wrapped in three cloths, and stepped back from it, and I understood that a foreigner's fingers were about to go where no foreigner's had been, and that he would wash after, and that the washing would not help. His red mouth worked. He said nothing. I have bought from frightened men all my life, and none of them ever looked at my hands as he looked at them. I packed it in front of him, so he should see it was done carefully: down to the bottom of a Frank's travelling box, under a broken astrolabe, a Latin herbal with its boards off, two engraved plates of the Frankish saints, and a quantity of old letters of no interest to anyone. Then I shut the lid on it, and he turned his face away.

The customs post was at a river crossing four days west: a mud fort, a ferry, and a line of carts waiting in the rain. There was the King's man with his scales and his stamp, and beside him, on a stool under an awning, a qazi's clerk — young, with a clean beard and a list. Some qazi or other had begun that year to post such men where the roads ran toward the capital. He was not there for duty. He was there for books.

They had my box open in the mud in a minute. The clerk lifted out the astrolabe and turned it over, a thing he could not use; he lifted the herbal by one board and let it swing; then he found the plates of the saints and held them up to the light, and his mouth went thin, because they were idols, and a Frank's idols at that. He looked at me, and then down into the box, and put his hand in, and his fingers went under the old letters and touched the cloth.

I talked price. It is the only weapon I have ever carried. I told him in my flattest Persian that the saints were a pair, Antwerp work and not good Antwerp work, that I had been trying to be rid of them since Surat, and that if the qazi's office wished to burn them it could have them for four rupees the pair, which was less than the frames, and he would be doing me

a kindness. I told him the astrolabe was broken and the herbal was wormed, and I told him which worms. I was an old Frank complaining about his stock in the rain, and I bored him, which I have always been able to do to a young man, and I watched his interest go out of him as a bid goes out of a sale-room when the lot turns out to be damaged. He took his hand out of the box. He did not buy the saints. The King's man stamped the lid and waved me on to the ferry.

My hands did not shake. I had done that very thing for forty years, to Venetian customs and Turkish and Portuguese, over nothing worse than a bad Greek colophon, and I did it this time over the one book in Hindustan that mullah and Brahmin alike wanted kept shut, and my voice did not change by a hair. The trade had made me perfect for it. I had never once asked it what it was making me perfect for.

I brought it through as only I could have, and that is the part that tells you what I had become. A Frank is nobody's heretic. That had been my whole estate in life — that I believed too little for any power to fear what I carried, that my boxes got the lazy search because what could a godless old Italian be smuggling but more of his own godless rubbish. I carried the holiest thing those Benares men possessed through the orthodox country wrapped in the trash of my own dead faith, because the one thing every throne agreed on was that I did not matter. I had spent sixty years being nobody who mattered, and being paid for it, and keeping my hands clean by keeping them on the price and never on the cause. And there in the rain with the pandit's terror and the prince's scandal both riding in my Frank's box, I used the not-mattering, for once, on purpose, for a side. You may set down the date if you like. It is the day I stopped being able to tell you I had never chosen one.

I knew it as I did it. I did not discover years later, in this chair, that I had crossed some line in the rain; I felt the line under my foot as I stepped over it, and stepped over it anyway, with my eyes as open as they are now and my knees a great deal better.

It was in those same months that I met the naked man.

You will have heard his name in the lanes even now, for they have made a sort of saint of him since, which would have set him laughing. Sarmad. He had been a merchant once, a Jew of Persia come east to trade, and somewhere on the roads he had put down his stock and then his coat and then everything else a man wears against the world, and he walked the new city naked as the day, burnt near black by the sun, his hair and beard gone to grey ropes, and he laughed. He laughed the way other men breathe. I have met holy men by the score in my trade — I have bought the works of a dozen of them and watched two of them denounced — and they go cloaked, always, in something: a doctrine, a discretion, a careful sentence with the dangerous half left for the trusted ear. Sarmad had taken off the cloak with the clothes. He said the thing. Whatever the prince said carefully of an evening with the doors watched, Sarmad said at noon in the bazaar to whoever stood near, laughing, and the crowd half loved him and half drew back, and the law had not yet decided what to do about a man it could not embarrass and could not frighten and could not even decently arrest, there being no charge in the books for going about as God reportedly made you.

I came on him by the river steps with the pandit's terror still fresh in me, and I will own that he frightened me more than the prince ever had, and it took me a while to learn why. The prince was a doomed man housed in a garden; I had grieved him from the first hour. But the prince hedged. The prince said the dangerous thing and then smiled it half back, and kept his doors, and trusted the wrong men but did at least know there were men not to be trusted. Sarmad had thrown all of that away. He had thrown away the one thing I had lived sixty years by — the held tongue, the closed face, the dangerous half kept back for the dark — and he was still walking around in the sun. For the moment. It was the for-the-moment that went through me cold. I had built a whole life on the proposition that a man survives by what he does not say, and here was a man surviving, that morning, by saying all of it, and the only thing between him and the answer to that proposition was time, and time is the one commodity I have never been able to misprice.

We spoke a little. He asked me what I carried — he could smell a dealer, naked men being free of the manners that keep the rest of us from such questions — and I told him books, and he asked whose God was in them, and I said I sold to whoever paid and asked the buyer's God no more than

I asked his weight. He laughed at that until he had to sit down on the step. He said I was the most honest holy man in the city, that I had found the one truth under all the books before any of the prince's clever scholars and had the wit to charge for it, and that they would never burn me, because you cannot burn a man who is already ash. Then he begged a copper off me, who owned nothing and wanted nothing, for the pleasure he said of making a rich Frank poorer by one coin, and I gave it to him, and he threw it in the river. I have been called a great many things across a long trade. I have not been more accurately insulted.

The prince loved him. That was the danger of it. I saw them together once in the court of the book-house: the heir in pale silk on the lip of the channel, and Sarmad squatting bare in the dust below him, telling him that God had never needed a library and would not miss this one, and the prince laughing until he had to wipe his eyes on his sleeve, while the calligraphers bent lower over their boards and pretended to hear nothing.

Around the prince's table there sat, by then, men who were writing it all down for the other side. I had marked one in particular — a court-scholar, Mir Askari, young and smooth and very well-kept, a clean turban and a clean tongue and a manner so pleasant that the prince trusted him with the doors I have said the prince did at least know to keep. He was always near, always agreeable, always last to speak and first to remember, and he wrote a fine correspondence, and I, who had spent my life watching one corner of a room while a deal was struck in another, watched him write down the prince's laughter at Sarmad's blasphemies as I had once watched a qazi in Agra fold away a sentence about the one God under many tongues. A price being noted, again, in a corner.

The prince did not see him for the same reason the prince did not count his silver: he had never in his life been made to learn that an open hand is a thing other men read. I said nothing. It was not my place, and it was not my trade, and a dealer who warns his patron's house of its own rot is a dealer looking for a new patron. I told myself that. I have told myself a number of things across the years and that one wore the worst.

So there is your answer, the one you asked me three nights ago with the China letters across your knees — was there ever a place that paid for the

truth instead of burning it. There was. I stood in it for the better part of fifteen years and I gave it the best work of my old age and one clean act besides, the only one of my life I did for a side and not a price, and I would do the act again tomorrow on these knees. And it was a throne, and it ran the same engine every throne runs, and the engine ate it, and ate the prince, and ate the naked man on the steps a year or two after the rest — the law found its charge in the end, as the law always does once a throne wants one. They paid for the truth, and then they paid for the paying. I had only ever seen the second half of that account settled before, in a square in Rome with a man tied to a stake. It was strange, and it was not strange at all, to watch the first half — the gathering, the wage, the long table — knowing the whole time how the books are closed.

I did not have long left in the new city, as it turned out, though I did not know it that season. There was a letter coming for me, the slowest letter of my life, that had been chasing me up out of Persia and across an ocean and up a river for years and had not yet found the man it was for; and before it found me the prince's business sent me back down to the coast, to Surat, to the rain and the customs and the Jesuit house — where the letter, and a half-dead Pole with the truth about China in his baggage, were both at last going to catch me up.

Chapter Eighteen — The Long Net

I came back down to the coast in the wet of 1651, the same road run backward, an old Frank of eight-and-sixty who felt every stage of the descent in knees that had never forgiven him the climb up. The prince had a Frankish atlas coming in off the Gulf shipping and a chest of star-tables with it, and wanted them cleared by hands he trusted, and mine were the hands he had; so I went down out of the new red city and the dust and the long river-country to the rain that does not fall so much as hang in the air and wait. I had come up that road promising myself a season. I had stopped telling myself anything about seasons. The lie had worn through at last — not at the elbow I watched but at a seam I had forgotten I had.

Surat took me back without a sign it had noticed I was gone. The bar was where I had left it, and the lighters working over it, and the brown river thick with country boats; the Mughal's customs-men weighed and stamped under the same dripping awnings and were no more to be hurried than before. What had changed was small, and was mine. The town had had a fever through it that season, as it always had a fever through it in the wet, and the fever had been into the houses I knew.

I went to the Jesuit house out of habit before I went on business, because it was where I heard my own tongues spoken, and found Bernardo three months under the floor of his own poor chapel. The Goa padre had dried down to cord and ink, and had given me sour Portuguese wine and the China letters nine years before; and the fever took him in a single week, after twenty years it had only ever worried at. I stood on the stone they had laid over him and reckoned, in the dealer's habit I cannot put off even there, how few of that make I had left to me. I had not known I counted him a friend until there was nothing under my feet but the counting.

The man keeping the house now was Portuguese too, but young and sound and busy, with none of the dead man's dried sweetness — a plain functionary sent up to hold the place till Goa decided what it was for. He had inherited Bernardo's papers and not yet read them, and they stood in damp stacks against the wall, and he was glad of any literate hand that would tell him what was worth the keeping and what the white ants could

have. I did not know, that first afternoon, that one of those stacks had been waiting a year for me.

He had a guest, the young padre said. A father come up from the south half-dead and not mending, lodged on the house's charity, starved for talk the house had no one to give him. Would I sit with him, having Latin. So I met Michał Boym.

He had been a big man once; you could read the architecture of it in the long heavy bones, the broad scaffold of a frame that something had since eaten the man off and left standing empty. His skin had gone the colour of old tallow, yellow down into the whites of his eyes, the yellow of a liver giving out. His hands, when he raised them, shook so that the blessing he made over the wine was the gesture of a man shaking water from his fingers. He wore a cassock that had been a fine one and was now a chart of every road between that rainy room and a country I had only ever held by letter, mended and re-mended by hands that were not a tailor's. He was a Pole, and a Jesuit, and he was dying of an errand.

The errand he gave me in pieces, across three wet afternoons, between the coughing and the long stops where he had to sit and gather the strength to go on. He had come out of China — out of the very court my Peking letters had come from, nine years and a world ago — but not with relations of the Emperor's astronomers and their honours. He had come as an ambassador. The dynasty that had set the Frankish fathers over its heavens, the Ming, was coming apart under a people out of the north; and a remnant of it, a prince of it, baptised and cornered, had sent this one priest overland and by sea the whole breadth of the earth to lay a letter at the feet of the Pope and beg Christendom for help before the throne went down.

He was bound for Rome with that letter, and he knew before ever he set foot there how Rome would take him. He told me of it flatly, as of a sum already paid out and not to be got back. They would doubt him — doubt his credentials, doubt whether the throne he spoke for was still standing to be helped, doubt in the slow careful manner of a court that loses nothing by doubting and is never in the room when the bill comes due. They would keep him waiting. They would give him at the last their letters of comfort and no army and no silver, and send him back over all of it again to a throne

that would be ash before he raised the coast of it. He knew the whole of it, and he was going anyway, because a man carries the letter he is handed.

“They will ask me for my papers,” he said once, and almost smiled, which on that face was a hard thing to watch. “A court that has weighed the heavens will not weigh a man’s papers. I will tell them the seal answers for me. They will tell me they must write and verify the seal.” He turned the yellow hand over. “It is two thousand leagues to ask after my seal, and two thousand more for the answer to come back. The man whose seal it is will be dead before the letter asking after him is opened.”

He showed me the letter. He carried it on his body, against the skin, in an oilcloth gone soft as cloth with the sweat of the whole journey, and he brought it out and let me hold it because I had told him my trade and a dying man is curious what a dealer’s hands will do with the one thing he has that no dealer could ever sell. It was a good heavy paper, and a court hand, and a great vermilion seal that I could not read; and I held it and felt the thing I have felt holding much that came through my hands, the small electric fact of provenance, this came from there, this was in that room — and felt, under it, that there was no market on the earth for it, that it was the most valuable worthless object I had ever been passed, a credential to a throne that would not exist by the time anyone honoured it. I gave it back as carefully as I have ever given anything back.

“Well?” he said. “What would you give me for it?”

“Nothing,” I told him. “Nor would any man alive. That is the trouble with it.”

He laughed at that, the only time I heard him laugh, and it brought the coughing on, and he had to sit a long while with the oilcloth pressed flat under his hand before he could go on.

I sat with him and I priced it all, because I cannot do otherwise; and the price of it was the thing I had crossed two seas half-believing I might find, and had let a Jesuit’s foxed paper sell me, here in this same town, in this same wet. A throne that paid in honour for the truth. I had held that hope up to the light once and seen the flaw in it plain — the honour and the falling lying on two leaves of the one packet, the bright tablet over the rebellion underneath — and I had wanted the hope more than I had minded

the flaw, and slid the flaw under. Here was the flaw come the whole way round the world in a yellow skin to sit at my elbow and shake. The honour had been real. So had the falling. An honour is worth the house that grants it and not one giulio more, and the house was rubble now, and the man it had honoured was on the road with a begging letter no living hand would answer.

I will not keep you in suspense over him: he reached Rome, and Rome did to him very nearly what he had told me it would, and he died years after on the road back east, somewhere on the rim of the country he had crossed the world to save, the seal still on him. The news of it reached me later, as all my news did, late. I tell it to you now so you needn't carry him further; carry the rest.

It was on the last of those afternoons, when I had stayed to put a price of usefulness on the dead padre's papers for the live one, that the thing waiting for me came up out of the damp. He handed me a packet because my name was on the cover — my name in a hand I did not know, *Niccolò Ferrucci, Frank, at the prince's house, Agra*, and beneath it the same again in case the first failed to find me — and said it had come up a year past with a word that it was to be held against any news of where I was, and that with Bernardo's dying it had simply sat in the stack with the rest.

I knew the inner sheet before I had the outer cover open. I am my trade; I know a hand as another man knows a face across a crowded market, and I knew this one, though I had never in my life had a letter in it. The figures were Marjan's. The ink was the walnut ink she ground and stained herself to the wrist with, browner than oak-gall and going faintly red in the down-stroke, the ink I had watched her wear like a second skin over the years I knew her. Her bookkeeper's hand, that had set my accounts straight and caught the forgery I had missed. I sat with the unopened packet on my knee in a dead man's house with the rain hanging in the yard and I appraised my own letter — the paper, the fold, the hand — because it was the last thing of hers I would ever hold, and the appraiser in me got to it first, before the rest of me could come up.

There were two sheets to it. The first was from a nephew of Sarkis's, a young man I had never met, with the house in his charge now, writing a

careful merchant's Italian got off the Venetians. It was a business letter. It settled, in its opening lines, an old balance the house held to my credit, and asked where I would have it remitted; and in its third paragraph, between the balance and the bills of it, in the same even hand he had given the figures, it told me that his aunt Marjan had died of a sickness in the autumn of the year '46, and was buried by the Armenian church, and that she had left the enclosed sheet to be sent on if ever the trade brought back word of me, and that the house trusted I was in health. He did not say what the sickness had been. I have wanted to know what the sickness was for fourteen years, and there is no one alive now to ask, and the not-knowing is its own small daily robbery to a dealer who has earned his bread off the provenance of everything he ever touched.

She had been five years dead.

The young padre was saying something behind me about the hour of the meal. Water ran off the eaves into the yard. I sat with the nephew's page in one hand and hers, still folded, in the other, and for some while I could not make either hand do anything at all.

I had been building the road home to her the whole five years. I had built it on the boat down from the Gulf and up the passes to Agra and along the river to the new city and down again, board by board, the house standing and she at her figures and a season, two at the most; and I would not do the sum, the whole five years, though I had only to do it once, at any plank, to see that I was carpentering a road to a grave. I above all men should have heard it. I had bought for a corpse one entire summer myself, years before — gone on buying eastern books for Ascanio Vitelleschi three months in his grave, his last standing-list crossing the notice of his death somewhere on the Aleppo road — and I had thought it the saddest comedy the trade dealt in, and filed it away to tell at tables. I had done the very thing again, for five years, on my own account, and called it hope.

And the slowness of it I had built myself, with my own hand, out of the discretion I had lived sixty years by. The letter was five years late not because the road from Julfa is slow — the road from Julfa is months — but because I had never once written to her. She knew I had gone to a prince in Hindustan; she did not know whether I had got there alive, or which of

his moving cities held me, and I sent no line to tell her. Not a word through any factory, not a merchant's note tucked into another man's packet, in five years. I had told no power and no friend where I went, the better to be nobody the customs need trouble over, and I had made so thorough a nobody of myself that when she died her people had no living man they could be sure of sending the grief to. They could not find me to tell me, because I had spent my life making certain I could not be found. And the one thing that broke my hiding in the end was the very court I had chosen over the going home — for an old Frank at the elbow of the Mughal's heir is specific enough at last to be written to. I had to become someone before the trade could tell me she was gone.

Her own sheet you do not get whole. There is little in it a stranger would call tender, and that is the truth of her, and I will not dress her up warmer in the telling than she went about in life. It was, like the nephew's, mostly a reckoning. She had kept the house's books on after Sarkis died, and she set out for me, short and clear, how a balance I had left tangled when I rode east in '41 ought properly to have been carried — and she was right, of course she was right, and her being right ten years after the fact and five years dead went through me worse than any endearment in the language could have. She did not ask me to come. She had not asked me to stay either, the autumn I left her — not the word, not even the hand laid palm-down on the table for me to take or leave, though the asking would have cost me more to refuse than anything in the language; she had read me before I read myself, and let me go rather than hand me a thing to be brave against. She had not asked it to my face, and she was not a woman to ask it on a page.

She had only, at the foot of it, set down the thing I have carried since in the place where her face used to be, now that I am losing the colour of that. That she did not know if this would ever find me, having no road to send it down; but that she had given it to the house to keep against the chance, the trade being a long net, and a man being, in the end, a sort of cargo it will report upon if only he stays in it long enough. She had found a road to me. I, who would not give her one, had been found by her — five years too late, off the long net of the very trade I had hidden myself inside. She out-read me dead as surely as she had out-read me living.

And under that, one line more, struck through in her own hand — one clean stroke, the way she cancelled an entry in the house's books, that left every word beneath it legible: that she had told me she had a better eye than mine for the things that do not come back, and that it had proved true; and that she had been wrong about the one thing she had been surest of, which was that she would not mind. It was the only time in all our dealings I ever knew her to be wrong, and she had been wrong about herself. She had tried to cancel it, and she had not made herself scrape it out. I have given you the words. The look of her hand on them stays with me.

Tommaso asked nothing when I had done. It was the first night of all the telling that he let a thing go by without a question on it. He got up and put more charcoal on the brazier, a piece at a time, with the tongs, so as to make no noise, and filled my cup, and sat down again and did not pick up his pen. I have told you a boy's joke is a coin he should be let bank himself. So is his silence. I did not thank him for it. I let it stand, and after a while I went on.

I cleared the prince's atlas and his star-tables through the customs that week with the same care I would have given them in any week of my life, because the work does not stop for grief and because I had no other notion what to do with my hands. I folded the two sheets together, hers inside the nephew's, the reckoning inside the reckoning, and put them into the breast of my coat, where they have more or less stayed from that afternoon to this one. Then I went back up the river to the new city and the prince and the long table and the gathered scholars and the work I had crossed the world and given her up to do. I did not turn west. There had been nothing west to turn to for five years; I had only just been told. I went on up to the one throne in my century that would pay for the truth instead of burning it, and I served it, and I grieved her on the road, and the grieving did not lighten for the serving nor the serving slacken for the grief. I carried both up the river as I had carried the books, because carrying is the whole of what I am, and I set neither of them down.

Chapter Nineteen — The Greatest Secret, Finished

The Persian book you keep circling back to — the one I have not entered, that you found at the dim end of the press and could not get a name out of me for — was finished the same autumn the old King fell ill. I have put off telling you that for three nights running, and I notice I am still putting it off, so let me set down the year at least before the candle does for the both of us. Sixteen fifty-seven. I was four-and-seventy, a dozen years and more the prince's Frank, far enough gone in the eyes by then that I held a folio at arm's length and read it through a ground lens out of Murano that I kept on a cord, and stiff enough in the knee that the young men in the book-house had learned to bring the chair to me. The hands were still good. The hands are the last to go, in my trade; I have buried men who could no longer climb the stair to their own shelves and could still tell you a leaf was sprung the moment they took the book in their palms.

The book-house had come up to the new city with everything else, and it was the great work of the prince's life by then, larger than Agra and busier, a long range of rooms off a garden court where the water ran in a cut channel and the calligraphers sat out of the glare. What I had not had, in sixty years of the trade, and have not had since, was the thing that had gathered in the rooms past the copyists — the Sufi shaikhs and the Benares pandits and the Persian clerks between them, every enemy faith bought and fed and set to write at one table. I had stood in it and been moved by it and then, because I am what I am, seen the engine under it; I have told you that too. What I had not yet seen, that autumn, was the engine's one finished product laid in my own hands.

They brought it to me to be made fit for the prince's own shelf — collated, the gatherings checked, a binding judged worthy of it — which was honest work and mine to do, and I did it. It was a fine court copy and no finer than a court copy should be: good Kashmir paper, a nasta'liq like smoke with no copyist's cramp anywhere, gold only at the openings. I have handled a hundred as handsome. I sat with it on my knee in the garden room with the lens up, and I read it, and that was the difference, you understand, that was the whole difference — I could read this one. The closed books I had carried

up out of Benares for him I never could; they were marks on country paper and I priced them by their danger and their age and never knew a word inside them. This was Persian. This was the court tongue I had bought my bread in from Isfahan to here, and so the one book in my life whose secret I had no need of another man to tell me, I had under the lens, alone, in the heat of an afternoon, with the water running in the channel.

I will tell you what it said, since you came all this way to ask it, and since a man ought not to be made to cross a room in the dark for a thing I can hand him in the light. It was the Hindus' oldest scriptures — the Upanishads, the hidden root under all the rest of their books — put over into Persian by the prince, Dara Shikoh, and his pandits, word fought for against word across those years at the table. And in the front of it the prince had written, in his own argument and over his own name, that these were no heathen rubbish at all but the *kitab al-maknun* — the hidden, well-guarded book that the Mussulmans' own Scripture says God keeps concealed and lets none but the purified touch. There is the boldness of it: their own holy Book names a concealed scripture under all the others, and the prince had stepped up and laid the Hindus' Upanishads in the place it named — proved the heathens' book sacred out of the Muslims' own. From that the rest followed: that the truth under the Quran and the truth under these and the truth under all the warring revelations was one truth, the same water carried in different jars; and that a wise throne would gather every jar and read the one water out from under the many names. He had titled it himself. *Sirr-i-Akbar*. The greatest secret.

And it was statecraft as much as faith, whatever the prince's own heart was in it; I had seen as much in those rooms, and I saw it again on the page. Set a crown over a country with more Hindus in it than Mussulmans, and the teaching that the whole of them bow to one thing under their thousand names is the only floor a throne like that can stand on. As for the name: *akbar* is merely the Persian for greatest, but it had been his own great-grandfather's name as well — the emperor Akbar, who had tried this very reconciling of the faiths a lifetime before and been careful all his reign never to set his hand to it. The title was a flag the prince ran up over the work the old man had left unsigned.

I had heard the prince say very near the whole of that aloud, years before, over wine, with his back half-turned to a clerk who was writing it down — careless talk in a careless evening, the kind a man can deny in the morning. This was not that. This was set, and ruled, and signed, and copied out fair for fifty shelves. I sat there an old dealer in a garden and felt the hair go up on my arms, and it was not the secret that did it. I have handled the secrets of half the faiths between Rome and here and found them all about equally heavy in the hand. It was the title page. I had carried contraband for forty years — books one throne wanted and another forbade, and the whole art of it was that the danger lived in the cargo and never in me. Here the danger lived in the name on the front. A man does not hang for what he says of an evening. He hangs for what he signs. And the heir to the richest throne on the earth had signed his name under the proposition that the heathen kept the hidden book of God — and his enemies, had they been let write the charge against him themselves, in their own hands, could not have written a fairer one.

I thought of an evening in a cell under the Vatican wall, the year I was seventeen, and Giordano Bruno, the small gaunt man who would not stop correcting his judges, and whom I had watched burn that February in the Campo. I will not make more of it than that. I thought of him, and I set the thought down, and I went on collating the gatherings, because the gatherings were what I had been given to do.

He came in on me once that autumn while I had it on my knee — the prince himself, alone for once, in from the garden with the light behind him and his slippers wet from the channel's edge. I began to get up. He waved me down and sat on the step below me, which no prince should do and he did often, and asked what I had got to.

I told him: the salt. It is a passage in one of their oldest books, where a father sends his son to drop a lump of salt in a bowl of water overnight and bring it back in the morning, and the boy cannot find it; and the father has him sip from the top, and the middle, and the bottom, and it is salt all through; and the father says, that is what you are — the thing you cannot see and cannot find, and taste everywhere.

“Yes,” the prince said, “yes, that one,” and took the book off my knee as though it were his, which it was, and found the place without looking for it. “Do you know how long we fought over that one word? *That*. Three pandits and my Persian scholar and myself, a whole week. There is a word for it the mullahs will hear as God. So the father tells the boy, *you are God* — and the last man of ours who said that aloud, they hanged in Baghdad, seven hundred years ago, and they are still angry with him.” He laughed. “We argued it every way. Then I thought of my brother reading it, and I laughed until the pandits thought I had lost my wits.”

He meant Aurangzeb. He called him the prayer-monger at his own table, and the whole court knew he did.

I said something a dealer says: that it was a fine thing the salt did not care what word they put on it.

“There,” he said, and turned on the step to look up at me, pleased, as if I had passed an examination. “You believe it. You tell everyone you believe nothing — the Flemish father who eats at my table says you are the least Christian Frank he ever met, and he means it as a warning — and then you say that. And you carried Jagannath’s book up the country in your own box, when you could have hired it carried. Oh, I was told. Nobody does that for a fee.” He shook his head at me, fond. “You are not so empty as you pretend.”

I was. That was the trouble. He had read me as he read everything, generously, as a better text than the page said, and I had not the heart to correct his copy.

Then a chamberlain came to the door to say that a Rajput lord was waiting on him in the hall, with gifts, and the prince made a face like a boy called in to lessons. “He will want me to admire his horses,” he said, “and he cannot read his own name on the letter he brings. Let him wait. A man who cannot read has all the time in the world.” He said it to the chamberlain, in front of the chamberlain’s boy, and sat on the step with the salt in his lap for a quarter of an hour more, reading me pieces aloud, until he had finished the chapter, and only then went out.

I think that was the happiest I ever saw him. And I think the lord waited the whole quarter-hour in the hall, and counted every minute of it, and knew exactly how he was being priced. That is how a prince's borrowed strength gets spent: a quarter-hour at a time, by a man too glad to count it.

It was in the ninth month of that year, while the book was still under my hand, that word came up through the city that the old King, Shah Jahan, was sick to death.

He was at the capital still, behind the red walls, and he did not die — you know that now, looking back, as I did not know it then, and as not one man in the bazaar knew it that week. What such a city knows is the rumour, and the rumour ran ahead of the truth as water runs ahead of the man carrying it, spilling. One morning the criers were ordinary and the next they were careful, and careful is the loudest thing a crier can be. The drums from the fort kept their hours and men stood listening to them anyway, counting, as though the number of strokes had changed. I had lived through the dying of one Shah in Isfahan and I knew the smell of it, which was a slowing more than a smell — petitions not answered, a customs matter that would have run clean last month, gone suddenly to a week of bowing and no decision, every clerk in the empire holding his hand a half-inch off the paper to see which way the great weight was going to come down before he committed his little one.

In that house the crown went to the son the lords and the soldiers and the doctors of the law chose to ride out for, and they had leaned to this prince for years because he was the eldest and the favourite and stood at his father's right hand in the full sun of it. The instant the sun looked like setting they began, very softly, the work of finding out whether they had leaned too far. None of them said so. You did not see a man change sides; you saw a man become difficult to find. The vestibule of the book-house, that had been crowded of an afternoon with people who wanted to be seen near the heir's beautiful enthusiasm, thinned over a fortnight to the ones who were paid to be there and the ones who had nowhere safer to stand.

A great noble who had haunted the rooms all spring, wanting a fair copy of the *Shahnama* made for his son, sent word that the commission must wait on better times, and did not trouble to say whose better times he meant.

A binder I had brought on myself left for Lahore over a family matter that had not existed the week before. I had watched courts empty in Isfahan, and once in Rome; men do not flee a falling house, they remember pressing business elsewhere — and the business is always genuine, and it is always the same business.

And one of those who stayed, and grew if anything more attentive as the rest fell away, was the smooth young scholar I have named to you before — Mir Askari, who sat always near the prince and was always agreeable and was always the last in a room to speak and the first afterward to remember what everyone in it had said. You will not have kept him in your head; there is no reason you should; he was built to be forgotten in exactly that way. A clean turban, a pleasant voice, and the palest, stillest hands I ever watched on a writing man — hands that handled ink all day and never wore a mark of it, where mine and every honest copyist's I have known are stained to the knuckle for life. He kept them folded and quiet in his lap and they made me think, every time, of a cat that has decided not to move yet. He wrote a fine correspondence. I had marked years before for whom.

Now, with the doors thinning, his work came out into the light a little, because there was less around it to hide it. He had taken to going through the book-house. Not reading — counting. He would have a list, and he would walk the presses with one of the orthodox up from the law-courts, a dry man in dark cloth who touched nothing and missed nothing, and the two of them would note what was held and what was being copied and into whose hands a given volume had gone, and Mir Askari's pale hand would move down the page and never blot it. I had spent a lifetime watching one corner of a room while the deal was struck in another, and I knew an inventory when I saw one taken. They were not valuing the library. You value a thing you mean to keep or sell. They were making the evidence. Every leaf the prince had gathered to read the one truth out of was going down on a list that would one day be read aloud against him by men who had already decided what it proved.

Once I watched them come to the shelf where the closed book out of Benares stood — the one I had carried up the country myself, wrapped in the trash of my own dead faith — and Mir Askari turned to me with his

pleasant face and asked, as a man asks after the weather, where it had been got and by whose hand. I had run contraband past sharper men than he would ever be, and I gave him a dealer's nothing: that I bought where I was sent and did not keep the histories of other men's purchases. He noted something down and smiled and moved along the press. He had not wanted the answer. He had wanted to see what my face did while I declined to give it. So had I wanted that, a thousand times, in a thousand rooms; it is an uncomfortable hour when a man meets the younger, cleaner copy of his own worst skill and stands on the wrong end of it.

I said nothing, which was my whole career in three words, and I will not pretend tonight that it sat easier on me than it did. The prince was in the rooms most days, glad as a boy, showing the finished *Sirr* to anyone who would hold still for it. He had copies made and sent to friends, which is to say he posted the charge against himself to fifty addresses with his compliments. He pressed a fair copy on a Persian noble who took it with both hands and a face I would not have bought a horse from. He had soft hands, the prince, did I ever say — uncalloused; he had never in his life been handed a bill and made to pay it at a counter — and he used them that autumn exactly as a man uses an open purse he has never had to close.

I tried, once. I am not proud of how little it was. I had the *Sirr* between us on the desk and I said, in the sideways manner of my trade, that it was a great book and a dangerous one to be seen owning just now, that I had known collectors ruined by what stood on their shelves when the wind changed, and that there were men in his own rooms whose interest in a volume was not the binding. I meant him to hear all of it. He heard a tradesman fretting over a manuscript, smiled the smile that had charmed his father and half the lords of the empire, and said, "Nothing true ever hurt anyone. Can the second binding have the same tooling as the first?" He did not argue with my warning. He did not register that one had been offered. I had just watched it slide by him close enough to part his hair.

I went back to the gatherings. And here is the thing I have carried longest out of that autumn, longer than the book, and you may set it down as the worst of me. I knew, sitting there, what was coming, because I had spent sixty years learning to know it. A throne was going to fall. And when a

throne falls its library breaks loose — I have told you that is the whole engine of my trade, that I go toward collapse because collapse is supply, that the great buying of my life had all been done in the wreck of houses better than mine. I sat in the prince's beautiful rooms with his finished book on my knee and the part of me I have never been able to put off was already, God forgive it, doing the sum — what such a library would scatter to, and how cheap, and who would have the nerve to be seen buying. I would not let myself finish that last part of the sum, not then. My trade had trained me my whole life to stand exactly here and wait for exactly this. It had only never before pointed me at a man I loved.

There was no one to say it to. That is a small thing beside the rest and I will give it only the one line it has earned: the one person on the earth who would have understood precisely what it cost me to hold the answer to the oldest question of my life in my two hands and price the room it sat in — Marjan had been eleven years in her grave at Julfa, and I had given her no road, and there was no one in the new city or the old or anywhere between the seas to whom I could have said *I am holding it, and I am appraising the house.*

By the turn of the year the book-house was a shell of itself. The water still ran in the channel and the lapis still got ground in the far room because the calligraphers had nowhere else to sell their hands, but the great traffic of it was gone; the corridor that had been a market of clever men was a place you could hear your own feet in. The prince came less, being needed at the fort where his father lay neither dead nor mended, and the men who counted came more. I finished the binding I had promised the *Sirr*. I made it sound and plain and good, the best work my old hands had in them, because the work does not stop and because I did not yet know what else to do with my care.

And then I set it back on the shelf it had been made for, in the prince's own press, and I left it there. It was not mine. I want you to understand that it was not mine that night, nor for two years after — that I closed the press on the greatest secret in the world and walked out into the cold of the new city and left it standing on a doomed man's shelf, finished, beautiful, signed, and waiting, the way a thing waits that does not yet know it is for sale.

Chapter Twenty — The Borrowed Strength

You have been counting on your fingers this last hour, getting to four, and looking unhappy about the number. I have watched you do it three times. Four sons, one throne, and a father who took an unconscionable while about dying — there is the whole sum, and you may put the hand down. You will not make it come out smaller by hiding the thumb.

“A printing-house with four masters and one press,” you told me last night, very pleased, “settles the matter in a week, and the only blood is from the type.” I did not laugh, because you were pleased enough already and I am not in the business of subsidising you. But it was not bad. It was even close to true, which is the only kind of joke worth the breath. The difference is that a press can have a second one bought for it. A throne cannot, and so the brothers did their settling the older way.

I will give you the brood in a sentence, since you are drawing them on your fingers regardless. Dara the eldest, the favourite, at his father’s right hand in the full sun of it. Shuja away in Bengal, who liked his pleasures and would proclaim himself the instant he heard the King was ill. Murad in Gujarat, brave as a bull and about as far-sighted, fond of his drink. And in the Deccan, the high south country, the lean one, Aurangzeb, who prayed where the others spent, and who did the cleverest thing of the four, which was very nearly nothing — he let Murad declare first, and joined him, so that the impiety of rising against a living father went down on the other man’s account, and the profit on his own.

You said, when I first set out their four natures for you, that you would have put your money on the lean one — the one who prayed and waited and let his brother sin first. I told you that you had the instincts of a Genoese banker and the soul of a kite, and you took it for the half of it that was a compliment. You were also right, which I did not tell you, since a boy proven right too early becomes insufferable and I had a whole winter of candles to get through in your company.

But you want the other thing, the thing you have circled all evening and not landed on, so I will spare you the run-up. Why did I not go. You will say it yourself in a moment if I let you: I was a Frank, I owed them nothing,

there was a sea at the foot of the country and ships on it that would carry an old man home.

There was. I am coming to it. Let me tell it in order; the order is the only honest part of me left, and I would not have you think I stayed by accident.

The King did not die. I have told you that, and you did not credit how little it mattered. A great city does not run on what is true; it runs on what is said, and what was said that winter was that the old man was finished, and so the winter behaved as though he were. The year turned to fifty-eight with Dara holding the capital and the seals and the treasury and his father's name to sign beneath — which in that house is the whole of power, until the morning the lords who lent it call it in.

The other three did not wait on the old man's mending. The proclamations went up in Bengal and in Gujarat, and Aurangzeb came north out of the Deccan with Murad beside him to carry the sin of it. When at last the King could be moved they took him down the river to Agra, a hundred miles south to the old red fort — for whoever held the old man held the right to sign in his name, and Dara would no sooner give that up than the treasury — and the household went with him, and the book-house with the household — for the prince's people would not leave the evidence of his heresy standing open on its shelves a hundred miles upstream for his enemies to read at their leisure, he himself, as ever, untroubled by it. So it fell to me to pack it, which is the truest sentence in this night's telling: when the war came, my work did not change. I had spent sixty years putting other men's broken libraries into boxes. Now I put my prince's whole one in, while it was not yet broken, and told myself that was a different thing.

I packed the Sirr myself, in the third box, between boards, wrapped in the rag-paper I would have given a Gospel. And I felt the old reflex turn over once under my hands — what such a book would fetch loose, and to whom, and how little, and which of my rivals would have the nerve to be seen bidding — and I shut the lid on the reflex along with the book, and nailed it down, and did not let it up again. You know what I am. I am only telling you that I knew it too, with my hand on the lid.

The one soul in that house who packed nothing was Sarmad. You remember him — the naked one who laughed as other men breathe. He sat on the book-house steps in the dust of our hurry while forty frightened men carried the prince's damnation past him in crates, and observed that we were all working very hard to spare God the bother of deciding which shelf to burn first. He was the only man in Agra that spring who was not afraid, for the plain reason that he had nothing left for fear to take hold of, and the sound of him laughing on those steps was the most companionable and the most frightening thing in the whole removal.

We went down to Agra on barges in a cold bright week, the boxes roped under oiled cloth and the calligraphers perched on them out of the wind, and I felt every mile of the river in the knees and in the eye that has shut its shop for good — an old man floating south on a raft of salvaged words, as I had floated down so many other waters with so many other dead men's books. Only these were a living man's, and the salvage, on paper at least, had not yet begun.

The first news from the war was good, which is the cruellest way a war can open. Dara's own son had gone east with a Rajput raja and beaten Shuja near Benares, and the court at Agra let out the breath it had been holding since autumn. For a week or two the rooms filled again — the careful men came flowing back, having discovered the wind had shifted and that they were wanted at court after all — and Dara was merrier than I had seen him since the day his book was finished. He took it for a sign. It was a sign, but not of what he thought.

It was into that good fortnight that the other thing arrived. A copy of it came to the book-house itself — to the book-house, mark that, the charge against the library carried in among the crates like one more manuscript come for shelving — and I read it through the Murano lens with my own eyes, because Persian is Persian and I had no need that day of any man to tell me what a page said.

Aurangzeb did not rage. That was the horror of the thing. I had braced for a tyrant's froth and got instead a clerk's clean reasoning, set down in short cold sentences a lawyer would admire. The eldest prince, it said, had forsaken the faith: he kept idolaters at his table and a naked blasphemer at

his ear; he had taken the scriptures of the Hindus and put them into the tongue of the faithful and called them, over his own name and seal, the hidden book of God. A throne raised over Mussulmans could not lawfully pass to an apostate. To take the sword against such a man was therefore no rebellion at all; it was duty.

And he had seen the true danger, which Dara's own friends had not troubled to: that a teaching by which all the faiths are one water under different names dissolves the single line a throne over warring believers must hold — the line between the true road and the false, the saved and the damned — and that a prince who would school his realm to call that line a fiction had unfitted himself to rule it long before any army took the field, whatever blood he carried. Every clause of it was true. I had handled the proof. I had bound the proof. The proof lay in that box with my nails in the lid.

The lean brother in the Deccan understood what the Sirr could do — that a book could pull a throne down — better than any friend Dara had in that house; which was the very reason he meant to climb to the throne up the rope of it. The counting of the autumn, the lists, the clean pale hands that had walked our shelves noting what was held and by whom, and that we had taken for some collector's clerks and not for the lean brother's — all of it had grown up over the winter into this. The dossier had become a charge. The bill had come in.

I carried it to Dara, because the men whose office it was had each found somewhere urgent to be. He read it and was not afraid. He was, God forgive him, very nearly flattered. He said his brother had at least taken the trouble to read the work, which was more than the orthodox of Delhi had ever done, and then he had the Sirr out of its box again to show me a turn of phrase in the preface he was still proud of — undid my packing, in the middle of his own ruin, to admire his own sentence. He had spent that whole spring being generous in the manner that had always been his glory and was now, I could see plainly, only his way of refusing to count: giving copies, giving audiences, giving his trust to men who had measured exactly what it was worth. Among them was a border chieftain whose life he had twice spared in better years, a man named Malik Jiwan, of whom you will hear again, and not to his credit or the prince's.

Now I will tell you about the ship, since I promised you order.

There was a way out for me that spring, and I want you to see that I saw it, because a door you never noticed is not a room you can claim to have chosen. Surat lay at the bottom of the country; a season's hard travel and a Frank could stand on a wharf and find a ship bound west. I owed the Mughal nothing. I had owed Rome everything and paid it the better part of fifty years. I was four-and-seventy, one eye shut for good and the knees not far behind it, with money enough laid by in three cities to die comfortable in any of them. No one on earth would have blamed me, and better than that, no one would have noticed; an old Frank is the easiest thing in the world to misplace, as I had spent my whole life proving.

I packed the library instead of packing myself.

I told myself it was the trade. Collapse is supply; the great buying of my life had every one of it been done in falling houses; a dealer with any sense stays near the shelves when they are coming loose. That was the reason I gave, and it was a good reason, sound as a coin, and it was not the reason.

The reason — which I could not have spoken then and can speak now only because there is no one left to be ashamed in front of but you — was that I had passed sixty years in rooms full of frightened men and clever men and men who counted, and in all that time exactly one of them had taken plain open joy in a book; had been glad of a made thing for no profit but that it was good; had spent without tallying and loved without first arranging his face to do it. And he was about to be killed for precisely that, and I found that I could not be at Surat haggling over a passage while it went out of the world. He was spoiled, your prince. He was vain in his soft-handed way, he would have made a poor emperor and made a worse general, and not one grain of that touched the thing. I stayed for the gladness. It was the only article I ever met in a lifetime of the trade that the trade had no price for, and I would not turn my back on it to catch a boat.

The one person who would have heard me say *I am staying for a man's gladness* and not laughed — or laughed in the right place, which from her was the same as not — had lain a dozen years in the ground at Julfa, and I

had given her, you will remember, no road to find me by. I did not follow that thought down to where it lived. There were carts to load.

Then the good fortnight ended as such things end, all at once and from the side you were not watching. The second army — the one Dara had sent south and west under a Rajput prince to stop Aurangzeb and Murad before they could gain the Agra road — met them at a place called Dharmat and was broken. Broken is the whole of it; I have no battle to give you, only the word coming up the river a few days stale, and the silence it made when it landed. After that there was no court to empty, because the emptying had already happened underneath the good fortnight while no one looked. Men came to the book-house now not to leave manuscripts but to take their own deposited volumes quietly away — withdrawing their books from the heretic's roof the way a careful man draws his money out of a house he has heard a whisper against, smiling, regretting, gone.

After Dharmat there was no more pretending the war could be won at the length of a dispatch. Dara would go to it himself, against the counsel of every man in Agra who had ever stood in a field with swords drawn — go and meet his brother on the plain at a place called Samugarh, a day east of the city, with the whole borrowed strength of the empire melting from one scale to the other while he buckled on his armour.

I helped carry the boxes down to the carts in the last of it, for he would not leave his library behind even to make war; he would take it to the battle, the evidence and the man together, as if the books were a regiment that could be counted on. The third box went up onto a baggage cart with the rest, the greatest secret in the world riding to Samugarh between two boards under the hand of the man who had packed it and could not yet guess he would one day buy it for the price of a frightened porter's silence. But that is tomorrow's telling, and the candle is more honest than I am about the hour.

I will get him to the battle tomorrow. Tonight I have him only as far as the carts — arming, and glad even then, God help him, his soft scholar's hand pushed down into a steel gauntlet that had been forged for a soldier and fit him like a glove borrowed off a better-suited man.

Chapter Twenty-One — The Empty Howdah

There is a heat that is a country of its own, with its own laws and its own citizens, and I was made a citizen of it for the first time at four-and-seventy, on a plain called Samugarh a day's march east of Agra, across the river, on the twenty-ninth day of May in the year fifty-eight. I had thought I knew heat. I had sweated in the customs sheds of Surat and crossed the salt country below Isfahan in a summer that cracked the lips of the camels. This was another thing. This was a furnace with the door left open before the rains come to shut it, a white sky with no sun in it that you could point to, only a glare pressed down flat on everything, and someone my age stood in it and felt his own life going off him in water he could not replace fast enough to matter.

I was where I had spent my whole life being, which was behind. The baggage park lay a good half-mile to the rear of the prince's line, in the lee of nothing, a town of carts and tents and tethered camels and the King's spare elephants swaying at their pickets, and the powder, and the cooks, and the clerks, and the boxes. My boxes — his boxes; I had stopped being able to tell them apart, which was its own kind of confession and I will not dress it up for you tonight. The library had come to the battle in eleven cases roped under oiled cloth, and the third case, the one with the Sirr in it between two boards, stood on a cart with a broken tailboard that I had complained about twice on the road and that no one had mended, because a country going to war does not mend tailboards.

Mir Salih was with me. You remember him — the secretary who had run the prince's book-house since Agra, a dry overworked man with a scholar's squint and ink worked so far into his fingers that no washing would ever fetch it out again. He had not slept. He stood by the broken cart with a list in his hand that there was no longer any use for, and he kept folding it and unfolding it, and once he asked me whether I thought the cases would take dust-damage standing in the open, and I told him no, the oiled cloth would hold, which was true and was also the least of what was coming, and we both knew it, and the small true answer was a comfort to him so I gave it.

The army formed up in the last grey before the glare, and I could make almost nothing of it. You will want me to give you the battle and I cannot;

I have given you false coin in my time but I will not counterfeit a thing I never saw. One eye had shut its shop for good years before, and the other held a folio at arm's length through a ground lens out of Murano or it held nothing, and a mile of dust and spears resolves for such an eye into a long brown smudge that shifts and glitters and tells you nothing. What I had instead of sight was four-and-seventy years of standing at the back of rooms reading the men in them, and a battle, it turns out, you can read off the men around you almost as well as off a face across a table, if you have the trade for it. I am ashamed of how much trade I had for it.

Before he rode out I saw the prince once, and it is the last I saw of him whole. They had brought up his elephant, a great tusked beast painted at the brow, and set on its back the howdah — the canopied chair they fix on an elephant for a king to ride in and, more to the purpose, to be seen riding in, a little gilt room swaying ten feet up where every man on the field can find his prince with his eyes.

Dara came up the ladder of its side in armour that did not suit him, the pearls put away, his soft uncalled hands gloved in steel, and his face under the strain still had the gladness in it that I had crossed two seas and stayed against my own sense to be near. He looked down and saw me by the carts and called out — I will give it to you exactly, because I have kept it — that he was pleased the library had come; that he would not leave his best regiment behind.

He was glad when he said it. He meant the books were soldiers. He went up into the gilt chair believing his own beautiful argument would hold a field, and I stood below in the dust and did not have it in me to tell this man arming for his life that books have never once held a field, that I had spent sixty years watching them lose every one they were ever carried onto. Then the elephant turned and carried him off into the smudge, and he became the one thing my ruined eyes could hold all that long day — a bright small figure in a chair, high up, the gilt catching that flat white light, riding away from me into the brown.

For the morning and into the worst of the heat I watched the figure and the smudge around it and learned nothing, and sweated, and drank water gone hot as broth in the skin, and watched Mir Salih fold his useless list. Sound

reached us that sight would not — the great soft thud of the war elephants meeting, a noise felt in the chest before the ears, and the field guns, and under it all a sea-roar of men that rose and fell and that I could not parse into winning or losing. The sun that was not a sun climbed and the glare came straight down and the spare elephants screamed at their pickets, and I thought, with the small cold corner of me that never stops working, that whoever had drilled his men to fight through this particular hour of the furnace would beat whoever had not, and that the lean praying brother down from the Deccan — Aurangzeb — had drilled his men in exactly this for twenty years, and that ours had not, and I put the thought away because I did not want it.

Then for an hour it seemed to go well. I want to be honest about the hour, because the cruelty of the day lived in it. The roar shifted forward, away from us; the camp behind me let out a breath it had been holding; a wounded man came back through the carts grinning with a hole in him and said the centre was driving them, the prince was driving them, and Mir Salih put his list in his sleeve and looked at me with something opening in his face that I had not seen there in a year, and I, fool, felt it open in myself. The bright figure in the chair was pressing forward. I had it in the lens. It went forward and the smudge gave back before it and for the length of that hour I let myself believe what the prince believed, which is the most expensive hour I have ever spent and I have spent some dear ones.

And then the howdah was empty.

I did not understand it. I want you to sit in the not-understanding with me, because that is where I was. I had the elephant in the lens, the great painted brow, and the little gilt room on its back, and the bright figure that had ridden in it all day was not in it. The elephant still stood. It did not fall, it was not killed, it simply stood there in the brown with its chair empty above it, and I lowered the lens and wiped my eye and raised it and the chair was still empty, and I thought, in my ignorance, that it meant nothing — that he had got down for some reason of his own, to mount a horse, to see better, and would climb back up directly.

He had got down. That much I learned later was true; that one of his own commanders had urged him out of the chair and onto a horse for the last

push, and was afterward found high in the winning brother's favour, and I will say no more of that than a dealer says of a rival's luck.

But here is the thing I did not know standing in the dust, and that the prince in his gladness had never troubled to learn, and that the lean brother had built a war upon: an army in that country does not watch the field. It watches its prince. The elephant is the standard a frightened man can find with his eyes through any dust, and the chair on its back is where the prince is, and when the chair goes empty the men nearest it do not reason that he has stepped down to take a horse. They read it as death. And the reading runs outward through the ranks faster than any horseman can ride to deny it, and it does not matter in the least that it is false, because by the time the truth has its boots on the thing the lie said would happen has already happened.

He stepped down out of sight to fight better, and his army saw an empty chair and decided he was dead, and made it nearly true by deciding it. He was not killed — that was the cruelty of it. He came down off the elephant alive, and the rumour of his death beat him as thoroughly as any blade could have, and left him alive to know it.

The camp behind me changed before I had words for why. There is a sound a great many men make when they begin, all together and unbidden, to think about their own lives, and I had heard the front of it twice before — once in Isfahan, once in Rome — and the back of it never, and the back of it is worse. The roar did not so much stop as come apart. The smudge that had been moving forward came back, all of it, faster than it had gone, and now it was coming at us, and it was no longer a smudge of a battle but a flood of single men, on foot, on horse, throwing things down to run lighter, and the first of them reached the baggage park while I still stood with the lens halfway to my eye like an old fool at a play.

I went for the box. I will tell you that plainly and you may make of it what you make of it. Of eleven cases I went for the one, the third, the broken-tailboard cart, the Sirr between its two boards, and I got both hands on the case and I could not move it. I have good hands still, you have seen them, they can tell you a leaf is sprung before your young eyes have found the page — but a chest of manuscript on a cart is not a leaf, it is the better part

of a hundredweight, and the arms that might once have dragged it clear had given out with the rest of me, and the cart was rolling already because the camel had been cut loose and slapped off by a man wanting it for the road, and the flood was through the lines of tents now and around me and the noise was inside my chest. I got a hand on the case as the cart went and I held on three steps and a man running blind put his shoulder into me without ever seeing me and I went down in the dust between the wheels, and when I got my knees under me the cart and the case and the greatest secret in the world were gone into the brown with everything else.

I had made my living, the whole of it, a working life, in the wreck of other men's houses. I had stood in the cold of a hundred broken libraries with a purse in my coat and bought the salvage off the weeping and the fleeing, and told myself it was a mercy, that the books at least I saved, and gone home richer. I had never once stood in the wreck of my own.

I knelt in the dust at Samugarh and watched the trade I had practiced all my life practiced upon me, the shelves coming loose, the cargo breaking free, the buyers — and there are always buyers — already moving through the wreck with their eyes going over the goods, and I understood at last and entirely what it is to be on the far side of the only thing I ever knew how to do.

The men taking the carts did not know what they had. I watched one of them with the appraiser's reflex that not even that hour could shut off, and saw him heft my third case and judge it light and dull, no plate, no jewel, only paper, and very nearly leave it, and then take it anyway on the chance — and I knew, kneeling there, that the dull light case he had almost left would be carried to Delhi and laid open on a table and read aloud against a man as the proof he had died for, and I could have told him so to his face and he would have made nothing of it, the words as little use to the case as my own arms had been.

Mir Salih I lost in the flood and never found again. He had been at my elbow when the chair went empty and he was not there when I got off my knees, and I do not know to this day whether he ran and lived or fell and did not; the world does not close its accounts for our wanting them closed, and a great many of the people you cross a life with simply walk into a brown

afternoon and do not walk with your knowledge again, and that is not a story, it is only the truth, and I have stopped pretending the two are the same. The last I had of him was the list going into his sleeve in the good hour, when for the space of an hour we had both been allowed to believe it.

They did not trouble with me. I have told you the one wealth of being old and a foreigner and small — that you are the easiest thing in the world to misplace, a knack I had cultivated on purpose across sixty years and never once had cause to bless, and it was the saving of me now. A routed army's fear runs forward, toward the road home; a victor's greed runs toward the carts and the elephants and the painted chests; and an old Frank on his knees in the dust between two wheels is in the path of neither, a thing of no account to the running or the taking, and I knelt there in the middle of the end of an empire and was passed over like a stone.

By evening the noise had gone west with the running and the dust began to settle, and I got myself up on knees that did not want it and stood in a baggage park that had been a town that morning and was now turned out and trampled and stripped, the oiled cloths flung back, the broken cart on its side, the spare elephants gone, and away to the east the prince's own elephant standing yet against the dimming glare with no one to bring it in, the little gilt room empty on its back, while somewhere west on the Agra road and beyond it Dara, the glad man it should have carried, rode into the dark with nothing, having left his best regiment behind after all.

Chapter Twenty-Two — No One's Man

It was three days before I got myself back across the river and inside the walls of Agra, and I made the crossing on foot among people who had made it before me, which is to say among the beaten. The river was low and brown and full of things that should not have been in it, and the ford was a slow press of carts and camels and men carrying what they had snatched, and no one looked at anyone, because to look was to be looked at back, and we had all of us seen by then what looking could cost. I was old and slow and on my own feet, my knees gone to gravel from the fall between the cart-wheels, and that, I have told you, was my whole protection. A man flying for his life steps around an obstacle. He does not stop to rob it.

The city was changing hands as I came into it. You could feel it before you saw a single soldier of the new sort — a city passing under a new master has a different air in the streets, a carefulness, every face arranged to give nothing away to whoever might now be the wrong man to give it to. The victors' men were already in it and around the old King's red fort, and within the week he would be shut inside it with his guard turned to his jailers, and would die in it years off, looking at the tomb he had built for a wife across the river; and his learned son Dara was already gone, somewhere west of us on a road I will come to; and the whole weight of the thing — the treasury, the seals, the right to be obeyed — had already begun its slide north to Delhi, where the lean brother, Aurangzeb, meant to sit and have himself called Emperor before the summer was out. None of that was my affair. What was my affair was that I was, in that city, a marked thing. I was the Frank of the heretic's library. I had built it and kept it and carried it to the battle, and a great many people knew my face, and some of them would be eager, now, to be useful to the men who had won.

You will want to know what I did then, and I am going to tell you, because it is the one stretch of this whole history I have walked around for six years and come at sideways and put down again. I have given you the fire and the trials and the partings. I have not given you this. Hear it plainly, then, since I am too old now to dress it.

I went to the book-house. Of course I went to the book-house; it was the only door in that city my feet knew, and a dealer with the world coming

down around him goes toward the shelves as other men go toward a church. The prince's atelier off its garden court stood with its gate open and its order gone, the calligraphers fled, the lamps cold, and inside it I found men I did not know going along the book-presses with lists, and at a writing-table near the window, supervising them with the air of a new owner walking rooms he has just been given, sat the smooth young scholar I have named to you before — Mir Askari.

Pale, hairless, very well kept, the ink-clean hands folded on the table. He had been the prince's, near the doors, agreeable, last to speak in any room, and he had been writing his fine correspondence the whole time for the side that was now winning. He looked up at me with no surprise at all, as still as a cat that has decided not yet to move.

He did not threaten me. I want you to understand that the whole of it passed without a hard word, because that is the part that has kept me awake. He was glad to see me looking so well, he said, at my age, after such a day. He hoped I was not too knocked about. And then, very kindly, as a man asks after the plans of an old friend, he asked me what I would do with myself now that my work here was finished. Whether I would go home. Whether Rome would not be glad to have its traveller back. And what, he wondered — folding and unfolding nothing, looking at the clean backs of his own hands — what I should find to tell them all, there, of everything I had seen in this country.

There it was, the whole of it, laid in a pleasant question with its blade wrapped. I had spent sixty years in rooms learning to hear what was truly being asked under what was said, and I heard this one to the bottom in the time it took him to reach the end of it. He was not asking my travel plans. He was asking whether the old Frank meant to be a problem — whether I would sit in some Roman library in my dotage and make the dead prince a martyr, write the pretty doomed scholar up for the cardinals to sigh over, turn a beheading into a tale that crossed back over the sea and embarrassed a throne that had every intention of lasting. He wanted to know if I was dangerous. And he was not going to ask it, because he did not need to. He was going to sit with his clean hands and let me answer the question he had not put.

And I answered it. I did not make him wait, and I did not make him ask again, and I have never been able to tell myself that I was tricked or pressed or cornered into it, because I was none of those things. I heard what he wanted and I gave it to him whole, in my own voice, before the silence had even gone uncomfortable.

I told him I was no teller of tales, that I was a tradesman. I told him I had bound books for a cardinal in Rome and books for the prince in Agra and would bind books tomorrow for the Sultan in Stamboul if the Sultan's steward paid on time, and that the insides of them had never once been my business — that I was a Frank and an unbeliever and what stood written between the boards was nothing to me, no more than the cargo on a bill of lading is anything to the clerk who weighs it; I cared for the paper and the hand and the binding and the price, and for the price most of all. I had no opinion of the prince's famous book, I said, that I would not have of a ledger. As for the prince himself — and here I made the smooth young man a small joke, because a joke is the most convincing coin there is — he had been a good customer, and prompt, which was more than I could say for cardinals, and a dealer does not weep over a closed account; he rules a line under it and turns the page.

He liked the joke. That is to say a very small motion happened at the corner of his mouth, the most he spent on anything, and he inclined his clean head, and after that he was no longer interested in me, which was the thing I had bought. He went back to his list. I was waved off like a porter, and I went out through the cold atelier and the open gate a free man, and I was three streets gone before I understood, standing still in the road with people going around me, what I had actually done.

Everything I had told him was true. That is what you must see, and it is the worst of it. Every word would have stood up in any court of the trade: I was a Frank, I was for hire, I had handled every revelation that ever came in a chest and priced them all and kept faith with none. A Christian cannot be hauled up for apostasy — you cannot be charged with walking out of a house you were never inside — and a craftsman who binds what he is paid to bind and believes none of it is no heretic but a workman, and there is nothing in a workman for a court to want.

Had I said the other thing — had I claimed the books, had I told that pale man that I had loved them, that I had carried that one library across two seas because the work in it was good and the man who made it was the only glad soul I met in sixty years — I should have confessed myself the very thing they were going to take the prince's head for, and tied my own name to his on the same page.

So I confessed nothing. I priced my whole life at the going rate for old paper and let it go for that, and the only article in the inventory that was a lie — the only thing I owned that was not for sale and never had been — I left out of the accounting and buried where he could not find it, and I knew I was burying it as I did it. A man can do a shameful thing in ignorance and be half forgiven. I did mine awake.

He let me go because I was his own kind, or had shown him I was, which from his side of the table was the same. Sell a dead prince for the price of a quiet old age and you will not be back to avenge one. He had read me with my own skill and found me safe, and he was right.

"You were his man," Tommaso said.

He said it flat, the way I had taught him to read a false colophon: not angry, only exact. "You told that pale man you were no one's. You were the prince's. You only said you weren't."

I did not dispute it. There was nothing in it to dispute. It was a correct entry, and he had made it himself, from the evidence, without my help, and in forty years I never had a clerk do that. I told him he had it right. He nodded once, the way his father nods over a proof that has come back clean, and did not look pleased, which is how I knew he meant it.

I did not take the ship. There was still a ship — Surat was where it had always been, and a season's road would have put a wharf under my feet and the whole country behind me. I went the other way. I followed the boxes north.

I have given you the reason a hundred times and I will give it you once more because it is true and because by now you will hear the rot in it without my help: a dealer goes where the shelves are breaking loose. The prince's

library was captured, and a captured library does not stay captured; it is sifted, and judged, and what is not wanted is sold, and the great buying of my life had every one of it been done in exactly such weather. So I told myself I was following my trade. And so I was. I was also an old man trailing after the one library he could not bear to lose, as a dog follows the cart that has his master on it, and I will let the two reasons stand side by side and not pretend I can sort them, because I could not sort them then. Behind me, that summer, the lean brother sat down at last in Delhi and had the drums beaten and his name read in the prayers as Emperor, lawfully, over a realm that had decided he was the safer bet. I heard it on the road like weather.

The rest of it came to me as all the far things in my life have come — late, up the roads, in pieces, each piece older than it sounded. The road north itself was a small matter — a week's road, once I finally took it — but I was in no hurry an old man could be made to explain, and the better part of a year went by between the field and the day I was settled small in Delhi. I lingered where the boxes lingered; I went up only when going up was safe for a masterless Frank; and I gave the rest of that year to the patient work of becoming no one — an old foreign bookman of no importance who had once served the wrong household and had been let alone. Across all of it the news of the prince walked in behind me, bent and dusty and weeks stale.

He had gone west, they said, and then further west. To Lahore first, and out of it before his brother's horse came up. Down into the sand country of Sind, where the wells are far apart and a great train of people becomes a small one. A second army gathered to him out of loyalty or calculation and a second field was fought, somewhere below Ajmer, and lost, and after that he had no army to speak of, only a household fleeing with what it could carry toward the passes in the far west and the road over them into Persia, where a fallen prince might at least be a guest instead of a corpse.

And on that road his wife died. Nadira his wife, who had come the whole way with him out of the wreck of everything; the sickness took her in the heat and the bad water, and he had her body, and a man cannot carry his dead over the mountains into exile. So he did the thing that was in him to do. He stripped off a guard of his own dwindling men and sent them back the long way to Lahore to lay her in the ground there with honour, in the

country he was losing, by the shrine of the saint he had loved — sent away, to bury her well, the very swords that were keeping him alive. He was a smaller party after that by exactly the men who might have saved him, which is the kind of arithmetic he never once in his life could be brought to do.

The last of it reached me as the hot months came round again, a year almost to the day from the furnace that had broken him. He had come at the end, sick and all but alone, to the ground of a border chieftain in the hills above the passes — Malik Jiwan, an Afghan, a man whose life the prince had twice begged off the old King's executioner in the good years, when sparing men had cost him nothing and pleased him to do. The chieftain took him in. Then the chieftain took him: laid hands on the man who had twice saved his neck, and his son with him, and gave them up to the new Emperor's officers — for which Malik Jiwan was raised in rank and given a title and a place at the court he had sold his guest to buy. They sell men so, in every country I have worked in, and they are paid in exactly that coin, advancement, and the oldest book in my own faith already had the price set at thirty pieces and a kiss. I had spent my life telling myself the trade was a cleaner thing than the world. It is not. It is the same thing. It only keeps better ledgers.

So they were bringing him north to Delhi in chains while I sat in it, an old Frank safe in a corner of a winning city because he had been wise enough to be no one's man. The bazaars were full and the new reign was settling and somewhere across the town the naked poet Sarmad still sat in the dust and laughed, the one loose thread the new throne had not yet reached out to pull. I took a room over a binder's shop, and shelved my few books, and waited with the whole city for them to bring the prince in.

Chapter Twenty-Three — Among the Weeping

They brought him into the city on a low grey morning that gave no rain, only held the heat down over Delhi like a hand laid over a mouth, and I went out to see it. I want to set that down plainly first, before I tell you what I did and did not do, because it is the part that surprises me still. In sixty years I had taught myself never to walk toward a thing that could hurt me in the walking. It was the whole of my craft, under the other crafts. And that morning I unlearned it in the time it took an old man to find his shoes and get himself down a stair, and went out into the crush to stand where the prince would pass, the one errand in my life I have never been able to price.

I had told you I went to the book-house in Agra as a man goes toward a church. This was the same kind of walk and yet not the same. The door my feet knew that morning had no shelf behind it. It had a man on an elephant, coming up the great bazaar, and I went toward him as toward the last of a thing.

The street was filling before I reached it. Shahjahanabad was built to be walked down in processions — a mile of bazaar laid out by rule, straight as a ruled line, a water-channel running its length and the shopfronts standing back in arcades to give a crowd somewhere to stand — and the city had come out into it to the last child. I have stood in crowds on three continents and I knew the feel of this one before I had read a single face in it. It was not a holiday crowd and it was not a mob. It had come to mourn, and it had come in the half-belief that if enough of them stood in the road the road might refuse to carry what was coming up it. They were wrong about that. Roads carry what they are given.

I worked myself in along the arcade on the shaded side, where the shopfronts were shuttered, and found a place against a pillar with a gap of light over the heads in front of me. An old foreigner, bent, far gone in one eye — I have told you what I am, a thing the running and the taking both step around, and what had nearly cost me my life on the field at Samugarh served me here as it had served me there. A crowd closes over a small bent man and forgets him. I meant to be forgotten. I had a reason for it that I will come to, and you will not think the better of me for it.

Then the head of it came up the bazaar, and the noise the crowd had been making — that low water-sound a great many people make when they are waiting and afraid — went out of it all at once, the whole mile of it, as if a door had been shut on it.

I had the lens up. I want you to understand that I watched the worst hour of it through a disc of Murano glass on a cord, the same glass through which I had held a bright gilt chair on an elephant's back all the long day the empire broke, because my own eye would give me no more than a smear past ten feet. So I had him sharp and small in the round of the lens while the men around me had him whole and dim, and I am not sure to this day which of us had the better of it.

They had put him on an elephant. That was the cruelty done with care, and I read it as I would read a binding, because reading is the only sense I was left with that morning that still worked. At Samugarh he had ridden out painted and gilt, a great tusked beast with the brow worked in colour and a little roofed chair ten feet up where every soldier on the field could find his prince and take heart. They had remembered that. They had set him this time on a small, scabbed, work-worn she-elephant, a beast you would hire to drag rubble out of a fallen house, her hide grey and cracked and a sore weeping at one ear, and no chair on her at all, only a rough wooden seat lashed on with rope. A stranger to the country would have seen only a prisoner on an old elephant. I had been in the country long enough to read the sentence written in the choice of the animal, and the sentence was passed before ever a word of law was read over him: *look what we have made of your prince; he is not worth a clean beast.*

He sat the rough seat in a coat I would not have used to wrap a poor book. Coarse dark stuff, road-filthy, torn at one shoulder — and I knew cloth, I had handled the silks he used to wear, I had bound books at a table where his sleeve lay across the page in pale figured silk with the pearls sewn at the cuff, and the man inside that filthy coat was the same man, and the two facts would not sit together in my head, and I made them sit, because that was what the morning was for. His hands were bare. They had been the softest hands I ever saw on a grown man, uncalledoused, a scholar's hands that had never pulled a rope or held a blade till the year they made him hold

one — and now they lay in his lap loose and filthy and still, and I could not tell from where I stood whether they were bound. I think they were not. I think by then there was no need.

The gladness was gone. I have given you that gladness a dozen times across these evenings because it was the truth of Dara and the thing I crossed two seas to be near — a brightness in the face that the doors-watched whispering and the informers and the slow closing-in had never put out. It was out now. What sat on the rough seat was grey and emptied and looking at nothing, an old man's face on a man not yet forty-five, and behind him on the same beast sat his boy, his son, a child of fourteen or so with his father's fine bones in him and a face gone stiff with the work of not weeping, and behind the boy stood a soldier with a drawn sword held up bare against the grey sky, so that no one in all that mile of grief should mistake what this was.

And the city wept.

I had stood once in a crowd that did not weep. Long ago, in Rome, in a cold February, in a square I have told you I will not describe, I stood among people watching a man go to the fire, and I looked into that crowd for the fear in it and found none — only a congregation, calm, certain, attending on a thing well done. I have carried the missing fear of that morning for sixty years.

Here was its opposite, and the opposite undid me worse. Here was a whole city's grief spent in the open, freely, on a man it had become safe to love now that loving him cost the lovers nothing but tears. Old men wept. Women held up children to see and wept over their heads. A shopkeeper near me had his fists against his own mouth and the water running over them. It went up the whole length of the bazaar ahead of the beast and rolled back down it, a sound I had never heard a city make.

Whoever had sent a beaten prince up the bazaar on a rubbish-hauler's elephant meant the city to see him brought low and be cured of loving him; instead it broke its heart over him in the open, and at the edges of the grief the new order's men shifted and watched and understood that the morning had slipped the leash they had cut for it. And I stood in the middle of it dry-

eyed, and kept my face shut, and that is the thing I came out that morning to do and did.

Here is the reason, since I am too old to leave it wrapped. More than a year before, in a captured book-house in Agra, I had bought my life from a smooth man by swearing that none of it had ever been mine — that I was a Frank for hire, that the prince was a closed account, that I wept over no one's books and least of all his. I had priced my whole life at the going rate for old paper to be let walk free. And a man does not unsay such a thing by standing in a public road a year and more later with the tears running down into his beard for the very prince he has sworn was nothing to him.

There were eyes in that crowd that were not grieving. I had marked two of them already, dry men standing easy at the edge of the wet, looking not at the elephant but at the faces turned up toward it, learning the city's heart so that the city's heart could be entered against it later. To weep where they could see me was to write my own name onto the page under his.

So I did not weep. I had sworn I did not love him; the only way left to keep faith with that lie was to stand in the one place on earth where loving him was safe, and there refuse him even a wet face. I gave the dying man nothing. I did it awake, and knowing, and I have never found the bottom of it.

Worse than that. The lens cut both ways. Through it I could see him; without it he could see nothing of me but a blur against a pillar, one bent grey nothing among ten thousand. I could have stood out into the light. I could have put myself where the round of the glass would have shown him, in all that strange country and all that grief, one known face — the Frank who had crossed the world to be near his books, the one man in the road who had been at his table — and let him find it, and take from it whatever a man takes who is being carried to his death and sees, for the space of a breath, that he is not entirely among strangers. It would have cost me everything and him almost nothing, and it might have been a kindness, and I did not do it. I stood where he could not find me on purpose. I had spent a lifetime making myself the easiest thing in a room to overlook, and that morning I turned the trick, for the first time, against a man I loved, so that he should go up the road and not know I had come. Whether his eyes

searched the crowd for any face at all I never learned, and I have had six years to not learn it.

The beast came on, level with my pillar, and went past, slow, the rope creaking on the rough seat, the sore at her ear black with flies, and I held him in the glass the whole length of it and let him go out of it at the far edge and did not move, and that was the last I had of him alive but for the once more I will tell you of in its place.

It was as the tail of the thing passed — the soldiers, the rabble of the curious that follows any cruelty hoping for more — that a hand took my sleeve, and I knew the smell before I had turned, dust and old sweat and sun-burnt skin, and it was the naked man.

Sarmad — the naked holy fool of these lanes, who said at noon in the open what the prince said only behind watched doors of an evening. I had told you he frightened me more than any inquisitor, because he had thrown away the one tool I had survived a lifetime by holding: discretion, the saved half of the sentence. He had no saved half. He said all of it, always, to anyone.

He was not laughing now. That was the whole of what was wrong, and it went through me colder than weeping. I had never seen him when he was not laughing. He stood holding my sleeve and watched the grey beast go up toward the fort with his ruined face perfectly still, and then he turned the stillness on me, and he had seen it, of course — he saw everything, it was his madness and his gift — he had seen the one dry face in the road and the cause of its dryness both, in the time it takes other men to see nothing.

“You came,” he said. “I thought you would. And you have made yourself small again.” He looked me over, the pillar I had set my back to, the shadow I stood in. “The most honest man in this city, hiding in the dark so the prince won’t catch him being sorry.” There was no cruelty in it. He said it as a man reports the weather. “They cannot frighten me, Roman, because there is nothing left of me to take hold of. They will never be done frightening you. You have kept too much.”

Up the road a dry man at the edge of the crowd had turned and was watching us — watching Sarmad, the bare loud impossible fact of him, and

his hand had gone inside his coat and come out with a folded paper and a reed, and he was writing, there in the street, a thing noted in a corner against a day, the same small motion I had watched scribes make over the prince's laughter years before and would watch made over men till I died. The naked man was being entered into a book. He knew it. He had always known it. He turned his face up the bazaar again toward where the beast had gone and said, not to me now, to the air, to the whole weeping mile of it, that they might carry the prince up to the fort and do their law on him, but a thing once said aloud in the open did not go back into the mouth that said it, and no executioner in any country had yet learned how to behead a sentence.

And I left him. That is the plain account of it. The marked man held my sleeve and said true things in a dangerous voice in a public road, and I took my sleeve back out of his hand and made my way out along the arcade and left him standing there to be written down, because to stand beside Sarmad one breath longer was to be written down on the same page, and I had spent a year and the whole of my self-respect making certain I would not be. He had thrown his life into the open road. I had buried mine where no court could reach it. We were the two ends of the one question, the loud and the silent, and I walked away from the loud end and did not look back at it, and I heard him begin, behind me, at last, to laugh again.

I went back up the lane against the grief still pouring down it, and up the dark stair over the binder's shop to the room I had taken, and sat down among the few books I had left in the world while the heat came up off the street and the light failed slowly behind the cloud. In all the years I had stood in the wreck of other men's houses I had never once stood in a great house coming down and not had my purse out. It is the one trade I know. And I had stood the whole morning in the ruin of the only house I ever loved and bought nothing, because there was nothing in it for sale and nothing in me left to spend, and my hands, when I looked at them, were empty, and steady, and clean. Out in the city they were weeping still for the man they were carrying to the red fort. I sat in the dark and kept faith with my lie and did not weep, and was as safe as a stone in a wall, and listened to a hundred thousand strangers grieve the thing I would not let myself grieve, until there was no more light.

Chapter Twenty-Four — For Almost Nothing

They came for me the next day, which I had half looked for and wholly dreaded, and the dread was the honestest of the two, because under the looking-for there was a vanity I am ashamed of even now — old and emptied and lying low over a binder's shop, and still some part of me pleased to be thought worth the sending. An officer of the new sort, with a list. He did not have my name; he had my trade and my face, and between them that was enough. The Frank who had built the library was wanted up at the fort, where the library now was, to say what stood in it. I went without being made to. There was a way to refuse — the knees, the age, the eye — and the refusing would have been a thing noticed, and a thing noticed about a masterless Frank under a new and watchful reign is a thing written down; I had given a year to making certain nothing about me was worth the ink. So I took my stick and my lens on its cord and climbed up through the grieving streets to help them read a dead man's shelves against him, and told myself the whole way that to say what a book is, is only to say what a book is.

I had better tell you plainly that the thing was already decided. I knew it before I reached the gate. You do not bring a beaten brother a thousand miles in chains and parade him on a rubbish-elephant before a weeping city in order to find out, at the end of it, whether he is guilty. The verdict had been settled in the Deccan years before, in a praying tent, by one who had long ago decided what his brother was; everything since — the field, the flight, the betrayal, the chains, and now the books laid out on tables — was not the making of a judgment but the dressing of one. They did not need me. That is the part I have never been able to set down comfortably. I was not summoned because the case turned on my eye. I was summoned because the form of the thing wanted someone able to say *this is a Persian rendering of the Hindus' scripture, in the prince's own commission, in such-and-such a hand*, and I was the nearest such man, and the form is everything to a throne that means to last. They had their reasons already. They wanted only the labels.

The library had come up to the fort ahead of me, all of it — the eleven cases that had gone out to Samugarh in the baggage and had not come home to anyone who loved them, and the prince among them now as the twelfth

case, brought the same road. They had it in a long stone room off a court, cool, with the heat held out by the thickness of the walls, and the crates broken open along trestle tables, and men I did not know going down the length of them with reeds and paper, lifting out volumes, turning them, setting them in heaps. I had spent sixty years in rooms like that one. I had made my living in them. The only strangeness was that this time the collection on the tables was not a dead bishop's or a fallen merchant's; it was the one I had carried across two seas and judged and shelved and packed with my own hands, and the heaps they were sorting it into were not *to keep* and *to sell* but *to read out* and *to burn*.

There is a thing I taught you in the first hour, over the wine — that a book without an entry does not exist, that we do not describe a library, we make it. I had spent my whole life making libraries exist by writing them down. I stood in that cool room and watched men make a library *damn* a man by reading it out, and I understood, slow, as an old fact turns over and shows you its other face, that the two crafts are the one craft. A man's shelves are his deposition. What he kept is the confession of what he thought worth keeping. They were not trying him on anything he had done. They were trying him on what he had loved enough to bind, and they had it all there on the tables in his own commissions, in his own hand's marginalia, with his seal on the flyleaves — the Hindus at his table, the naked blasphemer at his ear, the idolaters' book carried over into the faithful's tongue and called, over his own seal, the hidden thing under the Word. A throne does not need a sword to behead a man who has signed all that. It needs only a clerk who can read.

And they wanted me for the reading. Not the reading-aloud in the hall — that was for graver men, in beards, who knew the Arabic; I was sent the menial half, the part the beards were too lofty to be sure of: the provenance, the hand, the where-it-came-from and the what-it-was. An officer would lift a volume and hold it out and I would say what it was, and a clerk would write down what I said, and the saying placed it in the right heap.

I did it. I want you to hear that plainly. I stood at the table and I named the prince's books one after another in my flat trade voice, and each thing I named went onto the pile that was evidence, and not one word of it altered

by a grain what was going to be done to him, because that was already done; and I named them anyway, correctly, in good order, as I would have named them for a buyer, because to have fumbled, to have suddenly grown ignorant of a trade I had practised in front of half of them for years, would have been the one performance that could have undone me.

So I gave them clean labels for the killing they had already decided on, and took no risk, and saved my skin a second time with the same coin I had spent in the captured book-house a year before — accuracy, indifference, the workman's empty face. I have told you I did the Agra thing awake. I did this one awake as well, and it was the smaller act and sits the heavier, because in Agra I at least bought something with my lie — my life, sworn clear of the prince. Here I gave the truth away for nothing. They would have killed him just as dead if I had never climbed the stair.

It was while I was at it — the great Frankish Bible in my hand, the engraved polyglot folio I had carried unsold for years and then sold him myself, the door that had let me into his rooms in the first place, a salt-bloom along one board from its two sea-crossings — that the room changed in a breath, the men along the tables going still and lower at once, like a field of barley when the wind drops out of it, and I turned, and Aurangzeb had come in to see his brother's books.

I will give him to you as I saw him, because I had heard of him for years as a voice and a charge and a distant cold fact, and now here he was in a body, and the body was the argument. Lean — not starved, but pared, a man with nothing on him that did not work. Pale, the desert pallor of twenty years in tents, of prayer made out under the open sun. Dressed in plain white, no jewel, no thread of colour, in a court that had drowned his brother in pearls; and on his forehead the dark callus of forty years' prostration, head to the ground five times a day, the one mark he permitted himself, and it was worth more than all Dara's pearls, and he knew it, and so did the room. He did not stride and he did not glower. He came down the tables slowly, looking at the heaps, and his voice when it came was low and exact and spent no more breath than the words required, and that economy was the most frightening thing about him, because it is the voice of a power that has never once needed to raise itself to be obeyed.

He stopped across the table from me. He had the *Sirr* in his hands — the great one, the hidden book, the brown morocco with the envelope flap, the spine already going soft, the smoke-fine hand inside it; the very copy I had packed in the third case and gone down between the cart-wheels failing to save. A looter had judged it light and dull and taken it on a chance, and the chance had carried it here, to these hands, open on this table. He turned a few leaves with one finger, unhurried, and could read perfectly well what was in it. Then he looked up and asked me, in Persian, plainly, what such a book was worth.

I answered him as I would have answered any man across a table with a book in his hands. I told him the hand was a court nasta'liq of the first quality, that the paper was burnished and heavy and would outlast every man in the room, that a clean copy in a sound binding of a famous work in a known hand had a price, and I named one — a dealer's figure, sound, the figure I would have asked a buyer in Isfahan. I gave him the book as goods. It was the only language I had that was safe, and I spoke it well, and I watched my own steady voice lay the prince's masterwork on the table between us as a quantity of morocco and rag-paper and skilled labour, so much the leaf.

He let me finish. Then he set his hand flat on the open page, not to turn it, to stop it, and he said — evenly, to me, but truly to the book — that I had told him what it cost and not what it was; that I had appraised the box and not the thing in the box; that the thing in the box said all the waters were one water under their different names, and that a throne set over men who were cutting each other's throats over which name was the true one could not let that be said and still be a throne. He did not say it as a threat and he did not say it as a lament. He said it as a man states a sum he has checked. *This teaches that the line does not exist. I am the line.* And he was right. That is the whole horror of him and I will not soften it for you: he understood the book on the table better than the gentle prince who had made it, better than the friends who had loved the prince for making it, better than I who had carried it across the world; he was the only man in the long history of that book who had measured exactly what it weighed, and his measure was the executioner's.

I said nothing. There was nothing a tradesman could say to it, and to have answered as anything other than a tradesman, in that room, with that callus across the table from me, would have been to lay my own head beside the book. So I let it stand. He took his hand off the page and went on down the tables, and did not look at me again, having no more use for me than for the trestle the books lay on, and I stood and breathed and was, once more, furniture that happened to know paper.

I saw the prince once more after that. I have kept it for its place, as I promised you I would.

It was late in the day, the labelling near done, and there was a stir in the court outside the long room, and through the open door I saw them bring him across it under guard, out from wherever they had held him for the form of the trial, toward wherever they would keep him for the end of it. He came out past the very room where his library lay opened on the tables, the books and the man carried along the one short stretch of stone together for the last time, and then parted forever at the far door.

My hand had the glass up before my mind had agreed to it. It is the only sight my ruined eyes keep at any distance, and through the little disc I held him clear and no bigger than my thumb, sharper than anything else in the day, while the men jostling at my shoulders saw a smear of grey cross the court — a thin shape in soiled cloth, walking with care, as the very sick walk, his hands loose; and the gladness that I crossed two seas to be near, that I have spent these evenings trying to give you because it was the truth of him, was simply not in the face anymore. There was nothing in the face.

He went across the bright court and in at the dark door and was gone, and whether his eyes crossed the crowd of us in the long room's mouth, whether they found for half a breath the one old Frank who had stood at his table for years and now stood among the men labelling his books for the fire — that I never learned, and have had these six years in which to not learn it, and I had the lens up the whole time precisely so that I might see him and he might not see me, which was the last use I ever made of my trade, and the worst.

They did it the next night, in the dark, in a closed place, with no city looking on — having learned from the weeping in the bazaar that this prince was safer killed out of sight. I was not there; no one who loved him was there; that was the point of the dark. It reached me the next morning sidelong and already cold, as the great things always had, a thing said in the lane below the window before I had got my shoes on. And one more thing reached me with it, and I give it to you once and will not turn it over: they sent the head down the river to Agra, to the old fallen King shut in his fort there, so that the father might be made to look at what the throne had made of the son. Then I will say no more of it. Books are loud about such things and I have grown quiet about them; the older I get the less I can bear to describe a death, and the more exactly I remember the smell of the room I heard it in.

I had thought, sitting with it that morning, that I was finished in that city, that there was nothing left in it for me but the long road home and the sea. I was wrong, because I was still a dealer, and the trade had one more thing to teach me about myself before it let me go.

For a captured library does not stay captured. Once it had done its work in the trial it was only an embarrassment — paper that had killed a prince, that no one in Delhi could be seen to own and no one wished to keep about the new court. So it came loose, the way collapse always shakes books loose, into the hands of under-officers and porters and the small men who clear a great house after the great are done with it; and within a day it was to be had cheaper than I have ever in my life seen good books to be had, because the price of owning any leaf of it was that a man might be thought to have agreed with what it said, and a man had just lost his head for agreeing with what it said. Every dealer's instinct in that city pulled the other way. They stepped around it as you step around a thing in the road that might be plague.

And I, who had stepped around such things my whole life and made my fortune in the stepping, did not step around this one. I found the porter who had the clearing of that room — a frightened man, glad to be rid of poison for coin, gladder still to be told nothing of mine would ever be heard of again — and I bought the hidden book off him for almost nothing, a few coins for the leaves and a few more for his silence, and I did it in my flattest voice, as

a small dull transaction in damaged stock, as I have bought a thousand lots off frightened men in falling houses; and that is exactly how I have to tell it to you, flat, as a purchase, because if I let it be anything else it would break in my hands even now. Sixty years I had gone into the wreck of other men's lives with my purse out. I had stood in the wreck of the only thing I ever loved with my purse shut, in the bazaar, and bought nothing. And here, at the very end, over a porter's barrow, the purse came out — once, for this — and I carried the prince's hidden book away under my arm wrapped in a cloth, the one salvage of my whole career that I have never been able to enter in any ledger as a thing I was glad to have got cheap.

I carried it back down through the city to the room over the binder's shop and up the dark stair, and set it on the table, and lit nothing, and sat with it while the heat came up off the street and the light went. This is the book, Tommaso. This is the one you asked me about, that first evening, the uncatalogued one in the book-cupboard of Syriac liturgies — I carried it up a stair like this one, once, a long time ago, in another country, and have been carrying it ever since.

I did one thing to it that night, with a thin blade, by feel, in the dark, before I could let myself think better of it. On the flyleaf, low in the corner, the prince had set his seal, his small private mark of ownership, the *this is mine* a great collector presses into the things he loves. I worked it loose from the paper. A name can be looked for, and a book that crossed a frontier with a beheaded apostate's seal in it could hang the man who carried it, and so the dealer in me lifted the seal away clean and left only the pale scraped circle you may still find there if you look, no bigger than a giulio. That was the trade's reason and it was a true reason. But I did not throw the seal in the brazier, which the trade's reason would have had me do. I wrapped it in a scrap of oiled cloth, the same oiled cloth I would wrap a thing in to carry it dry across a sea, and I kept it. I have kept it. It is the one article I ever took out of a falling house that I never once meant to sell, and the trade has no entry for such a thing, and neither, for sixty years, had I.

Chapter Twenty-Five — The Uncatalogued Book

The wine that last evening was a Greco the cardinal had laid down before ever I came to Rome, and Tommaso fetched it up the three flights from a cellar he had no business being able to find, and set it by my right hand, and poured himself a thumb's width first to taste it for me, which was a printer's son's notion of how a great house is run. He had worked out by then that his Eminence three floors beneath us, who had not climbed to his own library in two years and took his soup at four and was asleep by six, would not miss what the two of us drank above his head; and the reckoning was sound, and I let him keep the pleasure of it. He weighed the bottle in his cracked hands when he had done, holding it up to the brazier to read the level off it, and said it was a hard thing that a man could be deaf to a whole staircase and not to one cellar door. I did not laugh. I had not laughed at his jokes in a whole winter of evenings, on a principle — that a boy's dry remark is a fragile article and spoils if you snatch at it — and I had let every one of them stand, and he knew the difference, and that was the joke we two truly held between us.

The telling was done. I had carried him the whole way from a cold cell under the Vatican wall to a porter's barrow in a broken Delhi and up a dark stair to a table no broader than this one, and there was nothing left of the sixty years to give him but the last small act, the one I had climbed up into that library every working morning for four years on purpose to avoid. The book lay on the table between us where I had set it when I began that night: brown morocco gone soft as a glove along the spine, the envelope flap folded over the fore-edge in the eastern manner, the Persian hand inside it fine as smoke off a snuffed wick, and a brown tide-line risen through the foot of the last third of the leaves where the sea had got at them on the long road home. I had carried it out of one falling house and across two seas to set it on the shelf of another. When I came up the stair again in sixty-one, salt in the bindings, Ottavio was two years buried and his books were Lanfranchi's, and Lanfranchi was glad of a man who knew what they were. In the years since the book reached this room I had not once written it down.

You will remember the first law I taught you, that first evening, over a worse wine than this — that a book without an entry does not exist; that we do not describe a library, we make it. I had made a whole library exist by that law: three thousand volumes and better, sixty years of other men's broken houses written into being on Lanfranchi's shelves. This one I had kept from being. Six years I had owned it and not entered it, four of them at the very catalogue the cardinal pays me to make — a labour I proposed myself, and promised him in three — walking the length of the book-cupboards every morning with my reed and my paper, coming to the cupboard of Syriac liturgies where it stood thirty-first in a row the catalogue swears is thirty, and walking on, and entering the next thing, and the next. To write the entry was to say where the book had come from. To say where it had come from was to say that I had been there. That was the whole of the delay, and you had the wit, all those evenings, not to ask me why the count was wrong.

"Give me the pen," I told him. He had been at fair copies all that month at the small desk under the north window, his hand a clean chancery thing his father hires out at twice what the boy ever sees, and he brought the pen and the inkhorn over to my stool and stood there holding them and did not at once let go of the pen when I took hold of it. I will not make a sermon of that. He let it go, and I dipped it, and I had to bring the page up close under the right eye to find the lines, the left having closed its shop years back and the right grown stingy of anything held past a hand's breadth, and I wrote in the dealer's hand I have set down ten thousand entries in, slow now, the letters straggling, while he stood at my shoulder and watched a thing be made to exist.

Item, I wrote. A volume in the Persian tongue, being the SIRR-i-Akbar, which a man may English as The Greatest Secret: the hidden scriptures of the Hindus carried over into Persian at the charge and in the household of the prince Dara Shikoh, who set his own preface before them, naming them the concealed book that God is said to keep hidden, and arguing therein that the truth lying under all the warring revelations is one water poured out into many jars. Bought out of the breaking-up of the prince's own library at Delhi, in the year 1659, for a few coppers for the leaves and a few more for a frightened man's silence; no other dealer in that city being willing to be seen to hold it, the prince having that same month lost his head for the holding of it.

Every other entry in that catalogue gives a price and gives no reason, because a price has no need of a reason; the reason is the market, and the market is only every man's fear and appetite added up together and divided out, and a dealer who explains his prices is a dealer with a bad one to hide. I taught you that too: that a misprice is audible by its missing reasons. This was the one line in sixty years where I wrote the reason in. The same act had made the book worth almost nothing and the man worth killing, and I set the two facts down side by side in the one sentence, in the only tongue I have ever wholly trusted — what a thing costs, and why — because it was the nearest I could come, with a reed in my hand, to saying what I had crossed the world to watch and had not lifted a finger to prevent. Then I went up to the head of the cupboard and struck out *thirty* and wrote *thirty-one*, so that the shelf and the book should agree at last, and the thing that had not existed existed.

And here is the strange part, which I have turned over every evening since and will hand you once. I had carried that book three thousand miles and six years believing I knew what was in it — a clean copy of a famous work, a prince's costly folly, goods I could price in my sleep. It was only in the writing of the entry, in setting down in my own poor words the thing the prince had argued in his — that the water under all the jars is one — that I heard, sixty years late, what a small gaunt man had asked me in a cell the week before they burned him: what it was they thought they were burning, and who had told them they might reach so high. I was seventeen. I thought he had set me a riddle about the stars. I went up onto the roof the night of the fire and tried to number them for him, because he had told me to, and they were all of them there, every one, and I came down again no wiser.

They were always all there. That was never the hard part. The stars do not care who looks at them, and the truth does not care who says it; both lie about in the open for any man to stoop and pick up, and a thing that is everywhere and free of charge has no price at all.

What has a price is the saying of it where a throne can hear. I spent sixty years learning the exact figure. A book doubles in worth the morning Rome's Index of forbidden books condemns it; a philosophy hissed at in Isfahan fetches triple in Rome; a whole library breaks loose and floods the

stalls the week its owner falls — and every one of those numbers is fear, somebody's fear, written out as a sum.

I made my fortune reading the numbers and never once let myself read what they spelled, which was the cell's own answer, plain as a tide-line up a page: the truth was never the thing in danger. The men who say it are. And no throne I have stood near in all that time — not the one that filed Bruno's sentence and went calmly home to its supper, not Aurangzeb's, in plain white, that lifted the prince's book out of my own hands and weighed it more exactly than I could — ever doubted, for the space of a single breath, that it held the right to reach up and put out the man for the saying.

Mulla Sadra, a philosopher I bought once on the Qom road, told me to my face that I did not believe a syllable of what I handled, and he was right, and went on being right for forty years after. I think that night, with the wet ink drying on the prince's book, I had come at last to believe a syllable of it. Not the whole. A syllable. It was enough to make the rest of the evening hard.

And since I promised you the tally on Vautier, and we are at the end of the candle, here it is. I won every round we ever played. I had the better eye at Zante and at Isfahan and at every table between, and the ledgers will say so. But the better eye is the thing that let me see what the prince's book was, and carry it, and stand in that long room at Delhi knowing exactly what they were sorting for the fire. Vautier never once in his life knew what he held, and so nothing he held could ever hurt him. He died in his bed at Marseille, fat and honoured, and his cabinet of forged Greek went to a buyer who could not tell either. *We sell to the blind*, he told me once. He never needed curing; the blindness kept him. Sadra called me the safe hand because the closed one. Vautier was safer still: his hand was closed on nothing at all. I won the rounds. Vautier won the life.

But an entry is a small box to bury a life in, and the life keeps working its way back out of the lid. I had settled the question. I had settled nothing else. A ledger line will hold a book — that is the entire use of a ledger line — and it will not hold a man kneeling in a square with two fingers' width of linen between his teeth, nor Dara's head sent down the river to Agra, to his father, the old fallen King shut in his fort there, nor the thing I did not enter that night and did not show the boy and will not show you: a small

article wrapped in a scrap of oiled cloth, kept where I keep it, that has no price for the reason that it was never once for sale, the one thing I ever lifted out of a falling house meaning never in this world to let it go. The book stands on the shelf now for any man to find. The other stays where it lies. A cataloguer to the very rind of me, and at the end of it I keep two things off every ledger I own: that scrap of oiled cloth, and a name.

He was quiet a while. The tramontana had found the chimney and the near brazier ducked and steadied itself. He had laid the pen down square across the inkhorn, as a boy does who has been taught to put his tools away, and when he asked it at last he asked it low, looking at the book and not at me — the one question in all the long telling that he had to gather himself to put — whose the name was, and whether it was written anywhere in the world at all.

She kept books, I told him. That was her trade as paper was mine. She kept the accounts of an Armenian house in the suburb over the river at Isfahan, in New Julfa, that the Shah had raised by emptying her birthplace and marching its people a thousand miles to a spot he found convenient — so that she had learned before she was five years old the thing it has taken me sixty to get by heart: that a throne will shift a whole people as I shift a chest of books, for reasons of its own and none of theirs. Her hands were stained to the wrist with walnut ink. She copied the manuscripts that came through the house, in a hand finer than mine, and she could find a forgery I had passed for sound, and tell me in the same breath the figure I ought to have asked and the figure I would in fact be paid, which are two different figures, and the whole of the trade lives in the gap between them. I have entered into this catalogue, with their full and honest provenance, books I cared for a great deal less than I cared for the corrections she made down the margins of my accounts.

When I went east the last time, in the year forty-one, to the prince and his books, she did not ask me to stay. She was the one soul in my life with the clear sight to know that the asking would have held me, and the harder sight not to ask — she read me the way she read an account, all the way down to the foot of it, and saw that if I meant to go I had better be let go clean, and she let me. I told myself for years that this was her coldness. It

was not her coldness. It was the most exact reading anyone ever gave me, and it was a kind of mercy, and I have forgiven it in neither her nor myself to this day.

And I never wrote to her. That is the thing, when all the rest is told. I, who can run a Gospel-book back through four owners and three centuries by the wear on its corners, sent her not one line through any factory or counting-house between Surat and Aleppo, so that when she died — of a sickness, in the autumn of forty-six, and was buried by her own church in Julfa — the news of it could not find me, and hunted me down the years, and ran me to ground in the Jesuit house at Surat in fifty-one, five years stale: a letter in her own hand that she had written and not sent, and that her people sent on after her when at last they learned where in the world I had got to.

Five years. I have moved cargoes over that same water in eleven months. The one consignment I ever ordered to come slow was the news of her, and I ordered it slow by never writing, and I did it as I have done the worst things of my life, which is to say wide awake.

There is no entry for her, I told him, and there never will be. Not in my catalogue and not in any other. Her name is on a stone in Julfa I have never seen and will not go to see, and in the books of a house that has changed hands twice over by now, and in the one letter, and nowhere else in all the made world — a scatter of marks, not one of them an entry. By the law I taught you on the first evening, the law I have lived sixty years inside of, she does not exist; a thing without its entry does not exist; and the law is a true law, and it is the cruelest thing I know, and I have spent my whole life its faithful servant.

You witnessed this, I said. You handed me the pen and you stood by while I set down where the book had come from and what it cost and why, and that has made you a man who knows where a beheaded heretic's book sits on a Roman cardinal's shelf, and knows the name of the hand that put it there. That is a piece of knowledge with an edge on it. I have passed it to you across this table as carelessly as a doomed man in a cell once passed the like of it to me — because you had a face that wanted to know, and I was old, and the wine was good enough and the room was warm, and there was no one else in it to take the thing from my hands.

The tramontana worked at the chimney. He looked at the book, and then he did at last look up at me, and he asked the last of it the only way he could bring himself to ask — not the book now, not the trade, but the woman with the inked hands at the ledgers in the city over the river. Was there nothing of her left in the world, then. Nothing at all.

There was the stone I would not go to, and the letter I would not show him, and there was this. I gave him the one entry I have ever made that went into no book at all — not into Lanfranchi's catalogue, where it would have been safe and findable and false to everything I had just told him, but into the warm air over a borrowed table and the ear of a printer's son, which is the frailest shelf in the world and the only one I would trust her to. By my own law it does not count. A thing that is said and not written down does not exist. I have kept faith with that law for sixty years, and I keep faith with it still, and it is a lie, and I told it him anyway, because it was also true, both at once, as the worst things always are.

I said her name to the boy.

Marjan.